

ACRC KOREA

Annual Report 2024



Anti-Corruption &
Civil Rights Commission

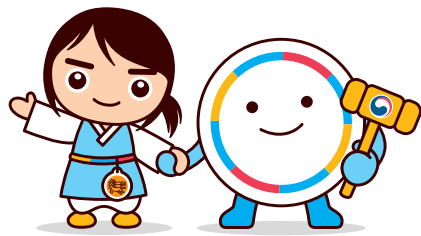


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ACRC KOREA Annual Report

2024



Anti-Corruption &
Civil Rights Commission

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Greetings from the Chairperson



The year 2024 was a period of continued difficulty in the people's livelihood. The economy slowed, and consumer sentiment weakened due to various internal and external reasons. Against this background, the Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Commission made every effort to resolve the grievances of the people and prevent corruption. As a result, there were meaningful achievements in many ways, such as protecting the vulnerable groups and achieving the 30th place in the CPI (Corruption Perceptions Index).

First of all, the ACRC closely protected vulnerable groups such as Hansen disease patients, the disabled, and single-parent households who suffer from economic and social difficulties. A dedicated investigator was designated to promptly address emergency complaints from the vulnerable groups on the spot. Those investigators also checked those groups throughout the entire year whether, for instance, the settlement environment for Hansen disease patients such as Doseong village is well organized. At the same time, mentoring for self-reliant young people was conducted in cooperation with various organizations, and providing help and support for the people in need at all times through various methods such as by sharing best practices through the ACRC.

ACRC reasonably coordinated and resolved collective grievances which have huge social ripple effects. The Commission successfully mediated the complaints of the Suseong Shooting Range in Pohang, where the shooting drill of the U.S. Forces Korea was suspended due to residents' opposition, and the complaints of Gwangju apartment complex which the residents had to pay huge amount of sewage fees due to groundwater leakage. As a result, the ACRC was able to resolve the long-cherished wish of tens of thousands of people and prevent greater social conflicts.

The commission faithfully implemented policies by collecting invaluable opinions of the people on various social issues. We communicated with the public by operating various public participation platforms such as e-People, People's Idea Box, and Complaints Big Data. The collected opinions were systematically analyzed in multi-faceted ways and used for recommendation to relevant institutions and for institutional improvement in all encompassing ways such as enhancing fairness of the national qualification test and safe management of long-distance late-night buses.



Administrative appeal is also improved so that easier and more convenient relief of rights can be available. By expanding the number of institutions which are using the online "Easy Administrative Appeals" system, anyone can easily file an administrative appeal through a single platform. The opportunity for applicant to be engaged in the appeal and direct statement has been strengthened by vitalizing oral hearing.

Corruption practices which were prevalent at local sites and impacting daily lives of the people were thoroughly investigated to prevent public finance leakage. Overseas business trips of local councils, irrational execution of local government payment for dangerous duty, and illegal receipt of government subsidies were investigated to detect and punish illegal activities. The foundation for the public to report with trust has also been strengthened by expanding the scope of reporting on public interest violations, and lifting the limit of the compensation. As a result of these efforts, Korea's CPI (Corruption Perceptions Index) in 2024, which is evaluated by Transparency International, showed continuous progress and was up two steps to the 30th out of 180 countries.

Looking ahead to 2025, uncertainty of the society is expected to increase with international low growth, protectionism, political uncertainty, and low birth rate with aging society. Active response of the government for stable and happy lives of its people is all the more important. The Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Commission will prioritize protection of the vulnerable groups and stabilization of people's livelihoods. The commission will listen to the voice of the people such as by establishing various, sustainable support system for self-reliant young people, and improve unreasonable institutions and practices in a fast manner. Society with integrity, fairness will be also further established by various anti-corruption activities so that people can feel the difference.

"2024 ACRC Korea Annual Report" faithfully documents the endeavors of the ACRC over the past year. The ACRC hopes this publication will be a valuable resource for those who are interested in the ACRC, contributing to policy development and research.

Ryu Chulwhan

Ryu Chul Whan

Chairperson

Anti-Corruption & Civil Rights Commission



Part
01

Assessment and Future
Direction of Policies for
People's Rights and Interests



Chapter 1. Achievement for the Past Year and the Way Forward

The Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Commission (ACRC) of Korea was established on February 29, 2008, through integration of three institutions, Ombudsman of Korea, Korea Independent Commission Against Corruption, and the Administrative Appeals Commission under the Prime Minister to effectively prevent corrupt practices and to swiftly resolve infringements on people's rights and interests caused by unreasonable administrative actions.

1. Major Achievements in the Past Year

A. Promoting Anti-Corruption and Fairness Policies to Enhance International Credibility

The ACRC, as a leading organization for the pan-governmental anti-corruption initiative, has led anti-corruption and fairness reforms to realize a transparent and fair society. The Commission focused its efforts on improving policies to embed anti-corruption reforms in civil society and the everyday lives of people.

The ACRC has made it a priority to improve unfair recruitment practices in the public sector. In January 2023, the ACRC established the 'Integrated Reporting Center for Recruitment Irregularities' to strengthen fairness in hiring and has been conducting annual inspections to assess the appropriateness of recruitment practices at public institutions. In September, the Commission also recommended unified fair recruitment standards to 398 additional affiliated organizations.

To enhance the integrity of local councils, the ACRC distributed the 'Customized Manual for

Local Councils' in January. From April to August, the Commission conducted inspections on the implementation of conflict of interest prevention systems within local councils. The ACRC also reviewed cases of violations of the Code of Conduct by local council members.

The Commission further operated various integrity education programs to foster talented individuals and promote a culture of integrity throughout society. It organized the 'K-Culture Integrity Special Lecture' by linking cultural content such as Taekwondo and films. In addition, the ACRC expanded anti-corruption training for public officials from developing countries and enhanced policy promotion targeting international evaluation agencies and foreign chambers of commerce in Korea.

Thanks to these efforts, Korea is maintaining its high international status, ranking 30th (announced in Feb. 2025) out of 180 countries in 2024 in the Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI) published annually by Transparency International (TI).

B. Active Handling of Corruption and Public Interest Violation Reports and Prevention of Public Fund Leakage

While making it easier for citizens to make corruption and public interest violation reports, and helping government agencies process the reports they receive more efficiently, the ACRC is working to block corruption factors that cause public fund leakage and to ensure the efficient management of national finance.

First, the ACRC conducted intensive field inspections to eradicate entrenched corruption practices at the local level. It investigated the installation status of uncertified corrosion control equipment in municipal water supply systems and confirmed that uncertified equipment worth a total of approximately KRW 12.4 billion had been installed, subsequently notifying the relevant ministry of the status.

Meanwhile, the Act on Prohibition of Improper Claims for Public Funds and Recovery of Illicit Profits, enacted in 2020, prohibits fraudulent claims on public finances and provides



for the recovery and management of illicit gains. In 2024, the ACRC identified cases in 64 local governments where KRW 22.2 billion in penalty surcharges related to electronic vouchers for social services had not been imposed. It also found that approximately KRW 4.2 billion in support funds for areas surrounding dams had been poorly executed in seven local governments and requested recovery measures.

The ACRC promptly and accurately handled a total of 4,015 corruption reports and 3,929 public interest reports in 2024, while actively protecting whistleblowers. It also promoted a culture of active reporting by awarding a total of KRW 4.98 billion in rewards, KRW 330 million in awards, and KRW 24 million in relief funds to whistleblowers of corruption and public interest violations.

C. Strengthening Protection of Vulnerable Groups and the Systematic Resolution of Public Grievances

The ACRC actively resolves public grievances to make a transparent, fair, and inclusive society where the rights and interests of all citizens are protected. It also makes on-site visits directly to ensure that no group or region is marginalized.

First of all, as the ACRC actively resolved public grievances in line with public expectations, the acceptance rate for grievance cases rose from approximately 19% in 2020 to around 30% in 2024. In addition, the ACRC resolved about 300 collective grievance cases in 2024 alone, which had been delayed for long periods due to disagreements between central government ministries and local governments. In particular, by mediating disputes among relevant agencies regarding abandoned deer on Anmado Island and proposing a compromise method for rock removal in the Geomdan housing development district, the Commission addressed long-standing issues of local residents and ensured their safety.

The ACRC also actively engaged with the public by visiting various sites across the country. It operated Onsite Outreach Service 104 times a year, reaching out to citizens in grievance blind spots and conducting approximately 2,000 consultations on-site. Through on-



site meetings with companies such as enterprises run by persons with disabilities and social enterprises, the Commission listened to their management difficulties and worked proactively to address them.

Meanwhile, the Government Complaint Counseling Center, which was launched in October 2019 to provide one-stop consultation for complaints involving multiple agencies without partitions, receives and counsels more than 20,000 complaints annually. In 2024, the call center systems of 17 government agencies were integrated, and the adoption of AI and related technologies has improved the accessibility and convenience of civil service consultations.

D. Enhancing Quasi-Judicial Relief through Administrative Appeals

The ACRC provides prompt relief for citizens whose rights have been infringed by unreasonable or unfair administrative actions through the handling of administrative appeals. Based on the Central Administrative Appeals Commission's overall management and coordination functions, the ACRC also supports the operation of administrative appeals commissions at the provincial and municipal levels.

Through the Central Administrative Appeals Commission, the ACRC processes approximately 20,000 administrative appeal cases annually. It continues to make active efforts to shorten the average decision period and to reduce the proportion of cases exceeding the legal processing time limit of 90 days.

In 2024, the ACRC made active efforts to improve the administrative appeals system by preparing the 'Guidelines for Handling Abuse of Administrative Appeal Rights' to prevent other citizens from being harmed by malicious claimants and by reviewing proposed amendments to the Administrative Appeals Act that include measures to sanction the abuse of appeals.

Additionally, to make administrative appeals more accessible to the public, the ACRC



actively operated the government-appointed representative system for administrative appeals and enhanced the oral hearing system, enabling claimants who could not receive legal support or had difficulty preparing written documents to fully exercise their right to defense.

Furthermore, the ACRC is promoting the implementation of a 'One-Stop Administrative Appeals Service'. In 2024, it prepared a legislative amendment to integrate 66 special administrative agencies, and it launched the integrated administrative appeals system in June 2025.

E. System Improvement through the Digital Public Participation Platform

The ACRC operates digital public participation platforms such as e-People and People's Idea Box. These platforms not only handle the receipt and processing of complaints, proposals, and reports but also offer discussion and public deliberation services, using big data analysis of grievances to reflect the voices of the people in policymaking.

The e-People system integrates and connects the grievance channels of administrative and public institutions. Following a complete overhaul in 2020, it has improved user convenience and efficiency. As of 2024, a total of 1,212 administrative and public institutions are using the system.

The People's Idea Box is a digital policy participation platform that allows citizens to directly engage in proposing and improving policies. In 2024, a total of 505 policy ideas were submitted through a public contest, and 39 ideas, including the shortening of mental health checkup intervals for young people, were utilized for policy improvements.

In addition, the ACRC provided insights for policy improvements at various institutions through multi-dimensional analysis of civil complaint data. The Commission monitors civil complaint big data and provides weekly and monthly trend reports titled 'The Voice of the People' to approximately 1,800 institutions. It also actively monitored grievance trends related to major social issues such as medical strikes, potholes, and the wedding industry.



The ACRC is working to improve systems that cause inconvenience to the public based on citizens' voices. In 2024, the ACRC made recommendations to relevant agencies on various issues, including 'Enhancing Fairness in the Administration of National Qualification Examinations,' 'Improving the Effectiveness of Parental Leave and Childcare Systems for Public Officials,' 'Measures to Prevent Illegal Transactions of Event and Sports Tickets,' and 'Improvement Plans for University Dormitory and Housing Environments.'

2. The Way Forward

In 2025, the ACRC will aim for "A Better Life for the People, A Leap Forward for Korea." The Commission plans to continue its efforts to more actively protect citizens' rights and interests, stabilize people's livelihoods, and realize a transparent and fair society that citizens can truly experience.

First of all, the ACRC will directly address and actively resolve difficulties faced in people's daily lives. The Commission will work to promptly handle urgent grievances, such as hardships experienced by vulnerable groups, and continue to promote amendments to the Administrative Appeals Act to ensure the swift and convenient protection of citizens' rights.

Second of all, the ACRC will respond firmly to corruption to further strengthen public trust in the government level. The Commission plans to intensify efforts to eliminate corruption at the local government level and in frontline sectors closely related to citizens' lives, and to prevent the waste of public funds and fraudulent receipt of subsidies. The ACRC will also actively engage with the international community through events such as the APEC Anti-Corruption and Transparency Working Group meetings in February and July and the High-Level Dialogue on Anti-Corruption Cooperation in July.

Third of all, the ACRC will communicate with the public and improve systems in line with the rapidly changing era. While technologies such as AI are advancing quickly, government policies and systems are slower to adapt. The ACRC will actively utilize public communication platforms, directly engage with citizens to understand the policies they desire, and continuously improve laws and systems.

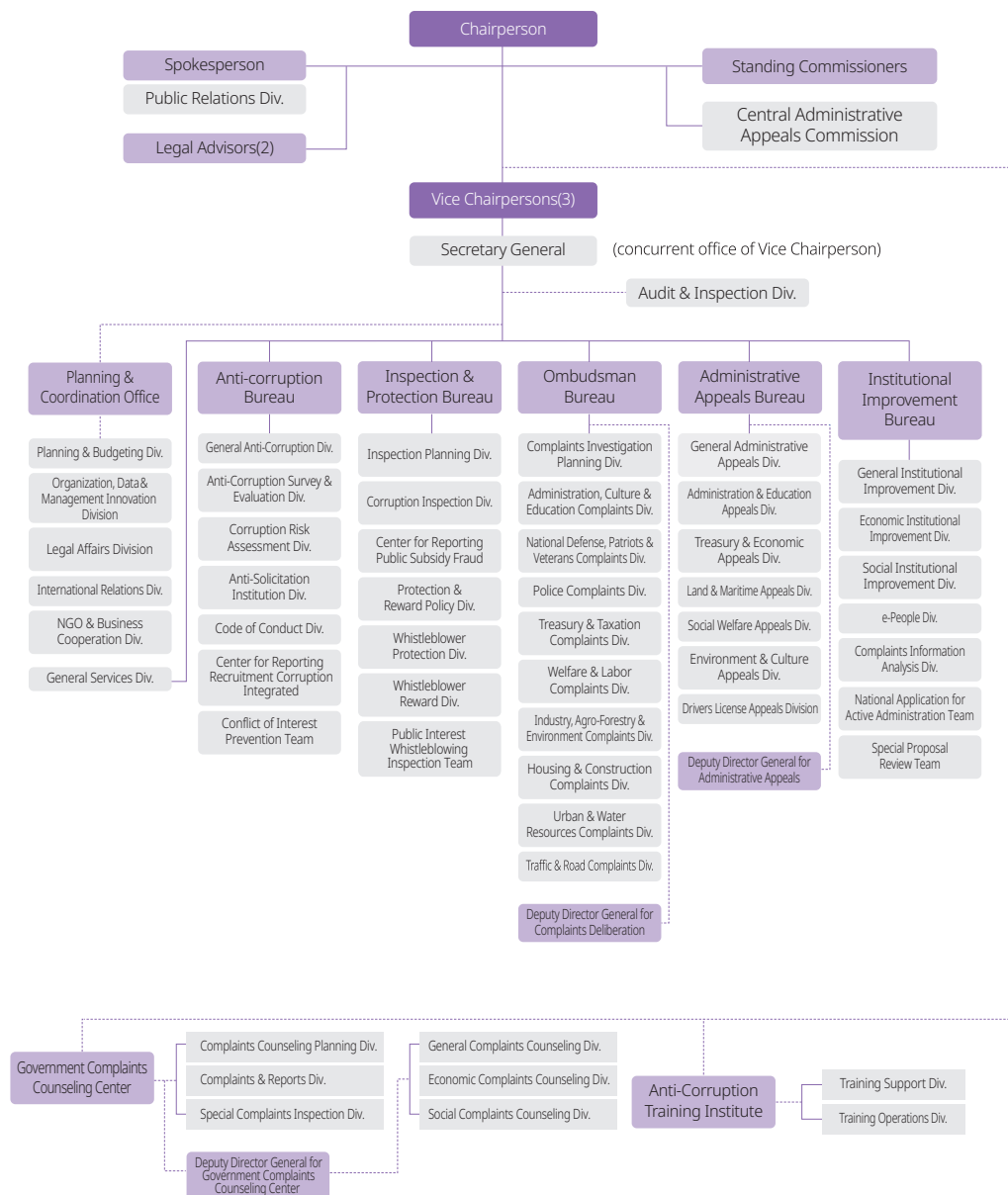




Chapter 2. Organization and Operation of the ACRC

The Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Commission (ACRC) consists of 15 members, including one Chairperson, three Vice Chairpersons, and three standing commissioners. The Chairperson, Vice Chairpersons, and commissioners are appointed or commissioned according to the qualifications prescribed by law. Each of three Vice chairpersons assists the Chairperson by handling grievances, addressing anti-corruption, and the operating the Central Administrative Appeals Commission (CAAC), respectively. The Commission also has a secretariat that handles its affairs. The position of Secretary General is concurrently held by one of the Vice Chairpersons designated by the Chairperson. The number of employees of the Commission is 561.

• [Figure 1-1] Organization chart



The ACRC's annual revenue budget for 2024 was KRW 892 million, and the tax expenditure budget was KRW 111.59 billion. This included KRW 48.82 billion for personnel expenses, KRW 7.85 billion for basic expenses, and KRW 54.93 billion for primary work expenses.

In 2024, the ACRC held a total of 280 meetings, during which it handled 10,929 agenda items, thereby ensuring the smooth operation of the Commission's core functions. By type, the plenary committee held 25 meetings to address 749 items, and the small committee held 207 meetings to handle 9,760 items, and the subcommittee held 48 meetings to process 420 items.

<Table 1-1> Committee meetings held in 2024

(unit : times, cases)

Committee			2024
Plenary Committee	Meeting		25
	Item	Resolution·Decision	617
		Report	132
		Total	749
Small Committee	1 st small committee	Meeting	41
		Item	3,602
	2 nd small committee	Meeting	42
		Item	2,688
	3 rd small committee	Meeting	41
		Item	1,434
	4 th small committee	Meeting	41
		Item	759
	5 th small committee	Meeting	42
		Item	1,277
	Total	Meeting	207
		Item	9,760
Subcommittee	First subcommittee	Meeting	24
		Item	193
	Second subcommittee	Meeting	24
		Item	227
	Total	Meeting	48
		Item	420
Total	Meeting		280
	Item		10,929



Chapter 3. Private-Public Cooperation and Support for Ethical Business Management

While strengthening its support to promote integrity and ethical management in the business sector at the governmental level, the ACRC has continued to expand communication and cooperation by engaging private organizations and the public in policy development to spread a culture of integrity and protect people's rights.

Section 1 Support for the Spread and Establishment of Ethical Management of Business

The ACRC supports the spread and establishment of a culture of integrity and ethical management across the business sector by collaborating with related organizations such as economic associations, public enterprises, and private companies, in line with global trends emphasizing anti-corruption and ESG management.

To this end, the ACRC has been publishing the 「ACRC Integrity and Ethical Management Briefs」 monthly in the form of a webzine and brochure, providing companies, economic organizations, academia, and public enterprises with the latest domestic and international trends, expert resources, and best practices related to integrity and ethical management since 2005.

Since 2022, to further improve transparency in the business sector, the ACRC has distributed the 'Guidelines for the Compliance Program for Integrity and Ethical Management', a system that encourages each organization to voluntarily establish an integrity and ethical management framework and to prevent corruption in advance.

In 2024, the ACRC published and distributed the 'Guidebook for Voluntary Ethical Management Practices for Companies,' which outlines the essential elements for operating a systematic self-compliance program for ethical management. It also supported companies by providing briefings, consulting services, and ethical management assessments.

Going forward, the ACRC will continue to support the effective implementation of ethical management practices in companies and strengthen cooperation with the private sector.

Section 2 Revitalization of Governance for Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Promotion

The ACRC operates the '2030 ACRC Advisory Group', a policy monitoring body, to identify key issues for anti-corruption and the promotion of citizens' rights from the public's perspective. It also reviews and evaluates existing policies to promote integrity and rights protection measures that meet the expectations of the people.

In 2024, in line with the national policy direction of "promoting youth participation in policymaking", the ACRC selected 20 members aged 19 to 39, taking into account regional and gender diversity, to form the Advisory Group, aiming to reflect the voices of young people in policymaking by providing them with opportunities to directly participate in policy sites.

The 2030 Advisory Group attended institutional improvement meetings and on-site grievance handling sessions as youth representatives, gaining firsthand experience in the policymaking process and providing their input. They also shared quarterly activity reports (including activity details, proposals for institutional improvements, and suggestions) through regular and ad-hoc meetings, and discussed future operational plans, ensuring the Advisory Group was operated substantively under the leadership of its members.

To enhance accountability and transparency in public administration, the ACRC has been working to promote the Citizen Integrity Auditor System, conducting a private participatory



external oversight roles across various institutions, including central governments, local governments and public service related institutions.

In 2024, 235 out of 236 organizations subject to the assessment have adopted and are operating the system. The ACRC supports tangible outcomes by incorporating Citizen Integrity Auditors recommendations, such as corrective actions, audit requests, and policy improvement suggestions, into regulatory revisions and audit implementation

The ACRC will continue to make efforts to revitalize the system by providing training on duties, audit and investigation techniques, and other areas to help citizen integrity auditors at various institutions carry out audits, investigations, evaluations, and recommendations for institutional improvements in a systematic and effective manner. It will also promote best practices by sharing outstanding operational cases from different institutions.

Section 3 Discover and Support Programs to Promote Autonomous Integrity and Rights at the Private Level

Since 2007, the ACRC has been selecting and funding projects through an open call to nonprofit private organizations every year. This initiative aims to foster a culture of integrity and promote people's rights based on autonomy and creativity.

In 2024, the ACRC selected 4 projects after evaluating their themes, impacts, and the organization's capabilities to carry them out, and granted approximately KRW 113 million. The ACRC newly developed programs to enhance integrity and promote citizens' rights, targeting various social groups (policy-marginalized groups) such as private organizations, youth, infants and toddlers, and persons with disabilities, who had been somewhat outside the direct focus of traditional anti-corruption policies.

Major projects in 2024 include 'Barrier-Free Iruri', a media action project for the rights of persons with disabilities by Gwangju Citizens' Broadcasting; the Youth Integrity Heritage Site Promotion Reporters project by the Korea Youth Village Network; and the



Development and Education of Transparency Content for Ethical Management of Nonprofit Organizations by the Korea Public Corporation Association.

The outcomes of the subsidy projects are provided as reference materials to the relevant departments of the ACRC for use in their operations (▲Promotional Video on Integrity Heroes Produced by the Youth Reporters of the Korea Youth Village Network, ▲Korea Public Interest Corporation Association's Q&A Casebook for Nonprofit Practitioners: "Practical Questions—Talk, Talk, Talk!")





Chapter 4. International Cooperation

In 2024, international cooperation and activities were actively pursued through participation in various international conferences and the expansion of bilateral exchanges and collaboration.

Section 1 International Anti-Corruption Cooperation

1. Implementation and Negotiation of the International Anti-Corruption Convention

The Republic of Korea signed the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC) in 2003 and ratified the convention in 2008. Korea completed its first cycle review in 2013 under Chapters III (Criminalization and Law Enforcement) and IV (International Cooperation) of the UNCAC, covering the period from 2010 to 2015. The second cycle review (2016–2026) was focused on Chapters II (Preventive Measures) and V (Asset Recovery), and Korea completed it in December 2023. Meanwhile, Korea, together with Papua New Guinea, has been selected as a reviewing country for Japan's second cycle review in the lottery of reviewing countries (June 25-26) prior to the 11th meeting of the Implementation Review Group (Vienna/ Video conference on June 29, 2020) and is currently conducting the review.

In order to implement the OECD Anti-Bribery Convention, Korea enacted the implementation law for the convention in December 1998 known as the Act on Combating Bribery of Foreign Public Officials in the International Business Transactions (International Anti-Bribery Act), which went into effect in February 1999. This Act is supported by the Public Interest Whistleblower Protection Act, which offers legal protection to individuals

reporting violations of the International Anti-Bribery Act. Korea reported its results of the Phase 4 recommendations in December 2023. The OECD Working Group on Bribery (WGB) conducted a technical mission in November 2024 to enhance the implementation of the recommendations. Follow-up actions based on the results of the technical mission will be finalized at a future meeting.

On May 23, 2022, the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF), a new trade and economic partnership focused on supply chain, digital, and clean energy, was launched to address common challenges faced by the Indo-Pacific region, including digital transformation, climate change adaptation, and the economic impacts of the pandemic. With the goal of strengthening cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region, the IPEF focuses on four pillars: trade, supply chain, clean economy (clean energy, decarbonization, and infrastructure), and fair economy (taxation and anti-corruption). At the IPEF Ministerial Meeting in June 2024, Pillar 4 (Fair Economy) was signed and came into effect in October 2024. Key anti-corruption elements of Pillar 4 (Fair Economy) include enhancing transparency and inclusiveness in the UNCAC implementation review process, introducing whistleblower protection systems and procedures, and implementing measures to promote public officials' integrity, such as operating anti-corruption education programs.

2. Participation in Anti-Corruption Meetings with International Organizations

In 2024, Brazil assumed the G20 Presidency and hosted three working group meetings as well as the G20 Anti-Corruption Ministerial Meeting on October 24. The ACRC attended as a representative of Korea and presented on "Korea's Implementation Efforts to Strengthen International Anti-Corruption Cooperation and Anti-Corruption Policy Achievements." As annexes to the G20 Leaders' Declaration, the Anti-Corruption Ministerial Declaration, High-Level Principles on Incentives for the Private Sector, the Accountability Report on Organizing against Corruption, and an Action Plan outlining key anti-corruption issues and objectives to be discussed from 2025 to 2027 were adopted.

At the 2024 APEC Anti-Corruption and Transparency Working Group (ACTWG) meeting hosted by the Public Integrity Secretariat of Peru's Cabinet, Korea delivered a presentation



on the role of technology in preventing and combating corruption, focusing on the Clean Portal. In addition, with Korea set to assume the APEC Chairmanship in 2025, the ACRC, as Chair of the ACTWG, presented its major planned activities for 2025.

The OECD holds the Public Integrity and Anti-Corruption meetings twice a year and the Global Anti-Corruption and Integrity Forum once a year to promote the design and implementation of integrity and anti-corruption policies that support good public governance. At the meeting on "Fostering Integrity Policies and Strengthening Anti-Corruption Frameworks in the Asia-Pacific Region," held during the OECD Integrity Week in March 2024, the ACRC attended as Korea's representative and presented on the key provisions of the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act, the procedures for reporting and handling conflicts of interest, and the protection and reward systems for whistleblowers.

Since its establishment in 1999, the ADB/OECD Asia-Pacific Anti-Corruption Council has been supporting anti-corruption efforts in the Asia-Pacific region through the effective implementation of the United Nations Convention against Corruption. At the Asia-Pacific Anti-Corruption Initiative (ACI) Seminar held in September 2024, participants discussed topics such as "Government Incentives for Corporate Anti-Corruption Compliance Programs," prospects for corporate integrity standards, and ways for companies and public officials to engage responsibly in the policymaking process.

In 2013, the ACRC made a voluntary contribution of about KRW 150 million to the International Anti-Corruption Academy (IACA), an international organization dedicated to anti-corruption education and training, and has contributed 50,000 euros annually since 2019. At the 13th Session of the IACA, held in Vienna, Austria, in October 2024, the ACRC actively participated in discussions on the latest trends in corruption measurement by international organizations. The ACRC also presented Korea's major anti-corruption efforts and achievements over the past year, including amendments to the Improper Solicitation and Graft Act to enhance the effectiveness of anti-corruption norms, the implementation of integrity assessments targeting local councils to improve transparency at the local level, and the strengthening of whistleblower rewards.



3. Anti-Corruption Technical Assistance

As Korea's leading anti-corruption organization under the UN Convention against Corruption, the ACRC provides technical assistance to other countries to help them establish and implement effective policies to prevent and combat corruption.

Through the “ACRC-UNDP Anti-Corruption Cooperation MOU” signed in December 2015, the ACRC has shared anti-corruption systems and measures—such as the Public Institutions Comprehensive Integrity Assessment, Corruption Risk Assessment, and the Clean Portal—with 12 countries including Vietnam, Uzbekistan, and Kosovo since 2016. Starting in 2024, the Commission began sharing the Public Institutions Comprehensive Integrity Assessment system with Sri Lanka. In addition, to enable other countries with strong anti-corruption reform initiatives to benchmark Korea's experience, the ACRC has worked with UNDP to develop knowledge products related to the Integrity Assessment and Corruption Risk Assessment. In 2024, it published a resource book on the Clean Portal, currently one of the ongoing projects.

4. Bilateral Cooperation on Anti-Corruption

In 2024, the ACRC signed its first-ever anti-corruption cooperation Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with an African country, the Federal Ethics and Anti-Corruption Commission of Ethiopia. To implement the MOU, the ACRC visited the Ethiopian Commission in November and held a high-level anti-corruption cooperation meeting. Through this visit, the ACRC introduced Korea's advanced anti-corruption systems, discussed international cooperation measures including the implementation of the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC), and further strengthened the foundation for bilateral cooperation.

In May 2024, the ACRC visited Hanoi, Vietnam, and held anti-corruption cooperation meetings with the Central Internal Affairs Commission and the Government Inspectorate of Vietnam. Through the extension of MOU with the Central Internal Affairs Commission, the ACRC laid the groundwork for future anti-corruption cooperation between the two countries.



Delegations from Mongolia's Parliament (January), Ministry of Justice (September), and senior public officials (October) visited the ACRC, during which briefing sessions were held on Korea's anti-corruption policies, including the Public Interest Whistleblower Protection Act and the e-People system. In October and December 2024, delegations from Indonesia's Ministry of Administrative and Bureaucratic Reform and the parliamentary Expertise Agency respectively visited the ACRC, where policy briefings were held on the e-People and People's Idea Box systems and the Corruption Risk Assessment system.



Policy briefing session for the delegation from the Ministry of Justice of Mongolia (Sep 25)



Policy briefing on Corruption Risk Assessment for the delegation from Indonesia (Dec 19)

In November 2024, the ACRC and the National Anti-Corruption Commission of Thailand co-hosted a workshop on "Utilizing Technology for Corruption Prevention" at the ACRC headquarters.

Additionally, in May, the ACRC held a policy briefing session introducing Korea's anti-corruption policies to a delegation from Uzbekistan's Ministry of Justice. In October, the ACRC participated in the Tashkent Anti-Corruption Virtual Forum in Uzbekistan and delivered a presentation on "Integrity Education in Korea." Furthermore, in July, the ACRC took part in a virtual seminar co-hosted by the OECD and the Jordan Integrity and Anti-Corruption Commission to share Korea's Comprehensive Integrity Assessment system.



Policy briefing session for the delegation from the Ministry of Justice of Uzbekistan (May 7)



The ACRC, NACC and KPI co-hosted a workshop on "Utilizing Technology in Corruption Prevention" (Nov 6)

Section 2 Ombudsman Cooperation

The Korea Independent Commission against Corruption, the predecessor of the ACRC, joined the International Ombudsmen Institute (IOI), a conference of heads of ombudsman organizations, in 1996. Since the establishment of the ACRC in 2008, the Chairperson of the Commission has been actively participated in the IOI as the Regional Director for Asia, contributing to discussions and decision-making on various agenda items at the IOI Board of Directors and General Assembly. At the IOI General Assembly held in May 2024, the ACRC actively participated in discussions aimed at mutual learning and joint responses among ombudsman institutions regarding emerging common challenges such as climate change, digitalization, and future generations.

Asian Ombudsman Association (AOA) was established in 1996 to enhance the capacity of ombudsman organizations in Asia and to promote the exchange of information and experience and the development of the AOA. At the AOA Board Meeting held in June 2024, the ACRC introduced the Collective Grievance Mediation System and the e-People system as best practices.

In December 2024, at the International Ombudsman Summit hosted by the Hong Kong Ombudsman, the ACRC presented Korea's grievance handling system, notable best practices, and major policy achievements. Also, leveraging the occasion of the summit, the ACRC also signed an MOU with the Hong Kong Ombudsman to strengthen cooperation, thereby establishing an institutional foundation for substantive collaboration between the two organizations.



IOI General Assembly (May 13-17)



International Ombudsman Summit (Nov 3)



Chapter 5. Public Relations

As the frontline institution for protecting citizens' rights and interests, the ACRC has actively promoted its efforts to resolve social conflicts and grievances centered on the public and field sites, prevent conflicts of interest, eradicate improper solicitations, and protect and reward whistleblowers. These efforts have been part of the Commission's broader initiatives to advocate for the protection of rights and interests and to spread a culture of integrity.

In 2024, the ACRC continued to actively promote its work across multiple areas, including resolving grievances of socially vulnerable groups, recommending institutional improvements affecting citizens' lives, and publicizing major survey results in fields such as grievance resolution, institutional reform, administrative appeals, and anti-corruption efforts. To this end, the Commission used a variety of methods, such as distributing press releases, holding media briefings, participating in broadcast programs, hosting discussion sessions, and contributing opinion pieces, to provide the public with detailed information on key initiatives.

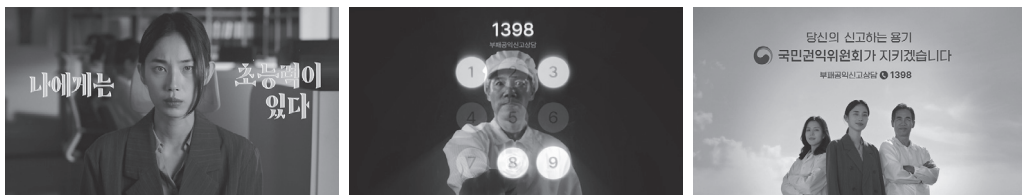
In particular, regarding the increase in the allowable value of meals under the Improper Solicitation and Graft Act (August), the ACRC emphasized the necessity of the policy by supporting regional press briefings and other active promotional efforts. It also engaged with the 2030 youth generation by focusing on major topics of interest such as employment, certifications, and recruitment irregularities through specially organized field events, media briefings, and press meetings highlighting key achievements in institutional improvements.

The ACRC produced and broadcast TV public service advertisements to actively inform the public about its work in anti-corruption, grievance resolution, administrative appeals,

and institutional improvements, while also encouraging public participation through the reporting of corruption and public interest violations, filing of grievances, and submission of administrative appeals. The Commission also operated a regular segment on radio broadcasts to enhance public awareness.

In December, in connection with Anti-Corruption Week and Public Interest Whistleblower Day, the ACRC produced and widely promoted a video publicizing the corruption and public interest reporting systems. By mobilizing all available media channels—including TV and radio ads, portal site events, and outdoor billboards—the Commission ensured broad dissemination of the promotional content.

[ACRC TV advertisement, "Corruption and Public Interest Violation Reporting System"]



The ACRC's digital communication team consists of a total of six people, including writers, video production PDs, and graphic designers, and utilizes its own filming studio to produce policy content in an organized and systematic manner. The ACRC operates official accounts on various social media platforms, including YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, X (formerly Twitter), and Naver blog, to actively promote the ACRC's major policies and operational achievements. In 2024, the ACRC's YouTube channel "Anti-Corruption & Civil Rights Vision" surpassed 100,000 subscribers, achieving notable results in online promotion.

The Digital Communication Team created the special series—"Listening to and Learning from Youth"—in various formats such as street interviews and talk shows to enhance the awareness and interest of the 2030 generation in ACRC policies. By capturing the voices of young people on-site and fostering opportunities for empathy, the team provided a platform for closer engagement. In addition, by collaborating with influencers from various fields, including KBS comedians, announcers, and film directors, the ACRC strengthened its efforts to communicate its key policies more closely with the public.

The ACRC also publishes a quarterly Newsletter, that highlights trends in major policy promotion activities and examples of policies that resonate with the public. Since its inaugural issue in March 2008, The ACRC Newsletter, has published 83 issues (Winter 2024) so far. In 2024, to promote key policies of the ACRC to a broader audience, the Commission launched and began operating its first-ever webzine (www.acrcwebzine.com), providing timely information on key policies of the ACRC to policy stakeholders.





Part
02

Implementation of
Anti-Corruption Policies for
Realization of Clean Korea



Chapter 1. Promotion of Anti-Corruption Legislation and Systems as Norms in Daily Life

Section 1 Stable Establishment of Act on the Prevention of Conflict of Interest Related to Duties of Public Servants and Effective Operation of the System

1. Overview

The Act on the Prevention of Conflict of Interest Related to Duties of Public Servants was enacted in 2021 and has been in effect since May 19, 2022 to prevent potential conflicts of interest that may arise during the performance of public servants' duties, thereby ensuring fair performance of duties and securing public trust in public institutions. As 2024 marks the third year of implementation of the Act, an important task for the ACRC was to create a compliance environment so that the conflict of interest prevention system could be established in the public service community.

The Conflict of Interest Prevention Act establishes 10 standards of conduct for public officials. These are divided into five reporting and submission obligations that public officials must fulfill and five restrictions and prohibitions that they must avoid.

<Table 2-1> Standards of conduct for public officials under the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act

- Reporting·Submission -	- Restriction·Prohibition -
① Disclosure of personally interested persons and application for evasion	⑥ Restriction on duty-related outside activities
② Disclosure of ownership/ purchase of public duty-related real estate	⑦ Restriction on employment of family members
③ Submission of records of high-ranking officials' business activities in the private sector	⑧ Restriction on private contracts
④ Report of transactions with duty-related persons	⑨ Prohibition of private use of or profiting from public institutions' goods
⑤ Report of personal contact with retirees	⑩ Prohibition of use of job secrets, etc

Public officials who fail to comply with the above 10 standards of conduct are subject to severe penalties, including imprisonment with labor for up to 7 years, a fine not exceeding KRW 70 million, or an administrative fine of up to KRW 30 million. Additionally, any unfair profits obtained through non-compliance will be recovered.

2. Activities and Achievements

Every public institution must establish operational guidelines for the conflict of interest prevention system, detailing specific procedures and methods to ensure compliance with the ten behavioral standards stipulated in the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act. In August 2024, the ACRC revised the Operational Guidelines for the Conflict of Interest Prevention System for Public Officials by supplementing detailed procedures and methods after collecting feedback from relevant agencies. The ACRC distributed a standard version of the guidelines to all institutions, thereby further enhancing the system's implementation.

To promote the key elements of the conflict of interest prevention system, share the main revisions to the operational guidelines, and gather feedback on the challenges faced by institutions in operating the system, the ACRC held regional briefing sessions for conflict of interest officers in September 2024. The sessions were held 10 times across five regions, with 1,351 public officials from 924 public institutions participating.

The '2024 work handbook of the Act on the Prevention of Conflict of Interest Related to Duties of Public Servants' was published. This handbook includes the revision of the operation guideline, legal interpretation standards, frequently asked questions and answers. The work handbook was distributed to all public institutions in November 2024, enabling institutions at all levels to operate a stable conflict of interest prevention system.

Meanwhile, anyone who becomes aware of a violation or potential violation of the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act may report it to the relevant public institution or the ACRC. From the enforcement of the Act (May 19, 2022) through 2024, a total of 502 reports were filed with the ACRC, and 481 cases were processed. Among them, 29 cases, which were deemed

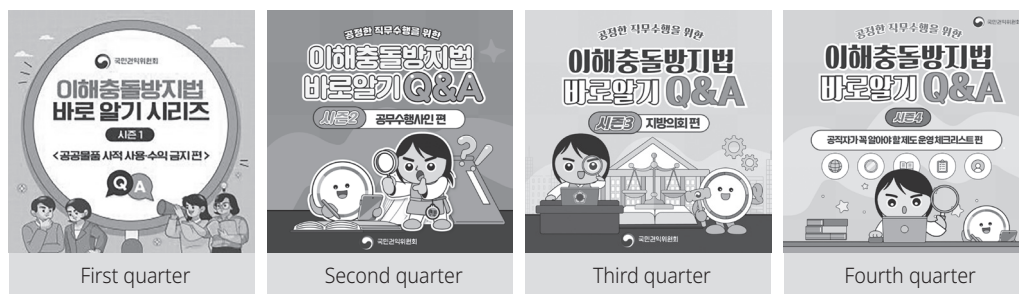


to require further investigation due to potential violations, were referred or forwarded to the relevant public institutions to ensure the effective operation of the system.

Additionally, from April to August 2024, the ACRC conducted on-site inspections of the conflict of interest prevention system at 20 local councils (7 metropolitan and 13 basic councils), which were considered to have a higher risk of conflict of interest due to their close ties with local communities. In November, the ACRC announced the inspection results, sharing major cases of violations of the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act within local councils and working to prevent the recurrence of such violations.

The ACRC is working to enhance public officials' and citizens' awareness of the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act through a variety of online and offline promotional efforts to ensure the stable establishment of the system. First, the ACRC produced easy-to-understand card news highlighting key violations and points of caution, and distributed them quarterly through the ACRC website and social media channels. Additionally, to mark the second anniversary of the Act's enforcement, the ACRC created a promotional video featuring the law's key provisions and broadcast it via elevator screens, outdoor railway advertisements, and YouTube.

◉ [Figure 2-1] Understanding the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act card series

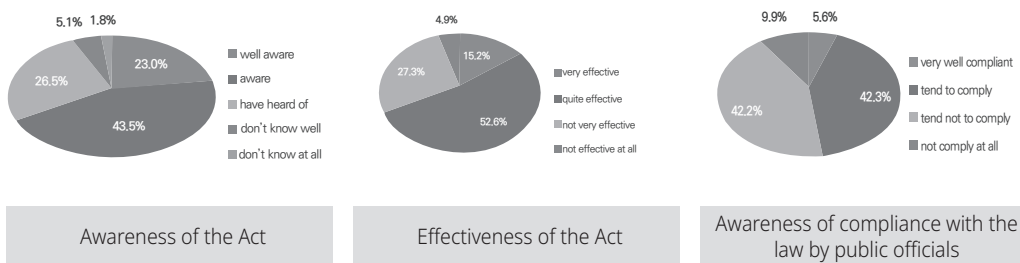


To promote the key provisions of the Act and gather public feedback, the ACRC conducted a survey through People's Idea Box. The survey questions covered topics such as awareness of the Act, its effectiveness, perceptions of public officials' compliance, future tasks, and other opinions related to the conflict of interest prevention system.

3,418 people participated in the survey. 66.5% of respondents were aware of the Conflict of

Interest Prevention Act, 67.8% believe it is effective, and 47.9% believe that public officials comply with the Act. In addition, the public identified strengthening the detection and punishment of violations, enhanced protection and rewards for whistleblowers, and the improvement of system operation as key tasks for the future to firmly establish the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act within public institutions.

○ [Figure 2-2] Survey result on the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act



Section 2 Enhancement of the Normative Power and Effectiveness of Anti-Graft Act

1. Overview

The Improper Solicitation and Graft Act (Anti-Graft Act), which was enacted and enforced on September 28, 2016, in response to the public's desire for a transparent and corruption-free society, is considered to have brought about a range of positive changes across the country as it has become a norm in the public sector and among ordinary citizens. New practices, such as "Dutch treat" are becoming commonplace, and various privileges and favors that have been considered routine are now recognized as unfair. The ACRC is focusing all its efforts on firmly establishing the Improper Solicitation and Graft Act in society with the goal of realizing a clean and transparent society where everyone can compete fairly without solicitation or entertainment.

2. Activities and Achievements

In accordance with the enforcement of the Anti-Graft Act, the ACRC has been providing briefing sessions and other forms of support for anti-corruption officers in charge of counseling and report processing across various levels of institutions. These efforts aim to ensure that public officials subject to the Act accurately understand the law and to strengthen the system operation capabilities of public institutions. In February, a briefing session on the operation of the anti-graft system was held for a total of 1,304 people, including officials responsible for the operation of the Improper Solicitation and Graft Act at various levels of institutions. In April and May, a total of 1,341 people in charge of operating the anti-graft system attended the regional briefings on the Anti-Graft Act, which were held in six regions across the country.

◉ [Figure 2-3] Regional briefings on the Anti-Graft Act



In particular, for journalists, who have been lacking practical training opportunities and experience compared to public officials, the ACRC has regularly organized training sessions on the Anti-Graft Act for trainee journalists in cooperation with the Korea Press Foundation. These sessions have been conducted in collaboration with the Korea Press Foundation, and about 130 trainee journalists have been trained on the Anti-Graft Act in a total of 7 sessions.

Section 3 Reviewing and Strengthening of the Code of Conduct for Public officials

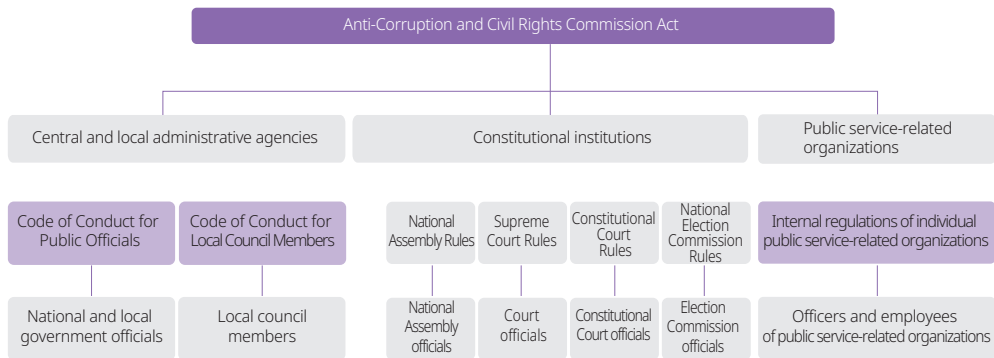
1. Overview

The code of conduct for public officials is a standard of conduct that public officials must comply with to ensure the fair performance of public duties and to prevent corruption. It includes both a code of ethics containing the values that internal members of an organization should basically pursue and a code of practice, which set out detailed standards and procedures for members to follow.

Article 8 of the ACRC Act, which serves as the legal basis for the Code of Conduct for Public Officials, mandates that all public institutions establish and enforce a code of conduct through presidential decrees, National Assembly rules, Supreme Court rules, Constitutional Court rules, National Election Commission rules, or internal regulations of affiliated organizations. This provision requires that the code of conduct address the following matters: ① Prohibition and restriction of the receipt of entertainment, gifts, and other benefits from persons related to one's official duties; ② Prohibition and restriction of personnel influence, intervention in interests, or solicitation by taking advantage of one's position; ③ Matters that public officials must observe to create a sound and fair public service environment, including fair personnel management; ④ Matters necessary for preventing corruption and maintaining the integrity and dignity of public officials in the performance of their duties.

Accordingly, the Code of Conduct for the Maintenance of Integrity by Public Officials, which applies to public officials under the Executive Branch, has been in effect since May 19, 2003. Constitutional bodies such as the National Assembly, the Supreme Court, the Constitutional Court, and the National Election Commission have also established and enforced their own codes of conduct through their respective rules. Since the first amendment to the Code of Conduct for Public Officials on December 9, 2005, the code has undergone nine revisions to reach its current form.

○ [Figure 2-4] Operational Framework of the Code of Conduct for Public Officials



2. Activities and Achievements

The ACRC has actively promoted the autonomous discipline of institutions and made various efforts to support the more effective operation of the Code of Conduct system. This included preparing and implementing institutional codes of conduct tailored to the characteristics of different levels of public institutions.

Briefing sessions on the establishment and operation of the code of conduct were held in March and August 2024 for 53 newly designated as public service-related organizations in 2024. Through this, the need to establish a code of conduct for each institution, the main contents of the code of conduct, and various integrity measures to improve the integrity of executives and employees of public service-related organizations were promoted. The ACRC received submissions on the establishment and revision of the Code of Conduct from institutions of various levels, reviewed them, and notified the relevant organizations of any corrective actions to ensure effective operation of the system.

In addition, to support the smooth operation of the Code of Conduct, the revised "Work Handbook on the Code of Conduct for Public Officials" was published and distributed to a total of 1,770 organizations. Lectures by expert inspectors were provided to organizations throughout the year to strengthen institutional capacity to implement the Code of Conduct.

Anyone who becomes aware of a violation of the Code of Conduct by a public official may report it to the ACRC, the head of the public official's affiliated institution, or the officer responsible for the code of conduct. In accordance with Article 10 of the Enforcement Decree of the ACRC Act, the ACRC verifies the report and, if a violation is confirmed, notifies the head of the affiliated institution or the head of the supervisory authority. The notified institution or authority is then required to take appropriate measures and report the results back to the ACRC.

In 2024, the ACRC identified a total of 66 violations of the Code of Conduct by public officials, notified the relevant organizations, and handled 342 reported cases, transferring some cases to the relevant organizations for further investigation.

The ACRC annually investigates and inspects the operation and implementation of the Code of Conduct by public institutions according to the Article 9 of the Enforcement Decree of the Act on the Prevention of Corruption and the Establishment and Management of the ACRC. The ACRC is committed to reducing blind spots in corruption control by reviewing codes of conduct in areas of vulnerability to corruption.

The ACRC first inspected the implementation status of the Code of Conduct related to budget execution by local councils, which serve as representative bodies of residents, and local governments. The inspection confirmed cases of improper use of business promotion expenses by local council members unrelated to their intended purposes, as well as improper execution of local tax collection rewards and clothing allowances by local governments. For violations of the Code of Conduct, the ACRC plans to notify the relevant institutions to take necessary actions such as disciplinary measures against those involved and the recovery of funds.

In addition, the ACRC conducted an inspection of the implementation of the Code of Conduct at affiliated public organizations entrusted with major government services, such as disaster relief and facility safety, particularly those with budgets exceeding KRW 10 billion and significant influence on citizens' lives. The inspection identified cases of suspected



improper use of business promotion expenses, including expenditures during late-night hours, holidays, and at entertainment establishments. The ACRC notified each institution to conduct internal investigations on improper expenditures and to take necessary measures such as disciplinary actions and employee training.

In addition, in order to eradicate corruption such as receiving money and goods during major holidays such as Lunar New Year and Chuseok, and to promote a culture of integrity, the ACRC conducted intensive inspections targeting public institutions with lower integrity scores. These inspections focused on the giving and receiving of money, entertainment, and gifts during vulnerable periods. Violations of the code of conduct, such as receiving gifts, were notified to the relevant organizations, and necessary measures such as disciplinary actions were recommended.





Chapter 2. Improvement of Laws and Systems to Combat Persistent Injustice and Recruitment Corruption

Section 1 Elimination of Recruitment Irregularities in Public Institutions and Promoting a Culture of Fair Recruitment

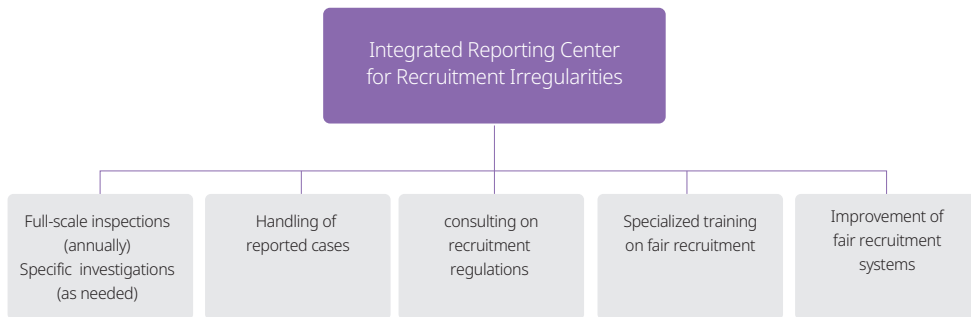
1. Background

The government established and operated the Task Force for the Eradication of Recruitment Irregularities in Public Institutions (the "TF"), a temporary body established in November 2018 to promote comprehensive government-wide measures to eliminate recruitment irregularities in public institutions. The TF carried out functions aimed at establishing a fair recruitment culture over the past four years, including conducting surveys on the hiring practices of public institutions, managing follow-up measures, and handling reports of hiring irregularities. Its operations concluded at the end of 2022. The "Eradication of employment corruption in the public sector" was a national task aimed at "ensuring fair opportunities for young people to take a leap forward" pledged when the Yoon Suk Yeol government was launched in 2022. In January 2023, the Integrated Center for Reporting Recruitment Corruption (the "Center") was established to promote the national tasks in a more systematic manner and to deepen the culture of fair employment in the public sector.

Since the launch of the center, the ACRC has been regularly receiving and resolving reported cases of recruitment irregularities in order to establish a fair hiring culture in the public sector, and its ability to detect hiring irregularities has been strengthened by conducting fact-finding investigations. Meanwhile, various efforts have been made to eradicate hiring irregularities, such as consulting on the hiring regulations of public service-

related organizations, professional training on fair hiring, and expanding preventive functions such as system improvement.

○ [Figure 2-5] Main Functions of the Integrated Reporting Center for Recruitment Irregularities



2. Comprehensive Inspection of the Hiring Status of Public Service-related Organizations and Handling of Recruitment Irregularity Cases

The ACRC has been promoting a comprehensive inspection of the hiring status of public service-related organizations every year jointly with related ministries since 2019, and in 2024, a comprehensive inspection was conducted targeting 1,386 public service-related organizations. The ACRC conducted a strict investigation, focusing on whether there were cases in which fairness was undermined due to failure to comply with relevant laws and guidelines at any stage of the process, including the establishment of plans related to new hiring and conversion to full-time employees, document screening, interview screening, and final selection of successful candidates. Through this comprehensive inspection, 861 cases of irregularities were identified. Disciplinary action was required for 39 cases in which serious negligence and errors occurred during the recruitment process that could affect evaluation ranking of applicants or candidates. For the 822 cases in which minor negligence was found, such as simple mistakes in the course of work, the ACRC requested caution and warning measures for those involved, as well as revisions to the organization's internal regulations. As a result of the ACRC conducting regular annual investigations into recruitment practices at affiliated public institutions and taking strict measures, including

disciplinary requests against those involved, the number of recruitment irregularities has steadily decreased. Specifically, the number of recruitment irregularity cases dropped by 78.6%, from 182 cases in 2019 to 39 cases in 2024.

Most public service-related organizations, such as public corporations and foundations, operate standardized recruitment procedures in accordance with higher-level laws and guidelines, such as the Act on the Management of Public Institutions and the Local Public Enterprises Act. However, "other public service-related organizations" that are not subject to these laws and guidelines have long faced issues due to the lack of separate procedures and standards for recruitment, leading to confusion during the recruitment process and limitations in conducting internal audits, thus raising potential risks of unfair hiring practices. In response, the ACRC established Fair Recruitment Standards by consolidating relevant laws and guidelines such as the Act on the Management of Public Institutions, widely adopted fair recruitment practices, and previous recommendations. In September 2024, the ACRC recommended that 398 other public service-related organizations formalize these standards into their own internal regulations. The ACRC plans to actively encourage the implementation of these improvements to resolve fairness issues in recruitment processes and to ensure that fair hiring procedures are firmly established. It will also regularly monitor whether recruitment practices comply with the Fair Recruitment Standards.

Since its launch, the ACRC has supported the improvement of the system by conducting consulting on internal employment-related regulations for public service-related organizations in order to prevent and detect hiring irregularities. In addition, the ACRC has introduced a specialized training program on fair recruitment.



Section 2 Corruption Risk Assessment of Enacted and Revised Laws to Improve Corruption-Causing Factors

1. Overview

Corruption Risk Assessment (CRA) is a tool that seeks to systematically analyze and evaluate corruption-causing factors within laws and regulations in order to prevent corruption in advance by preparing improvement measures. It can be divided into two main categories: assessment of enacted and revised laws and regulations and assessment of current laws and regulations. In the assessment of enacted and revised laws, the ACRC reviews laws and regulations requested by central administrative agencies in advance from the legislative stage for factors causing corruption. The assessment of current laws is to analyze and review the factors that cause corruption, such as social problems that have emerged due to corruption cases, or those inherent in laws, autonomous laws, and internal regulations of public institutions that are currently in effect, and to improve them. As for the evaluation of local statutes and internal rules of public service-related organizations, each institution autonomously establishes an evaluation system in accordance with their own characteristics and carries out the evaluation autonomously.

The Corruption Risk Assessment system was introduced through the amendment of the ACRC Act on December 29, 2005, and was officially implemented starting April 1, 2006. For affiliated public institutions, the system was introduced and has been operated since December 28, 2007. Furthermore, with the amendment of the ACRC Act on April 16, 2019, internal regulations of public institutions¹⁾ under the Act on the Management of Public Institutions and local public corporations and foundations under the Local Public Enterprises Act also became subject to corruption risk assessments by the ACRC.

2. Progress and Results of CRA on Newly Enacted and Revised Laws

In the assessment of enacted and revised laws, a total of 1,833 enacted and revised laws

1) Public institutions under the Act on the Management of Public Institutions and local public corporations and foundations under the Local Public Enterprises Act

were reviewed in 2024. During this process, 272 corruption-inducing factors were found in 148 laws, and recommendations for improvements were made to the relevant ministries. The number of laws and regulations evaluated increased by 13.1% (212) year-on-year, but the average processing time was 3.8 days, which was 2.6 days shorter than the previous year, enabling faster support for the enactment and revision of laws and regulations. The rate of recommended legal improvements reached 14.8%, marking a 5.1% increase compared to the previous year. This is attributed to the ACRC's active support for evaluation work in response to changes in the legislative environment, such as the opening of the 22nd National Assembly and the elevation of the Ministry of Patriots and Veterans Affairs to a full ministry.

3. Local Autonomous Rules

Meanwhile, as the functions and powers of local governments have expanded, the anti-corruption system that can prevent abuse of power and habitual local corruption such as preferential public-private ties, etc, is insufficient. As entrenched local corruption continued to persist and act as a barrier to revitalizing local economies, the ACRC recognized the need to fundamentally diagnose and address local government corruption. Therefore, a plan to conduct the CRA on local autonomous rules was established. And the ACRC has focused on the CRA for current laws and regulations including ordinances and rules. From 2022 to 2024, the ACRC conducted corruption risk assessments on 243 local governments and 152,881 local ordinances. Through these assessments, the ACRC recommended a total of 7,333 improvements across 72 cumulative improvement tasks.

The main results of the corruption risk assessments on local ordinances are as follows.

First, The ACRC has established prior screening criteria to assess the validity and adequacy of overseas business trips. Additionally, any travel expenses spent for purposes other than the stated objectives must be recovered.

Second, to prevent local government officials from engaging in tourism-oriented overseas business trips, regulations were established to require the participation of external experts



in the prior review of overseas trips and to provide grounds for requesting the correction of plagiarized or poorly prepared trip reports.

Third, recommendations were made to enhance the standards for executing business expenses, such as execution standards for entertainment expenses and restrictions on private use that do not comply with higher-level laws, including the Anti-Graft Act, etc. It was recommended that violations of mandatory obligations violating the code of ethics and ethical practice of local council members be specified as misconduct subject to disciplinary action, with specific disciplinary standards established for each type of misconduct in order to ensure accountability in legislative activities.

Fourth, to prevent public-private collusion, the ACRC introduced measures such as limiting the long-term tenure of advisory certified public accountants and tax accountants. In addition, management-level public officials unrelated to collection practices were excluded from receiving monetary rewards for local taxes, and award eligibility was ensured through a public review committee that included external members.

Fifth, in order to enhance fairness in the process of implementing various projects such as subsidy support, the ACRC blocks subsidies for local administrative clubs that lack a legal basis. The ACRC recommended that relevant organizations establish reasonable contractor priority standards for cases where there are two or more applicants within the same priority level when contracting for priority installation of stores, etc. in public facilities.

Sixth, there was an issue where administrative convenience was prioritized over public safety by excessively reducing the deadline for reporting poor construction of public construction projects to within one year from the date of completion without considering the characteristics of construction projects. To address this, the ACRC has blocked passive administration by extending this reporting deadline to the end of the defects liability period specified in the 「Framework Act On The Construction Industry」.



Seventh, in order to prevent hiring irregularities, such as private recruitment when hiring members of art organizations, the recruitment process has been improved to include open recruitment and screening by a selection committee. The ACRC also prevented the possibility of conflicts of interest by requiring members of large architectural art installation review committees to limit their own artwork during their term of office. The ACRC also specified the criteria for calculating the cost of artwork installation in accordance with the statutory mandate to prevent local governments from abusing their discretion.

4. Future Plans

During the sequential evaluations of local ordinances by year and by local government, the ACRC conducted additional assessments on ordinances from local governments evaluated in 2022 and 2023 where newly identified improvement tasks had not yet been applied. To enhance the effectiveness of improvement recommendations, the ACRC plans to monitor the implementation status of these recommendations by local governments and ensure that ordinance amendments are completed promptly through follow-up management.





Chapter 3.

Support for Improvement of the Integrity of Public Institutions

Section 1 Enhancement of Integrity through Comprehensive Public Integrity Assessment

1. Background

The ACRC has been conducting an objective assessment of the integrity levels of public institutions every year since 2002 and publishing the results in order to overcome the limitations of existing anti-corruption policies of the public sector, which are mostly focused on countermeasures such as detection and punishment. This allows public institutions to voluntarily improve areas vulnerable to corruption and to keep the public informed about the level of integrity in the public sector, thereby building consensus on the need to fight corruption and improve integrity.

In particular, considering that recently enacted and implemented anti-corruption laws such as the Anti-Graft Act and the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act largely aim to proactively prevent corrupt practices by public officials, the importance of preventive anti-corruption policy measures-including the Comprehensive Integrity Assessment-is expected to grow further in the future.

2. Assessment Overview and System

The target institutions for the comprehensive integrity assessment of public institutions conducted in 2024 in accordance with Articles 12 and 27-2 of the Act on the Prevention of Corruption and the Establishment and Management of the Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Commission are 16 types and a total of 718 institutions. Considering the characteristics of

the organizations, the target organizations were divided into 16 types, including central administrative agencies, local governments, offices of education, and public service-related organizations. In particular, 243 local councils were also included to accurately diagnose and improve the level of integrity in local areas.

<Table 2-2> Institutions subject to Comprehensive Integrity Assessment in 2024

(Unit: number)

Total	Central Administrative Agencies		Local Government Agencies				Offices of Education	Public service-related institutions				Public medical institutions	Local councils			
			Metropolitan	Lower-level local gov'ts				I	II	III	IV		Metropolitan	Lower-level local gov'ts		
	I (Ministry)	II (Office)		I	II	III								I	II	III
718	25	22	17	75	82	69	17	32	55	34	34	13	17	75	82	69

The 2024 Comprehensive Integrity Assessment is based on a 100-point scale, the same as in 2023. Scores are determined using a weighted sum of 60% for integrity perception and 40% for integrity effort, with a maximum of 10 points deducted for corrupt practices.

Integrity perception was measured through an objective survey conducted by a social research organization on awareness and experience of corruption in the main business of an institution. Integrity effort was measured by a group of internal and external experts evaluating the institution's anti-corruption efforts and performance using quantitative and qualitative indicators and confirmed through an appeal process.

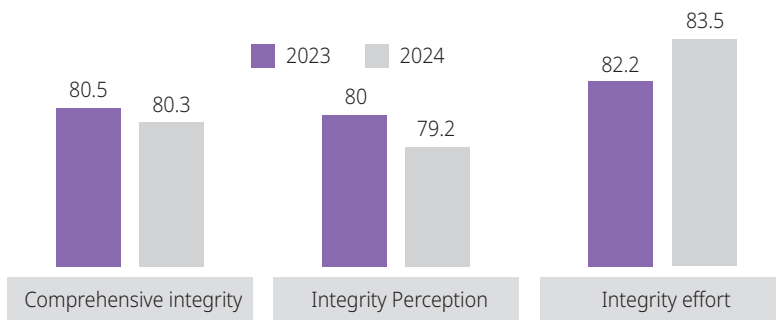
The assessment results for each level of institution were presented on a scale of 1 to 5 for each type of institution for comprehensive integrity level, integrity perception, and integrity effort. The rating for each institution is based on its total score, which was calculated by determining the rating range using the average score and standard deviation of each type. Each institution was provided with detailed scores for each area(including average scores for all institutions and for each type of institution) in the form of an institutional report for analysis of the institution's corruption-prone areas and voluntary improvement efforts.

3. Assessment Results

<Administrative agencies and public service-related organizations>

For 460 administrative agencies and public service-related organizations, and 11 types of institutions, the average comprehensive integrity score was 80.3, down 0.2 points from the previous year. The average integrity perception score was 79.2, the integrity effort score was 83.5. Among the detailed corruption perception measurement items, the corruption perception score for the pursuit of unfair private interests using job-related secrets or undisclosed information was the highest in both external and internal perception.

○ [Figure 2-6] Comparison of comprehensive integrity and sector-specific scores with the previous year



In integrity effort assessment in 2024, the ACRC introduced a new indicator titled 'Sharing and dissemination of anti-corruption best practices' to encourage public institutions at all levels to share and expand examples of efforts in corruption-prone areas. Accordingly, improvement cases in corruption-prone areas implemented by 460 institutions were posted on the 'Clean Portal', providing other institutions with opportunities for benchmarking.

<Local Councils>

Separate evaluation models were applied to local councils (243) and public healthcare organizations (13) due to differences in their institutional characteristics and nature of their work compared to administrative agencies and public service-related organizations. Notably, 2024 marked the first year in which a comprehensive integrity assessment was carried out for all local councils. The average scores for local councils was 69.2, compared to an average of 80.3 for the 460 administrative agencies and public service-related organizations. Specifically, the integrity perception score was 67.4, while the integrity effort score was 77.8, with the perception area yielding particularly lower results.

<Public medical institutions>

The comprehensive integrity score of 13 public medical institutions was 79.6, lower than that (80.3) of administrative agencies and public service-related organizations. The integrity perception score was 78.9, and the integrity effort score was 86.8. Among the 13 institutions, the overall integrity score of 2 institutions improved compared to the previous year, while 6 institutions saw a decline.

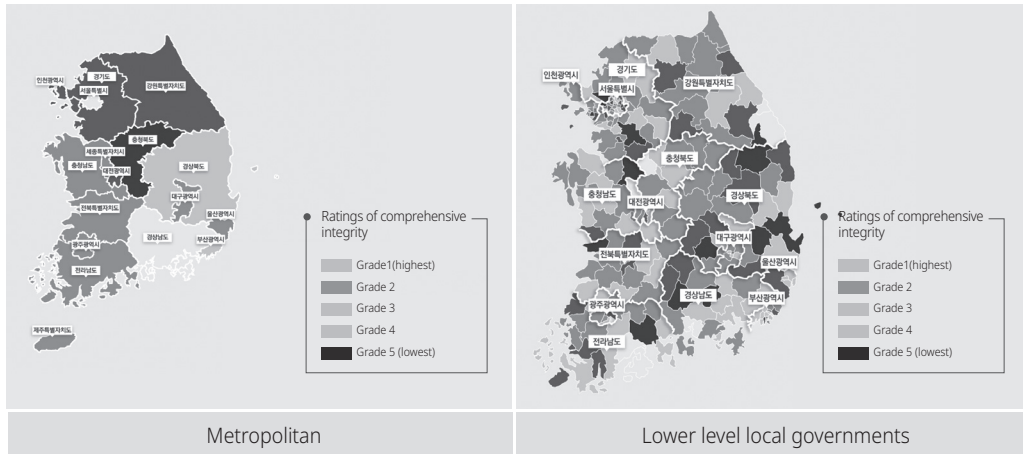
4. Way Forward

The results of this comprehensive integrity assessment will be reflected in the public enterprise and quasi-government agency management evaluations. In accordance with the ACRC Act, each institution is required to publish its individual results on its website within 14 days of the announcement date and keep them posted for at least one month.

The public can access each agency's comprehensive integrity assessment results through their websites. Additionally, an integrity map is posted on the Clean Portal operated by the ACRC offering a user-friendly visualization of the level of integrity of each institution.



○ [Figure 2-7] Integrity map for local government agencies in 2024



The ACRC plans to continue its efforts to ensure that the Comprehensive Integrity Assessment accurately diagnoses the level of integrity in the public sector and serves as a guiding benchmark for each institution's anti-corruption initiatives. To this end, the ACRC will attentively listen to feedback from the field, thoroughly review and improve necessary aspects, and strive to build trust among both citizens and public officials.

Section 2 Support for Integrity Consulting for Corruption-Prone Institutions

1. Background

The ACRC objectively measures the integrity levels of public institutions and discloses the results every year. To improve the overall integrity of public institutions, it is important to share and disseminate outstanding anti-corruption practices from high integrity institutions. It is also essential to diagnose the shortcomings of institutions with lower integrity from an objective perspective and support the establishment of fundamental and effective countermeasures. Although individual institutions are making voluntary efforts to combat corruption and promote integrity by establishing and implementing their own anti-corruption policies, it was necessary to objectively analyze these policies from a third-party

perspective to ensure their effectiveness, taking into account the specific duties and issues of each institution.

Integrity consulting is a follow-up policy of the ACRC to promote integrity aimed at enhancing integrity levels. It diagnoses the problems and causes faced by public institutions with relatively low integrity or those requiring strengthened anti-corruption capabilities, and provides tailored solutions accordingly. The ACRC aims to raise the overall level of integrity across public institutions by creating successful case examples among public institutions with low integrity levels through integrity consulting and spreading them to institutions of various levels.

2. Progress

Integrity consulting has been implemented since 2006 as part of efforts to strengthen the consulting functions for public institutions. In March 2016, the revision of the ACRC Act formally institutionalized the provision of consulting support to public organizations. Since 2018, the ACRC shifted its integrity consulting program from a one-on-one support model to a regional group consulting model, where one mentor institution supports two to three mentee institutions. Until 2017, the ACRC provided "Integrity Consulting" to individual institutions, but starting in 2018, it switched to a group consulting model involving multiple institutions to effectively respond to the growing demand for consulting and to transfer best practices from high-integrity institutions. Group consulting is organized by designating high-integrity institutions within the same region or type as "mentor institutions" and lower-integrity institutions as "mentee institutions." The program is operated through joint consulting at the group level, facilitating the sharing of integrity improvement know-how and mutual learning of best anti-corruption practices among institutions.

In 2024, the ACRC received applications from 35 groups (35 mentor institutions and 73 mentee institutions). Considering factors such as the integrity level of mentor and mentee institutions, their commitment to implementation, and success conditions, the ACRC provided consulting to 12 groups (12 mentor institutions and 24 mentee institutions).



When classified by type, the mentee institutions participating in the integrity consulting program included two central administrative agencies, one metropolitan government, ten basic local governments, three local councils, two offices of education, and six public service-related institutions.

3. Achievements

Out of the 24 institutions that received integrity consulting in 2024, 18 (75.0%) institutions saw an increase in their ratings in the 2024 Comprehensive Integrity Assessment compared to last year's results. In particular, four organizations moved up two or more levels.

Section 3 Communication with Institutions of Various Levels through Public Institution Auditors Meetings

As an anti-corruption agency, the ACRC holds regular and ad hoc meetings each year with auditors at all levels of public institutions, including the central government, local governments, and public-related organizations, to guide the direction of the government's new anti-corruption and integrity policies and to discuss major issues and priority initiatives.

At the beginning of each year, the ACRC hosts a meeting to discuss the 'anti-corruption and integrity policy implementation tasks' to be promoted throughout the year, and shares information needed to promote integrity policies and philosophy on the direction of the Korean government's anti-corruption policy. It is used as an opportunity to communicate with each other. The ACRC also holds customized auditors' meetings on an ad hoc basis adjusting the agenda and scope of attendance to reflect emerging corruption issues and administrative social changes.

In 2024, the ACRC held a total of three auditor meetings to communicate with public institutions. These included two meetings in the first half of the year (February) to share the 2024 anti-corruption and integrity policy directions and tasks by institution type, and a meeting in the second half of the year (September) to discuss three key priority tasks for addressing corruption at the local frontline level.



In February, a task delivery meeting was held for five types of organizations: central administrative agencies, metropolitan municipalities, metropolitan and provincial offices of education, metropolitan council, public service-related organizations. Customized information required for each type of institution was provided, including main contents of the code of conduct for public officials such as the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act, Anti-Graft Act, system operation direction, and integrity competency support measures such as customized integrity education and integrity consulting, etc. In addition, through the task briefing sessions, the ACRC facilitated the introduction of exemplary anti-corruption and integrity policy cases implemented by the Ministry of SMEs and Startups and the Korea Disease Control and Prevention Agency. By sharing these cases with participating institutions, the ACRC promoted and encouraged further efforts to advance anti-corruption and integrity policies across various organizations.

◉ [Figure 2-8] 2024 Public Institution Auditors Meeting



* Source: News1, Yonhap News

In September, the ACRC held intensive discussions with public institutions responsible for local administration, such as metropolitan governments, provincial offices of education, and metropolitan councils, on strategies to strengthen fairness and transparency in local administration. In particular, the discussions focused on major strategies and policy directions for the second half of the year, including the newly expanded Comprehensive Integrity Assessment for all local councils in 2024, targeted inspections of vulnerable areas prone to financial leakage in local governments, improvements to corruption and unfairness factors in local ordinances, and the establishment of a fair recruitment framework for affiliated public institutions. The ACRC also gathered feedback from the field during these sessions.



Chapter 4.

Substantialization of Anti-Corruption Training to Foster a Culture of Integrity

Section 1 Enhancement of the Mandatory Education Management

Since the enforcement of the amended ACRC Act in September 2016, which requires public officials to undergo at least 2 hours of integrity training annually, the ACRC has been making efforts to enhance the effectiveness of integrity education by providing high-quality and tailored integrity training programs and by continuously managing the completion status of statutory training across all institutions. Consequently, the number of public officials who have completed integrity training since it became mandatory has been steadily increasing over the past three years: 1.74 million public officials in 2021, 1.76 million in 2022, and 1.76 million in 2023.

A survey conducted in 2024 revealed that 96.1% of all eligible public officials had completed their integrity training in 2023. This represents a 0.5%p increase in the completion rate from the previous year (95.6%). The participation rate among heads of institutions in integrity training, and the completion rate among high-level public officials also rose. The ACRC's efforts to strengthen the implementation of integrity education seem to have been effective, as special training for managers has been conducted based on the ACRC Act and the Enforcement Decree of the Act, which was amended in 2022.

In 2024, the ACRC provided guidance on the integrity education system to public institutions with limited access to integrity training, and conducted on-site inspections of newly established institutions, small-scale institutions with low training completion rates, and national and public universities. To address issues such as insufficient education budgets and lack of institutional interest among newly designated public-service related

institutions, the ACRC introduced the On-Site Anti-Corruption Education program. Under this initiative, ACRC officials visit institutions directly to provide all employees with training on anti-corruption laws and regulations, thereby strengthening preventive efforts against corruption through education.

Section 2 Realization of High-Quality Integrity Education through Diverse and Differentiated Approaches

1. Operation of the Integrity Academy to Enhance Integrity Awareness in the Public Sector

To create a clean and corruption-free society, the ACRC has not only enacted various anti-corruption laws such as the Improper Solicitation and Graft Act and the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act, but has also implemented diverse policies such as the Integrity Assessment and Corruption Risk Assessment to steadily improve perceptions of corruption within the public sector. However, with the advancement of digital technologies and the increasing complexity of corruption issues, it is now emphasized that, beyond establishing laws and systems, there is a growing need to enhance integrity awareness throughout society. Accordingly, the importance of anti-corruption and integrity education, aimed at preventing corruption and establishing individual values of integrity, is becoming even greater.

In line with such, the ACRC's Anti-Corruption Training Institute (ACTI), Korea's only specialized education and training institution for anti-corruption and integrity education, was established in October 2012. For the past decade, it has been dedicated to fulfilling its mission of "Fostering Integrity Leaders to Transform Korea" by providing professional integrity education to members across the public sector, including central government ministries, local governments, and affiliated public institutions. Through these efforts, the Institute has continuously worked to spread a culture of integrity within the public service.

Last year, the ACTI operated a variety of differentiated integrity education programs, including training courses tailored to each generation of public officials, from newly appointed officials to senior executives, as well as customized courses for sectors

vulnerable to corruption. It also newly developed programs that combined education with cultural content such as films and Taekwondo.

In addition, following the easing of COVID-19 restrictions, the Institute expanded in-person training programs and enhanced the accessibility of integrity education by introducing on-site integrity education courses for institutions and public officials who face difficulties visiting the Institute.

2. Support for Integrity Education through Diverse Educational Content and Expert Instructors

As interest in anti-corruption and integrity across society grows and major anti-corruption laws are newly enacted or amended, the demand for integrity education continues to rise. In response, the ACTI has expanded the foundation for public officials to access integrity education not only through programs directly provided by the Institute but also by training integrity education instructors, developing educational content, and operating online courses, thereby effectively addressing the increasing demand for education.

In addition, the ACTI operated skill enhancement training programs for integrity education instructors to disseminate the latest trends in anti-corruption policies and to enhance the teaching capabilities of professional instructors. In particular, with the emergence of generative AI and the growing recognition of AI literacy as a core competency for the future, the Institute organized and provided training sessions for integrity education instructors on the use of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT to strengthen public officials' capacity to respond to technological changes.

Meanwhile, to spread social consensus on integrity and enhance the effectiveness of integrity education, the Institute developed and distributed a variety of integrity education materials. First, in addition to producing a common textbook for public officials covering key anti-corruption laws and recent policy trends, the Institute developed standardized customized lecture materials tailored for six occupational groups—such as police officers, teachers, and researchers—where demand for integrity education is particularly high,



focusing on examples of violations that could occur in each profession.

The Institute also produced and distributed integrity education video content titled Integrity Channel ①. Integrity Channel ① is an educational video series that combines information and entertainment by using anti-corruption topics closely related to everyday life to spark intellectual curiosity and build public consensus. It is composed of three segments: the Book Channel, the Human Story Channel, and the Trend Channel, each focusing on books, people, and current trends, respectively. Anyone interested in integrity can access the content through the ACTI's website and the ACRC's YouTube channel "Anti-Corruption & Civil Rights Vision."

○ [Figure 2-9] Newly Developed Video Content (Integrity Channel ①)



In addition, to raise public interest and awareness about integrity, the ACTI produced and distributed 16 types of mobile emoticons featuring the Commission's mascots, Chung-begi and Gwon-igi. The emoticons, which conveyed various integrity messages such as preventing abuse of power and eradicating corruption, were distributed to 25,000 people in celebration of International Anti-Corruption Day (December 9).

○ [Figure 2-10] Mobile emoticons : Chung-begi and Gwon-igi



Finally, the Anti-Corruption Training Institute operated 35 online education courses using various platforms, such as Government e-Learning Platform for public officials and Integrity Learning Center for affiliated public institutions. The Institute also actively distributed its self-produced online educational content to institutions utilizing their own learning management systems to support independent training efforts. This year, a total of 1,732,852 public officials completed the ACTI's online courses.

Section 3 An Integrity Culture Embedded in Everyday Life, A Global Leader in Integrity

1. Operation of Integrity Education Program with Public Participation

To build an integrity-based society and advance as a leading nation in integrity, it is essential that not only the public sector but also all citizens work together. It is important for the general public—from students and young people who will lead the future of Korea to adults—to establish strong values of integrity and embed a culture of integrity into their daily lives.

To this end, the ACTI operated specialized education programs for elementary, middle, and high school students as well as university students and young people to foster integrity awareness among the future generation. It also held the Public Participation Integrity Content Contest, allowing citizens to directly participate in creating integrity-related content.

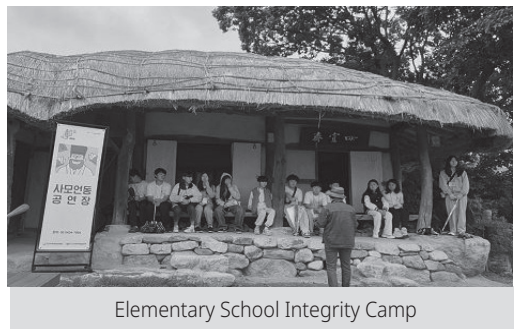
First, the Institute operated the On-Site Integrity Experience Classroom, a school-based education program that provided various participatory and experiential content, such as the Integrity Golden Bell quiz, to help students easily understand the concept of integrity. The scale of the Integrity Experience Classroom has expanded every year, and in 2024, it was held at 91 schools, an increase of 34 schools compared to the previous year, reaching a total of 11,472 students.

In addition, the Institute operated the Elementary School Integrity Camp, an experiential and activity-based education program where elementary students learn the value of integrity through outdoor activities such as visiting historical sites. Following a pilot operation (one session) last year, the camp was officially launched this year with two sessions. During the three-day, two-night camp, students were introduced to the stories of exemplary figures known for their integrity and engaged in various hands-on learning activities, allowing them to experience and internalize the value of integrity through all five senses.

○ [Figure 2-11] Integrity education program for elementary, middle and high school students



On-site Integrity Experience Classroom



Elementary School Integrity Camp

Second, the Institute operated the University Collaboration Integrity Special Lectures and the 2030 Integrity Talent Academy for university students and young adults to help them develop a strong sense of integrity as future members of society. Through the University Collaboration Integrity Special Lectures, linked to majors such as public administration and business administration, students were supported in establishing integrity as a key professional value. Additionally, through the 2030 Integrity Talent Academy, which included various participatory programs such as discussions on solving daily corruption

issues, young people were given opportunities to build their knowledge and awareness of integrity.

- [Figure 2-12] Integrity education program for university students and young adults



University Collaboration Integrity Special Lectures



2030 Integrity Talent Academy

Third, the ACTI held the Public Participation Integrity Content Contest to encourage citizens to creatively express everyday integrity through various forms such as writing and drawing, and to promote a culture of integrity by disseminating these works throughout society. This year, to mark the 10th anniversary of the contest, new categories such as slogans, short-form videos, posters, and drawings were added. A writing and drawing competition was also held at the Sejong Arboretum, where many citizens participated along with various side events, including magic shows and bubble performances.



○ [Figure 2-13] Public Participation Integrity Content Contest-writing and drawing competition



As a result, a total of 4,862 entries were submitted to this year's contest—approximately four times more than the 1,276 entries received last year. After evaluation by internal and external judges and the collection of public opinions, 46 works were selected as award-winning entries. The awards ceremony was held on December 12 at Kobaco Hall in the Korea Broadcasting Center and was also broadcast through the ACRC's YouTube channel, Anti-Corruption & Civil Rights Vision. During the ceremony, the winning piece in the writing category was read aloud by the child recipient, and the top video entry was screened. The event also featured celebratory performances, including a calligraphy show and a Taekwondo demonstration promoting integrity, which received an enthusiastic response from the audience.

○ [Figure 2-14] Award Ceremony for the Public Participation Integrity Content Contest



2. Support for Strengthening Anti-Corruption Capacity in Developing Countries through Education on Outstanding Anti-Corruption Systems

As Korea is recognized internationally as a successful model of both economic development and corruption reduction, there is growing global demand for Korea's anti-corruption and integrity policies. In response, the ACTI is strengthening Korea's international standing as a leading nation in integrity by operating a multi-country anti-corruption capacity-building training program for public officials from developing countries. As part of official development assistance (ODA) efforts, this program introduces Korea's outstanding anti-corruption systems to support the enhancement of integrity capacities in developing nations.

In 2024, the Institute expanded the scope of its multi-country anti-corruption capacity-building training programs by adding a new Spanish-language course for Central and South American countries, in addition to the English-language course for the Asia-Pacific and Africa regions and the Russian-language course for Central Asia. The Spanish-language course was conducted over nine days (September 3-11) in Sejong, Cheongju and Seoul and provided education to 15 participants, including public officials from four countries: Columbia, Peru, Bolivia, and Paraguay.

In addition, the ACTI conducted an English-language anti-corruption policy training course (April 15–24) for 14 public officials from five countries in the Asia-Pacific and Africa regions—Laos, Malaysia, Thailand, Ethiopia, and Egypt. It also conducted a Russian-language course for 15 public officials from anti-corruption agencies in three Central Asian and Eastern European countries—Azerbaijan, Uzbekistan, and Tajikistan. Through these programs, the Institute introduced Korea's outstanding anti-corruption systems to a total of 44 public officials from 12 countries this year.



○ [Figure 2-15] Operation of Anti-Corruption Capacity Building Training Programs



3. The Publication of an Academic Journal to Enhance the Expertise of Korea's Only Integrity Education Institution

The ACTI launched 「Kwonik」, a "public scholarly journal" in the fields of anti-corruption and citizens' rights, to raise social interest in integrity and public rights and to promote free and professional research by the public. The inaugural issue of 「Kwonik」 accepted research and written works from experts in various fields through a public call for papers and published a total of 10 articles on anti-corruption and citizens' rights after expert review and editorial board deliberation. The published papers covered a wide range of topics, including legal analyses of the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act and the Improper Solicitation and Graft Act, an in-depth study of whistleblower protection through analysis of case law and guidelines, and an analysis of how emotional labor caused by grievance handling impacts emotional exhaustion.



Part
03

Systematic Handling of
Corruption and Public Interest
Reports, and Protection of
Whistleblowers



Chapter 1. Promotion of Self-Discipline in Society through Handling of Reported Corruption and Public Interest Violations

Section 1 Operation of the Corruption and Public Interest Violation Reporting System

The Corruption Reporting System aims to protect the basic rights of citizens, ensuring the appropriateness of administration and establishing a transparent and ethical social atmosphere by preventing public officials from abusing their authority or violating laws and effectively regulating corruption acts as defined in the ACRC Act. The system was introduced under the Anti-Corruption Act, which was enacted on July 24, 2001, and enforced on January 25, 2002.

The Public Interest Violation Reporting System (Whistleblowing System) was introduced under the Public Interest Whistleblower Protection Act, enacted on March 29, 2011, and enforced on September 30, 2011. It is an effective means and a tool for stabilizing people's lives and build a transparent and clean society by protecting and supporting people who reports acts that infringe on the health and safety of the public, the environment, consumer interest, fair competition and the public interest corresponding thereto.

Reports are received by the Inspection Planning Division (Report Reception Team) and assigned to the relevant division in charge of handling the reported cases. They undergo the process of examination and verification by inspectors, review by the commissioner in charge, and then deliberation by the ACRC. If it is deemed necessary to conduct an audit under the Board of Audit and Inspection Act, the case is referred to the Board of Audit and Inspection. If there are suspicions of a crime or a need for investigation, it is referred

to investigative authorities. In other cases, it is referred to the supervisory body of the respective public institutions. When it is unclear whether the case should be referred or closed, the case is sent to the public institution if it is deemed appropriate for that institution to handle it.

The investigative agency to which the report is referred or forwarded should notify the ACRC of its findings within 10 days of completing the audit, investigation, or inspection. Upon receipt of the results of the audit, investigation or inspection, the ACRC should notify the reporter of the summary of the results and report the results to its internal committee. If the Commission deems that the audit, investigation, or inspection by the investigative organization is not sufficient, it may request the investigative agencies to re-investigate, citing reasonable grounds such as the submission of new evidence.

1. Receipt and Handling of Corruption Reports

The total number of cases of counseling and guidance related to corruption is 224,106. While there may be fluctuations from year to year, the overall shows an increase.

<Table 3-1> Counseling & guidance services by year

(unit : No. of cases, %)

Mode of use	Total		2002~2005	2006~2010	2011~2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2021	2022	2023	2024
		%													
Total	224,106	100.0	25,406	27,090	41,732	11,104	10,884	12,312	14,465	14,004	12,952	12,952	13,000	13,972	14,233
Phone call	174,387	77.8	16,381	22,590	37,210	9,719	10,014	11,082	11,479	10,200	8,765	8,765	8,870	9,894	9,418
Internet	36,878	16.5	4,147	3,074	2,640	1,001	485	676	2,342	3,177	3,512	3,512	3,821	3,840	4,651
Visitation	12,841	5.7	4,878	1,426	1,882	384	385	554	644	627	675	675	309	238	164

* The number of counseling and guidance services offered through fax, mail, and in-person meeting is included in the number of the "visitation" category

From January 25, 2002, when the former Korea Independent Commission Against Corruption was launched, until the end of December 2024, a total of 98,063 reports were submitted with an average of 356 per month.

<Table 3-2> Corruption reports received by year

(unit : No.of cases)

Category	Total	2002~ 2005	2006~ 2010	2011~ 2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
No.of cases	98,063	7,988	11,585	17,186	3,758	4,066	7,328	9,435	6,103	9,690	7,300	6,853	6,771
Monthly average	356	167	193	287	313	339	610	786	506	808	608	572	565

During the same period, a total of 98,063 cases were received, and 97,949 cases were addressed from January 25, 2002 until the end of December 2024.

<Table 3-3> Status of reports handled

(unit : No.of cases)

Category	Total	Referral	Notification of violation of code of conduct	Forwarding to public institutions	Closed
Report Handling	97,949	3,635	1,691	16,257	76,366

The number of referral cases totaled 3,635, and as of December 2024, the rate of confirmation of charges in 3,394 cases except for 241 on which investigation and inspection were underway was 72.4%.

<Table 3-4> Referral to investigative agencies by year

Category	Total	Notification of investigation result			Under investigation	Corruption detection rate [(2)/(1)]
		Sub-total①	Corruption detected②	Acquitted		
Total	3,635	3,394	2,458	936	241	72.4

A total of 2,458 cases were investigated, leading to the prosecution of 5,685 individuals and disciplinary action against 5,600 individuals. The detection of corruption resulted in the collection and recovery of approximately KRW 900.3 billion.

<Table 3-5> Result of notification by investigative agencies

(unit : No.of cases)

Category	Prosecution/discipline, etc.(persons)				Institutional warning (cases)	Other (cases)	Amount to be collected or recovered (KRW 1 million)
	Total	Prosecution	Discipline	Accusation/dismissal from office			
Total	11,397	5,685	5,600	112	251	1,158	900,388

* The number does not include 241 cases under investigation by investigative agencies

2. Receipt and Treatment of Public Interest Violation Reports

From September 30, 2011, when the Public Interest Whistleblower Protection Act was enforced to the end of December 2024, a total of 54,326 whistleblowing disclosures were reported to the ACRC. By type, health violations such as the manufacture of harmful food and the sale of unlicensed drugs accounted for the highest proportion of 18,068 cases (33.3%), followed by safety violations such as poor construction and the failure to install firefighting facilities, with 8,601 cases (15.8%).

<Table 3-6> Public interest reports received by the ACRC by year

(unit : No.of cases)

Category	Total	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
No.of cases	54,326	292	1,153	2,887	9,130	5,771	2,611	2,521	3,923	5,164	5,546	4,531	3,266	3,005	4,526
Monthly average	328	97	96	241	761	481	218	210	327	430	462	378	272	250	377

Meanwhile, in 2024, the number of public interest reports received by the ACRC was 4,526 a decrease of 50.6% from the previous year. The ACRC handled 54,073 cases out of total 54,326 public interest reports since the enactment and implementation of the Act, including referring 28,131 cases to investigative and prosecutorial agencies.

<Table 3-7> Handling of public interest reports by the ACRC

(unit : cases)

Category	Sector	Handling Classification			
		Subtotal	Referred	Forwarded	Closed
	Total	54,073	3,078	25,053	25,942
2011~ 2017	Sub-total	23,975	607	13,549	9,819
	Public health	10,649	308	9,150	1,191
	Public safety	3,740	95	2,615	1,030
	Environment	2,246	145	781	1,320
	Consumer interest	1,155	43	710	402
	Fair competition	382	16	212	154
	Others	5,803	0	81	5,722
2018	Sub-total	3,952	37	943	2,972
	Public health	836	15	403	418
	Public safety	686	11	344	331
	Environment	153	8	61	84
	Consumer interest	224	1	64	159
	Fair competition	198	2	70	126
	the equivalent public interest	1	0	1	0
	Others	1,854	0	0	1,854
2019	Sub-total	5,165	388	2,187	2,590
	Public health	1,047	154	710	183
	Public safety	877	121	571	185
	Environment	546	23	433	90
	Consumer interest	609	73	396	140
	Fair competition	147	17	72	58
	the equivalent public interest	10	0	5	5
	Others	1,929	0	0	1,929
2020	Sub-total	5,563	629	2,975	1,959
	Public health	1,791	322	1,288	181
	Public safety	1,324	153	993	178
	Environment	365	40	294	31
	Consumer interest	571	104	336	131
	Fair competition	96	8	46	42
	the equivalent public interest	28	2	18	8
	Others	1,388	0	0	1,388

Category	Sector	Handling Classification			
		Subtotal	Referred	Forwarded	Closed
2021	Sub-total	4,782	432	1,621	2,729
	Public health	1,893	275	764	854
	Public safety	414	46	248	120
	Environment	158	2	122	34
	Consumer interest	400	99	215	86
	Fair competition	242	5	220	17
	the equivalent public interest	75	5	52	18
	Others	1,600	0	0	1,600
2022	Sub-total	3,262	483	1,069	1,710
	Public health	648	305	267	76
	Public safety	234	14	185	35
	Environment	323	1	310	12
	Consumer interest	438	157	189	92
	Fair competition	91	4	67	20
	the equivalent public interest	67	2	51	14
	Others	1,461	0	0	1,461
2023	Sub-total	3,031	296	836	1,899
	Public health	570	153	336	81
	Public safety	192	2	148	42
	Environment	112	5	84	23
	Consumer interest	345	135	143	67
	Fair competition	76	0	59	17
	the equivalent public interest	82	1	62	19
	Others	1,654	0	4	1,650
2024	Sub-total	4,343	206	1,873	2,264
	Public health	576	113	375	88
	Public safety	1,049	13	894	142
	Environment	280	5	235	40
	Consumer interest	388	72	233	83
	Fair competition	76	1	55	20
	the equivalent public interest	141	2	71	68
	Others	1,833	0	10	1,823

Out of 25,722 cases notified to the ACRC by investigative and law enforcement agencies since the enforcement of the Act, 12,336 cases (48.0%) were found to have corruption-related allegations, and appropriate actions were taken: prosecution and accusation (3,514 cases), fine (260 cases) and penalty surcharge and administrative fine (2,516 cases).

<Table 3-8> Result of cases referred/ forwarded to investigative agencies

(unit : No.of cases)

Investigation result on referred/forwarded cases					Action taken					
Result notification status				Under inspection/ investigation by another agency	Prosecution	Accusation	Fine	Penalty surcharge	Administrative fine	Others
Total (D=F+G)	Suspicion confirmed (F)	Confirmation rate (F/D)	Acquitted (G)							
25,722	12,336	48.0%	13,386	2,409	2,081	1,433	260	1,095	1,421	7,473

Section 2 Handling Reports of Fraudulent Claims for Public Funds

Measures at a cross-government level to address irregularities causing financial losses in the welfare sector and eradicate fraudulent welfare benefits were discussed. As a result of that, the "Joint-Government Center for Welfare Fraud Reporting" was established within the ACRC on October 15, 2013 to conduct comprehensive oversight and management as well as regular on-site inspections by collectively handling reported fraudulent payments in the welfare sector prevailing across ministries. After that, on December 2014, in the "Comprehensive Plan for Combating the Illegal Receipt of National Subsidies", the subsidy reporting and monitoring systems, which were scattered among ministries, were centralized under the ACRC. The center was reorganized into the "Center for Reporting Welfare and Subsidy Fraud," which is entitled to handle the reports on subsidy frauds as well as welfare frauds on January 16, 2015.

Afterwards, on May 1, 2023, in order to carry out comprehensive and integrated work to eradicate fraudulent claims of public funds, the "Public Funds Recovery Division", which is an integration of the existing "Public Funds Recovery System Division" and the "Center for Reporting Welfare and Subsidy Fraud" has been newly launched and is operating the public funds recovery system and handling reports of unlawful receipts, etc.

Since October 2013, a total of 13,551 cases of fraudulent receipt of public subsidy were received, of which 13,445 cases (99.2%) were handled, and 4,347 cases, representing 32.3% of the handled cases, were referred or forwarded to investigative and supervisory agencies.

In 2024, 1,381 cases were received, and 1,414 cases were handled. Of which 324 cases were referred/forwarded to investigative/ supervisory agencies and 1,090 cases were closed.

<Table 3-9> Reports received and handled (as of Dec.31, 2024)

(unit : No.of cases)

Year	Reports received	Reports handled			
		Total	Referred	Forwarded	Closed
Total	12,170	12,031	1,680	2,343	8,008
2024	1,381	1,414	73	251	1,090
2023	1,600	1,532	58	319	1,155
2022	1,467	1,520	13	433	1,074
2021	1,598	1,639	62	575	1,002
2020	1,187	1,205	299	313	593
2019	1,537	1,527	321	225	981
2018	1,446	1,428	265	227	936
2017	960	892	168	66	658
2016	593	582	192	22	368
2015	861	865	198	64	603
2014	776	740	103	78	559
2013	145	101	1	21	79

Of the 4,347 cases referred/forwarded cases from October 2013, investigations have been completed on 3,960 cases, resulting in findings of alleged improper receipts in 2,815 cases (71.1%), and KRW 197.4 billion in unlawful receipt were recovered and returned.

<Table 3-10> Suspicion confirmed in referred/ forwarded cases (Oct. 2013~Dec.2024)

(unit : No.of cases)

Referred/ forwarded	Investigation completed (result notified)			Under investigation by investigative agency
		Suspicion confirmed	Acquitted	
4,347	3,960 (Redemption of 197.4 billion decided)	2,815 (71.1%)	1,145 (28.9%)	387



Chapter 2.

Effective Protection and Reward for Whistleblowers

Section 1 Strengthening of the Whistleblower Protection and Reward System and Improvement of Awareness

1. Strengthening the Protection and Reward System for Whistleblowers of Corruption and Public Interest Violations

The ACRC has continuously enhanced the relevant legal and institutional frameworks to ensure that individuals can report acts of corruption and public interest violations with confidence, and that they receive reliable protection and support from the state following such reports.

The major amendments to the Act on the Protection of Public Interest Whistleblowers in 2024 include, first, the establishment of a legal basis for supporting legal assistance costs for internal whistleblowers. The Enforcement Decree of the Act further specifies the procedures for the payment of legal assistance costs and the criteria for recovering such costs if they are received through improper means. Additionally, not only the ACRC but also other public interest whistleblowing agencies are now required to inform whistleblowers about protection and support measures at various stages, such as upon receiving a report or notifying the result of its handling.

Second, to promote public interest reporting, the previous cap of KRW 3 billion on public interest whistleblower rewards was abolished. Additionally, when the ACRC exercises the right of subrogation after providing relief payments, a legal basis was established to allow the Commission to access property-related information of the person responsible for the damage or cost.

Third, to address protection gaps caused by the emergence of new types of public interest violations, 22 additional laws closely related to the public interest and with a high need for whistleblower protection were added to the scope of public interest reporting. The newly added laws include the Special Act on the Prevention of Illegal Trafficking in Narcotics, the Act on the Protection of Financial Consumers, and the Act on the Management of Local Government Subsidies, among others.

2. Efforts to Unify Whistleblowers Protection and Reward Systems

Currently, the ACRC oversees five anti-corruption laws (Anti-Corruption Act, Public Interest Whistleblower Protection Act, Act on the Recovery of Public Funds, Conflict of Interest Prevention Act, and Improper Solicitation and Graft Act), each of which regulates whistleblower protection and support differently due to differences in their enactment timelines. To address issues such as disparities in protection and support levels among whistleblowers and inefficiencies in system operation, the ACRC is pursuing legislative improvements aimed at ensuring that whistleblowers receive the same level of protection and support under any of these laws. This initiative seeks to enhance public predictability regarding the application of the laws and restore trust in the system.

3. Promoting Anonymous Proxy Reporting for Internal Whistleblowing

Since the ACRC introduced the Anonymous Reporting through Attorney Representation system in October 2018, which allows public interest whistleblowers to file reports under an attorney's name instead of their own to protect their identity, the number of cases using this system has been steadily increasing. When first introduced, there were only 2 cases, but the number rose significantly to 77 cases in 2023 and 91 cases in 2024. In particular, the ACRC operates a "Non-Real Name Proxy Report Advisory Lawyer Group" with around 100 members to provide free assistance to whistleblowers who may face penalties for reporting.



4. Efforts to Improve Public Perception through Events such as 'Public Interest Whistleblowing Day'

In 2018, the ACRC declared December 9, the UN-designated “World Anti-Corruption Day,” as “Public Interest Whistleblowing Day” to raise the self-esteem of whistleblowers and promote positive awareness of whistleblowing and celebrated the 6th anniversary of Public Interest Whistleblowing Day in 2024.

The ACRC awarded commendations to individuals from related organizations who actively cooperated and participated in whistleblower protection and support efforts. Outstanding cases and experiences encountered while handling whistleblower protection and support duties were shared by the award recipients. In addition, the ACRC invited actual public interest whistleblowers and academic experts to deliver special lectures aimed at advancing the protection and support of whistleblowers, thereby fostering a broader public consensus on the importance of reporting corruption and protecting whistleblowers.

5. Providing Tailored Training on Whistleblower Protection and Support Systems

Recently, grievances are being filed through various channels such as e-People and the internal reporting centers of each institution, and the number of corruption and public interest violation reports submitted in the form of grievances has also been increasing. However, during the handling of these reports, issues have arisen where the confidentiality of whistleblowers was not properly protected. In response, the ACRC sought to prevent breaches of whistleblower confidentiality in advance by providing practical training focused on key points and precautions to be checked at each stage of the receipt and processing of corruption and public interest reports, as well as by sharing actual cases of confidentiality breaches and offering guidance on necessary precautions.



Section 2 Protection of Corruption and Public Interest Whistleblowers

1. Significance of the System

Whistleblowers who report wrongdoing and corruption conducted covertly within an organization often face a high risk of retaliation and may be perceived as informants or traitors, encountering significant difficulties in continuing their careers within the organization. Therefore, the purpose of the whistleblower protection system is to create an environment where anyone can report wrongdoing without fear by actively ensuring the confidentiality and employment status protection of whistleblowers, thereby effectively preventing corruption and public interest violations.

2. Key Contents

A. Whistleblower protection system for reporting corruption

The subjects of corruption reporting include acts of corruption as defined in Article 2, Paragraph 4 of the ACRC Act, as well as violations of the Code of Conduct for Public Officials under Article 67 of the same Act.

Individuals are eligible for protection if they report acts of corruption to the ACRC, investigative agencies, the Board of Audit and Inspection, the public institution to which the accused belongs, or public institutions that supervise the accused's organization, association, or company. Protection also extends to individuals who testify before the National Assembly or the courts, or who file complaints or accusations with investigative agencies. In addition to the whistleblower, those who assist in the audit, investigation, or inquiry related to the report—such as by providing statements, testimony, or submitting relevant materials—are also protected.

A whistleblower must submit a signed written report that includes their personal information, the purpose and reason for the report, and must present evidence related to the subject of the report and the corrupt act. Alternatively, a whistleblower may file an



anonymous report through attorney representation with the ACRC by appointing a lawyer to report on their behalf without disclosing their identity. However, reporting persons are not protected if the persons knew the report was false, or if the report was made for a fraudulent purpose, such as to solicit money or employment preferences.

The whistleblower protection system for reporting corruption is composed of confidentiality protection, employment status protection, and personal safety protection. Confidentiality protection prohibits disclosing, exposing, or reporting a whistleblower's personal information or any facts that could lead to their identification. Employment status protection ensures that whistleblowers are not subjected to dismissal, disciplinary action, or any other disadvantage because of their report. Personal safety protection provides measures to prevent harm to the whistleblower's physical safety resulting from their reporting activities.

B. Public interest whistleblower protection system

Acts of public interest violation subject to reporting are acts detrimental to public health and safety, the environment, consumer interest, fair competition, and public interest equivalent thereto as defined in Article 2(1) of the Public Interest Whistleblower Protection Act, which are subject administrative disposition such as penalty or cancellation of license or permission or injunction, etc. according to 495 applicable laws (as of Mar. 20, 2025). Any person who reports or provides information on public interest violations to investigative agencies (administrative or supervisory agencies that have the authority to guide, supervise, regulate, or investigate acts detrimental to the public interest), prosecutorial or law enforcement bodies, the ACRC, or the head of the institution where the violation occurred, or who offers an investigation clue, are eligible for protection.

In addition to whistleblowers, individuals who assist by providing statements, testimony, or materials in relation to public interest reports and the investigations, prosecutions, lawsuits, or whistleblower protection measures arising from such reports are also protected. However, if a whistleblower knowingly files a false report or reports with an improper purpose, such as demanding money, favors, or employment advantages, they are not eligible for protection.



The public interest whistleblower protection system consists of measures to prevent disadvantageous actions such as dismissal or disciplinary measures due to public interest reporting, to restore the original status by canceling any disadvantageous actions that have already occurred, to protect the personal safety of whistleblowers, and to guarantee the confidentiality of whistleblowers by prohibiting the disclosure or reporting of their identity without their consent.

3. Performance of Protection Activities

From 2011 to 2024, there were a total of 2,113 handled cases in which corruption and public interest whistleblowers of their cooperators who requested protection. The acceptance rate of protection requested by corruption reporters reached 58.3% and by public interest whistleblowers reached 54.1%.



<Table 3-11> Corruption and public interest reporters protection by year

(unit : cases)

Year	Protection of corruption reporters						Protection of public interest reporters					
	Total	Guarantee of position	Protection of personal safety	Identity disclosure	Temporary suspension	Mitigation of culpability	Total	Guarantee of position	Protection of personal safety	Identity disclosure	Prohibition of disadvantageous measures	Mitigation of culpability
Total	929	649	55	174	32	19	1,184	575	131	262	74	142
2011	9	9	0	0	0	0	6	2	0	2	2	0
2012	25	19	2	4	0	0	9	3	3	1	1	1
2013	27	20	3	4	0	0	19	15	1	2	0	1
2014	22	14	4	4	0	0	13	1	2	8	1	1
2015	21	15	3	3	0	0	13	8	0	4	1	0
2016	15	15	0	0	0	0	20	12	2	4	2	0
2017	9	8	1	0	0	0	28	13	2	7	1	5
2018	38	25	0	10	3	0	53	27	8	8	3	7
2019	106	68	6	21	11	0	131	65	17	28	9	12
2020	107	75	6	19	7	0	125	67	12	29	4	13
2021	126	94	4	23	5	0	126	63	8	28	9	18
2022	107	74	5	21	4	3	137	63	10	28	10	26
2023	129	84	8	30	1	6	229	109	23	58	8	31
2024	188	129	13	35	1	10	275	127	43	55	23	27

Section3 Reward for Corruption and Public Interest Whistleblowers

The reward system for whistleblowers is to provide monetary rewards to whistleblowers who have contributed to the promotion of the public interest or have directly resulted in the recovery or increase of revenues or reduction in public expenses. It serves as an effective means of preventing corruption and public interest violation by incentivizing the voluntary participation of individuals who take courageous actions, despite various risks.

1. Award System

If a report results in significant financial benefits to a public institution, prevents financial losses, or promotes the public interest, the whistleblower may be recommended for an award under relevant regulations, such as the Act on Awards and Decorations, either through a public institution's recommendation or by the Commission's own initiative. If the criteria for payment are met, an award of up to KRW 500 million may be granted.

2. Reward System

Unlike monetary awards, monetary rewards are paid upon the application of the whistleblowers if there is a direct recovery of revenue of a public institution as a result of the report. For public interest reports, there is no limit on the reward amount (for reports filed on or after August 7, 2024). For reports related to acts of corruption, reward of up to KRW 3 billion may be paid.

<Table 3-12> Annual payment of rewards

(unit : cases, KRW 1,000)

Year	Corruption reporters			Public Interest reporters		
	Cases	Benefits incurred*	Rewards paid	Cases	Benefits incurred*	Rewards paid
2015	29	28,770,531	1,426,658	511	1,988,446	379,997
2016	90	23,997,537	2,275,033	2,476	8,344,742	1,603,578
2017	113	26,539,641	2,108,374	1,710	11,198,923	1,976,511
2018	166	36,836,590	3,114,994	277	66,077,269	2,213,658
2019	197	28,364,346	2,312,974	211	22,254,652	1,534,593
2020	238	46,003,611	3,842,099	249	25,258,924	1,560,901
2021	485	40,862,696	3,397,868	138	10,312,828	811,290
2022	480	17,922,028	2,863,390	99	48,536,415	2,255,828
2023	601	40,482,944	4,055,806	45	15,080,041	813,790
2024	231	24,704,633	2,664,528	55	47,775,708	1,149,733
Total	2,630	314,484,557	28,061,724	5,771	256,827,948	14,299,879

* The value of the recovered or increased revenues of the State or local governments through a report. The amount of rewards is calculated based on it.

3. Relief Fund System

Relief funds may be provided to cover expenses incurred in physical and mental treatment, moving service or litigation procedures, and the amount of lost wage during the period of disadvantageous measures faced by the whistleblower, cooperator or others in connection with the report.

4. Major Cases

A. Reward for reporting construction cost fraud through substandard work

A whistleblower reported companies that had embezzled construction costs by using methods such as improperly installing formwork during public construction projects. Thanks to the report, around KRW 44 million in fraudulently obtained funds were recovered, and approximately KRW 187 million in project expenses were saved. As a result, the whistleblower was paid reward of about KRW 56 million.

B. Reward for reporting embezzlement of national R&D funds

The whistleblower reported company representatives who received research funding for an existing project and fraudulently applied again for the same project. Based on the report, about KRW 240 million was recovered. The whistleblower received approximately KRW 72 million in reward.

C. Reward for reporting illegal rebates by a pharmaceutical company

The whistleblower reported a pharmaceutical company that gave cash, gifts, and entertainment to medical staff at hospitals, clinics, and health centers. As a result of the report, a fine of KRW 500 million was imposed. The whistleblower was paid about KRW 60 million in reward.





Chapter 3.

Promotion of the Public Fund Recovery System

With the expansion of public funds and the continuous occurrence of cases involving fraudulent claims and receipt of public funds, the ACRC pushed for the establishment of a general law regarding the recovery of and sanctions on the fraudulent claim of public funds from 2014. As a result, the Act on the Prohibition of False Claims for Public Funds and Recovery of Illicit Profits (“Public Funds Recovery Act”) was enacted on April 16, 2019, and finally came into effect on January 1, 2020.

It is mainly regarding four types of false claims of public funds such as subsidy, reward, and contribution. The types are as follows: ① Claiming public fund payments without legitimate qualifications, ② claiming excessive amounts of such payments, ③ using the fund for a purpose or usage other than specified purposes, and ④ falsely receiving such funds. The Act stipulated that the administrative authority should impose and collect an additional monetary sanction of up to five times the value of relevant illicit profits where there exists such as false claim.

Under the Act, competent administrative authorities should announce a list of illegal beneficiaries who have falsely claimed large amount of public funds or who have committed false claim of public funds several times. The ACRC entitled to the inspection of the progress of the public institutions’ recovery of falsely-claimed public funds and imposition of additional monetary sanctions. The Act also requires the ACRC to establish strict protection measures for those who report such false claim cases such as guarantee of their positions and protection of personal safety, to promote active reporting of false claims of public funds and pay them monetary rewards.

In 2024, the Public Fund Recovery Act was amended on March 26 to strengthen the punishment of fraudulent claims, enhance the protection and rewards for whistleblowers, and ease unnecessary regulations. The following are the main contents of the amendments: (1) in the case of mistaken payments that are not attributable to the unlawful beneficiary, the interest charge is exempted upon repayment; (2) excluding public schools from unlawful beneficiary; (3) imposing interest by applying the Public Funds Recovery Act when other laws have provisions for recovering underpayments but do not have provisions for recovering interest; (4) even if a fraudulent claim is voluntarily reported and all illicit gains are returned before the administrative agency issues a prior notice for recovery, if the investigation has already begun, a 50% reduction will apply instead of granting a full exemption of the penalty surcharge; (5) adding a new provision on criminal punishment for both fraudulent claimants and payer (false claim: imprisonment for up to 3 years or a fine of up to KRW 30 million, and overbilling: imprisonment for up to 1 year or a fine of up to KRW 10 million); (6) introduction of non-real name proxy reporting; (7) establishment of a relief fund system. The revised law has been in effect since September 27, 2024.

Since the enforcement of the Public Fund Recovery Act in 2020, the ACRC has regularly conducted inspections on the fraudulent receipt of public funds, including government grants from central administrative agencies, local governments and local education autonomous entities. As a result, the amount of recoveries and additional monetary sanctions imposed have been gradually increasing.

<Table 3-13> Result of inspections on the status of recovery of public funds, imposition of monetary sanctions, etc.

(unit : KRW million)

Year	Recovery	Monetary sanctions
2020	45,425	263
2021	95,473	9,855
2022	114,988	18,563
2023	110,790	41,459
First half of 2024	53,993	10,843
Total	420,669	80,983

The Public Funds Recovery & Management Division conducts surveys to identify vulnerable areas of frequent fraudulent receipts and problems in the field and prepare measures to eradicate illicit profits. In 2024, the ACRC conducted on-site inspections on the use of the Dam Vicinity Area Support Fund, which is intended to support income generation and improve living infrastructure for residents near dams. As a result, improper use totaling about KRW 4.2 billion was uncovered in seven local governments, and the ACRC demanded the recovery of the misused funds as well as improvements to the relevant system.

The ACRC also made efforts to ensure that public institutions strictly manage and punish fraudulent claims on public funds. In 2024, after analyzing the results of implementation inspections, the ACRC recommended imposing penalty surcharges totaling approximately KRW 22.2 billion—the largest amount recommended since the law's enforcement—against 64 local governments that had failed to impose sanctions in cases related to electronic social service vouchers (e-vouchers).

※ (2020) KRW 400 million → (2021) KRW 300 million → (2022) KRW 3.1 billion → (2023) KRW 10.1 billion
→ (2024) KRW 22.2 billion

To improve understanding of the Public Fund Recovery System and to strengthen its overall implementation, the ACRC, marking the fifth year since the enforcement of the Public Fund Recovery Act, carried out tailored training programs and consulting services for various institutions. In 2024, the Commission conducted regional integrated training sessions across six regions, reaching 1,162 participants; provided customized training for specific groups, including 791 principals of public schools and kindergartens; held consultation meetings with 11 provincial and metropolitan offices of education and workshops with 17 institutions; and offered consulting to three institutions with low performance in detecting or recovering fraudulently obtained funds. As a result of these efforts to enhance the capacity of administrative agencies to prevent fraudulent claims, the number of training participants increased by 230% compared to the previous year, from 740 to 2,451. Meanwhile, the ACRC carried out wide-ranging public outreach efforts to raise public awareness about fraudulent practices related to public fund claims. Press releases and media briefings were issued on key occasions, and various platforms—including radio, card

news, and YouTube—were used to share information on major types of fraudulent claims, the results of implementation inspections, and the strengthened penalties introduced through recent legal amendments.

In 2025, marking the sixth year of the enforcement of the Public Fund Recovery Act, the ACRC plans to ensure that the system takes firm root in society and brings about a fundamental shift in public awareness and behavior regarding fraudulent claims.

The Commission will conduct year-round public awareness campaigns in collaboration with relevant agencies and will strengthen on-site inspections to prevent the leakage of public funds that should be used for supporting vulnerable groups and fostering new growth engines. In addition, the ACRC will carry out thorough investigations and handling of reported cases and actively encourage recovery efforts by institutions through implementation monitoring.





Chapter 4.

Operation of the System to Restrict the Employment of Public Officials Dismissed for Corruption Charges

Public officials who have rightly resigned, or have been dismissed or removed from office for corrupt acts in connection with their duties during the term of their offices are prohibited from getting employment at public institutions or for-profit companies closely related to the department or institution to which they belonged from five years before their resignation, for five years after the date of resignation. The employment restriction system for public officials dismissed for corruption was introduced in the Corruption Prevention Act in 2001. The scope of individuals and institutions subject to the employment restriction was significantly expanded in accordance with the revision of the applicable law in March 2016. The ACRC identifies violators employed in restricted institutions by conducting regular inspections on the employment status of public officials who have been dismissed for corruption and reviewing rule violations of those who got employed.

Over the past five years (2019-2023), a total of 1,144 public officials were dismissed for corruption. Among them, the most common type of corruption was a receipt of money, entertainment, or other valuables, with 425 cases, followed by 262 cases of embezzlement and misappropriation of public funds, 81 cases of abuse of authority or dereliction of duty and 47 cases of document forgery or counterfeiting. An additional 329 were dismissed for other reasons (leaking official secrets and violation of statutes related to budget and finances).

<Table 3-14> Dismissal of public officials by type

(unit : persons)

Type of corruption	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	Total
Receipt of money, entertainment	129	91	72	70	63	425
Embezzlement or misappropriation of public funds	65	49	53	43	52	262
Abuse of authority or dereliction of duty	15	12	20	12	22	81
Document forgery or counterfeiting	11	9	10	8	9	47
Others	90	55	59	69	56	329
Total	310	216	214	202	202	1,144

In inspection on the employment of former public officials who have resigned, been dismissed or removed due to corruption, the ACRC detected 63, 46, 53, 34, and 47 violators of the employment restriction provision in 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 respectively. For those caught for unauthorized reemployment, the ACRC requested their former organizations to take prosecution or precautionary measures to prevent a recurrence, while for those who are still working, the ACRC requested that measures be taken to terminate their employment or dismiss them.

This is a three-to four-fold increase from 16 individuals who were detected in the inspection in 2017. It can be attributable to the amendment to the Corruption Prevention and the ACRC Act in September 2016, which expanded the scope of institutions subject to employment restriction on former public officials. (Among the violators of the employment restriction provision, the number of those who were hired by entities related to their former public duties was 2 in 2015, 3 in 2016, 11 in 2017, 31 in 2018, 40 in 2019, 29 in 2020, 32 in 2021, 17 in 2022 and 30 in 2023)

In 2024, the ACRC strengthened the operation of the employment restriction system by expanding on-site inspections to supplement detailed document verification regarding the relevance of public officials' previous duties to their new employment at public institutions. To resolve issues related to employment restrictions for individuals dismissed for misconduct, the Commission held advisory meetings and discussions with experts and relevant agencies, thereby securing the effectiveness of confirming violations of employment restriction regulations.

To systematize the operation of the employment restriction system in public institutions and improve understanding of the system, the ACRC held integrated regional briefing sessions for public officials in charge of integrity and audit work (6 regions, 1,162 participants in total).

In addition, marking the 20th anniversary of the implementation of the employment restriction system for individuals dismissed for misconduct (introduced in January 2002), the ACRC conducted a policy study to analyze the system's achievements and limitations. Based on this analysis, the study aimed to redesign the current legal framework and establish a foundation for operating the employment restriction system in a more systematic and rational manner.

The policy study for improving the employment restriction system was conducted in collaboration with the Korea Research Institute for Local Law from August 26 to December 31, 2024. The main focus areas included an analysis of the system's performance and issues over the past 20 years, the development of redesign plans for the relevant legal framework (including laws, enforcement decrees, and administrative guidelines), and strategies for advancing institutional reform.

To ensure the effective implementation of future system improvements and to minimize trial and error during the reform process, the ACRC gathered a wide range of opinions from academia, the legal community, and other experts while developing the legal redesign plan. These efforts were aimed at formulating a rational and well-founded strategy for improving the employment restriction system.



In the future, the ACRC plans to carry out preventive activities in various ways to prevent the violations of employment restriction regulations. To this end, public institutions at all levels will be required to inform persons dismissed for corruption, etc. of the employment restriction system without delay.

The ACRC is considering a number of ways to identify persons dismissed for corruption who are not on the list, including identifying those who are subject to pension restrictions due to dismissal or criminal penalties. This will ensure that in the future, public institutions will be more thorough in identifying and notifying the ACRC of persons dismissed for corruption, including any changes to the original disciplinary action.

The ACRC will also strengthen employment fact-finding inspections of persons dismissed for corruption, including in sectors with high potential for public-private ties, and will conduct in-depth reviews of violations, including the relevance of work between the organization where the person was employed before leaving and the organization where the person is reemployed.

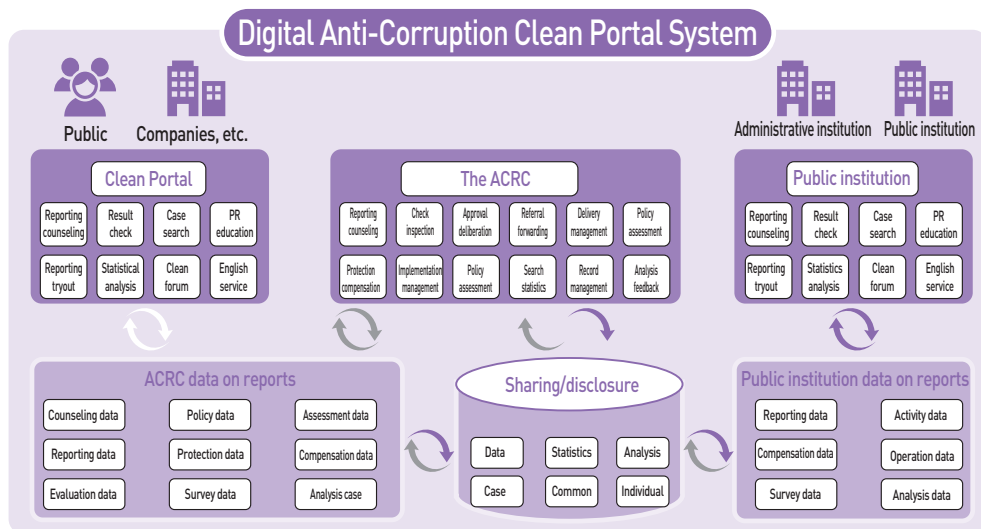


Chapter 5.

Innovation of Anti-Corruption Work by Advancing Clean Portal System

The Clean Portal_Corruption and Public Interest Violation Reporting System is a comprehensive anti-corruption information platform that allows people to conveniently make online corruption reports and easily search for necessary anti-corruption information. In 2018, the ACRC completely overhauled its corruption reporting system, known as the Corruption Prevention System, which had been in operation since 2003, to provide a one-stop service for anti-corruption work procedures, ranging from customized reporting for different types of users to applications for protection and rewards. This also led to the establishment of a common platform for anti-corruption officers to handle relevant tasks promptly and accurately by supporting the sharing and disclosure of anti-corruption information.

• [Figure 3-1] Digital Anti-Corruption Clean Portal System



In 2020, the existing "National Integrity Information System" was renamed "Clean Portal_Corruption reporting system" to make the public clearly aware of the functions of the Clean Portal, and a standardized reporting system was disseminated to public institutions to provide convenience to the public. As of December 2024, a total of 1,196 organizations use the Clean Portal, including 54 central administrative agencies, 250 local governments, and 892 public service-related organizations. In addition, an analytical foundation has been laid to enable the ACRC and public institutions to utilize intelligence and information technology in their anti-corruption work based on the establishment and dissemination of the Clean Portal system and the anti-corruption information accumulated therefrom.

In line with the enforcement of the Conflict of Interest Prevention Act on May 19, 2022, the ACRC opened the service which enables mandatory reporting by public officials and violation reports by the public. As of December 2024, 2,184 institutions are using the system. Furthermore, as the scope of non-real name proxy reporting has been expanded, the ACRC has enhanced the convenience of reporting by enabling the submission of non-real name proxy reports, which were only accepted offline, through the Clean Portal.

In 2024, the ACRC held system briefing sessions on the Clean Portal for Kosovo and Mongolia as part of the UNDP project to promote the overseas expansion of the portal. The ACRC also introduced the portal's functions to visiting officials from Thailand. Additionally, through a KOICA government ministry proposal project, the establishment of the PACO II anti-corruption reporting system in Colombia was confirmed and is scheduled to begin in 2025.

The Clean Portal will continue to be stabilized through annual surveys of users to collect their opinions for improvement, conduct maintenance, and continuously improve functions. From 2025 to 2027, the ACRC plans to promote the export of the Clean Portal to Colombia as well. The Commission will continue its efforts to share its expertise in building and operating the Clean Portal's reporting system with the international community.



Part
04

Protecting People's Rights and
Interests by Addressing
Grievances with a Focus on
Real-Life Problems



Chapter 1. Grievance Petition Handling System

1. Overview of Grievance Petition

Definition

The term “civil petition for grievance” means a civil petition for the redress of a grievance pertaining to matters that infringe the rights of the people, or give any inconvenience or burden to people, due to unlawful, irrational or passive disposition (including factual act and omission) of an administrative agency, etc., or the irrational administrative system. (Article 2(5) of the ACRC Act)

A. General civil petition and grievance petition

Article 2 of the Civil Petitions Treatment Act divides complaints into a general civil petition and a grievance petition. The Act defines the former while stating that the definition of “grievance petition” is in accordance with the ACRC Act. A general petition is a legal civil petition applying for authorization, permission, approval, patent, license, registrations, certifications, etc. to administrative agencies, an inquisitive civil petition requesting an explanation of statutes, regulations, or systems, and a recommendatory civil petition requesting the improvement of administrative systems and operations. A grievance petition is a secondary complaint filed by a person dissatisfied with the outcome of a general civil petition.

In principle, a grievance petition should be handled by the audit department of the original processing organization or a supervisory body with authority over the matters related to the grievance. However, they may be handled directly by the ACRC as it serves as the final complaint-handling body within the administration. In addition, unlike the audit

department and supervisory body of the original processing agencies, the ACRC as the national Ombudsman, investigates and handles civil petitions through its dedicated unit and authority. The Ombudsman receives grievances from the public regarding public administration, conducts impartial investigations, and issues corrective recommendations or opinions when necessary. It also mediates and arbitrates disputes between citizens and administrative agencies, and improves administrative practices to enhance government trust and public satisfaction.

B. Recommendation of rectification and expression of opinions on unlawful or unjust administrative actions

If there are reasonable grounds to believe that a disposition taken as a result of an investigation into a grievance petition is unlawful or unjust, the ACRC recommends that the relevant administrative agency rectify it. Additionally, if it is deemed that the argument of a petitioner is based on reasonable grounds, the Commission expresses its opinion to the relevant administrative agency to take corrective action.

C. Recommendation for institutional improvement and expression of opinions on unreasonable laws and systems

If it is deemed necessary to improve laws or regulations, systems, policies, etc. in the course of processing grievance petitions, the ACRC recommends the heads of relevant administrative agencies to make rational improvements or expresses its opinions, thus preventing the same kind of complaints from recurring.

D. Settlement and mediation of grievance petitions between the petitioner and the respondent as a third party

The ACRC acts as a third-party mediator and arbitrator between the petitioner and the respondent to reach an amicable settlement or to mediate and arbitrate public conflicts involving multiple parties. Especially for a grievance petition that involves multiple people or that is recognized as having a high social impact, the mediation is a form of alternative dispute resolution (ADR)¹⁾



Features of the ACRC grievance process

- Republic of Korea's National Ombudsman
- The final grievance authority in the government
- Performing indirect administrative control functions by making corrective recommendations and expressing opinions
- Help desk for government policies and affairs
- Quick, easy and flexible processing from a third-party, non-bureaucratic perspective

2. Cooperation, Support, and Training for the Local Ombudsman

As a national ombudsman²⁾, the ACRC supports local government in establishing and operating Local Ombudsmen and provides them with the Commission's know-how and information on handling grievance petitions to help the Local Ombudsmen fulfill their role of protecting and promoting the rights and interests of local residents.

3. Comprehensive Evaluation of Civil Service of Administrative Agencies

Every year, the ACRC, in collaboration with the Ministry of the Interior and Safety, conducts a comprehensive evaluation of civil service to improve the civil service of local governments, offices of education, etc. and visits each institution to provide consultation on resolving grievance petitions and group conflicts to help improve inadequate civil service practices.

1) Alternative Dispute Resolution: A process of bringing disagreeing parties for dispute settlement with the help of a fair and neutral third party -except for the court- without resorting to litigation

2) Ombudsman: A system that originated and developed in the Nordic countries of Sweden, Finland, Denmark, and Norway. An ombudsman is a person who has been appointed as a representative of the public to monitor whether a public institution is properly fulfilling its statutory responsibilities.



Chapter 2. Receipt and Handling of Grievance Petitions

1. Overview

Receiving, examining, and processing grievance petitions are key duties of the ACRC to protect people's rights and interests. The ACRC examines civil petitions seeking redress for grievances related to matters that violate the public rights or causes of inconvenience or burden to the public, stemming from unlawful, irrational, or passive disposition of an administrative agencies or from irrational administrative system. It recommends corrective measures or expresses opinions to the relevant administrative agencies, and resolves grievance petitions through mediation and settlement.

In 2024, the ACRC received 42,917 grievance petitions and handled 42,549 cases. The acceptance rate indicating the resolved grievance petitions was 29.6%, increased by 0.9%p from the previous year. Meanwhile, satisfaction score for grievance complaints decreased by 2.2 points, indicating that efforts are needed to improve complaint satisfaction.

<Table 4-1> Receipt and handling of grievance petitions

Category	2022	2023	2024
No. of cases received	37,739	44,390	42,917
No. of cases handled	37,598	42,581	42,549

<Table 4-2> Acceptance rate and satisfaction score of grievance petitions

Category	2022	2023	2024
Acceptance rate	25.7%	28.7%	29.6%
Satisfaction score	76.7 points	80.1 points	77.9 points

2. Current Status of Corrective Recommendation/Expression of Opinions

A. Processing status

The ACRC resolved a total of 585 cases in 2024, including 170 corrective recommendation and 415 expressions of opinions based on Articles 46 and 47 of the ACRC Act.

<Table 4-3> Status of corrective recommendation and expression of opinions

Category	2022	2023	2024
Corrective recommendation	224	181	170
Expression of opinions	368	336	415

B. Efforts to improve the acceptance rate of corrective recommendation and expression of opinions

The resolution of the ACRC has an “advisory effect” and is not enforceable. This is intended to provide a broad and flexible remedy for people's grievances by complementing litigation, which is a rigid means of compulsory resolution. If the decisions made by the ACRC were to have binding forces, it would require strict legal judgments such as litigation, to handle a civil petition, which could undermine the protection of the rights and interests of the public instead. In addition, if a specific factual investigation and logical judgment are made, most respondents are willing to accept without legal compulsion. Even if they express their intention to refuse, the ACRC continues to persuade them, taking responsible management efforts until the grievance petition is resolved.

For example, the ACRC confirms and inspects the actual status of compliance with recommendations under Article 52 of the ACRC Act, and holds grievance resolution cooperation meetings for institutions with a high number of unaccepted cases, aiming to diagnose and analyze the cause of unacceptance and find alternatives, together with administrative agencies such as the ACRC, the relevant institutions and competent ministries. The ACRC will continue to make efforts to protect people's rights and interests by direct and indirect efforts to improve acceptance of corrective recommendations and feedback.





Chapter 3.

Complaint Handling to Increase Public Perception

1. Overview

Since 2003, the ACRC has been operating the Onsite Outreach Service, visiting sites directly to consult and receive grievances. The service targets regions with poor access to administrative services, such as rural areas, islands, and remote regions, as well as vulnerable groups including the elderly, persons with disabilities, and marriage immigrants. Through on-site consultations and grievance resolution, the ACRC has worked to reduce regional and social inequalities.

From 2003 to 2024, the Onsite Outreach Service visited local governments 1,192 times (si/gun/gu) and consulted 30,920 grievances. Since 2012, the Onsite Outreach Service has been operating as a one-stop comprehensive counseling channel for citizens to consult and resolve their daily inconveniences in collaboration with related organizations¹⁾ such as the Korea Legal Aid Corporation, the Korea National Council on Social Welfare and the Small Enterprise and Market Service.

In addition, since 2018, the ACRC has operated a dedicated team for handling corporate grievances to actively protect the rights and interests of small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) and small business owners. Starting in September 2024, the ACRC established the On-site Grievance Investigation Division to further enhance on-site, field-oriented administration. Through this new division, the ACRC is working to resolve

1) Collaborative organizations: Korea Legal Aid Corporation, Korea National Council on Social Welfare, Korea Consumer Agency, Korea Land and Geospatial Information Corporation, Korea District Heating Corporation, Small Enterprise and Market Service, Credit Recovery Committee, Korea Inclusive Finance Agency

grievances of vulnerable groups left in blind spots of administrative services and to coordinate the resolution of complex corporate grievances involving multiple ministries and agencies.

In particular, the ACRC has continuously held On-site Meeting for business grievance, where the head of the Commission visits companies facing difficulties, such as enterprises run by persons with disabilities and social enterprises, to listen to and resolve their grievances. For suggestions regarding the improvement of unreasonable regulations and other policy or institutional issues, the ACRC actively promotes reforms by forming consultative bodies with relevant agencies.

※ No. of meetings held : (2018) 16 → (2019) 12 → (2020) 7 → (2021) 12 → (2022) 13 → (2023) 12 → (2024) 12

2. Onsite Outreach Service for Eliminating the Blind Spots in People's Rights and Interests

A. Operation and role of the Onsite Outreach Service

The Onsite Outreach Service is a system that provides consultation and receives civil complaints. It is designed for the ACRC to visit island, remote and rural areas whose residents have difficulty getting consultation on civil complaints due to limited internet access, lack of time or other reasons as well as those in need.

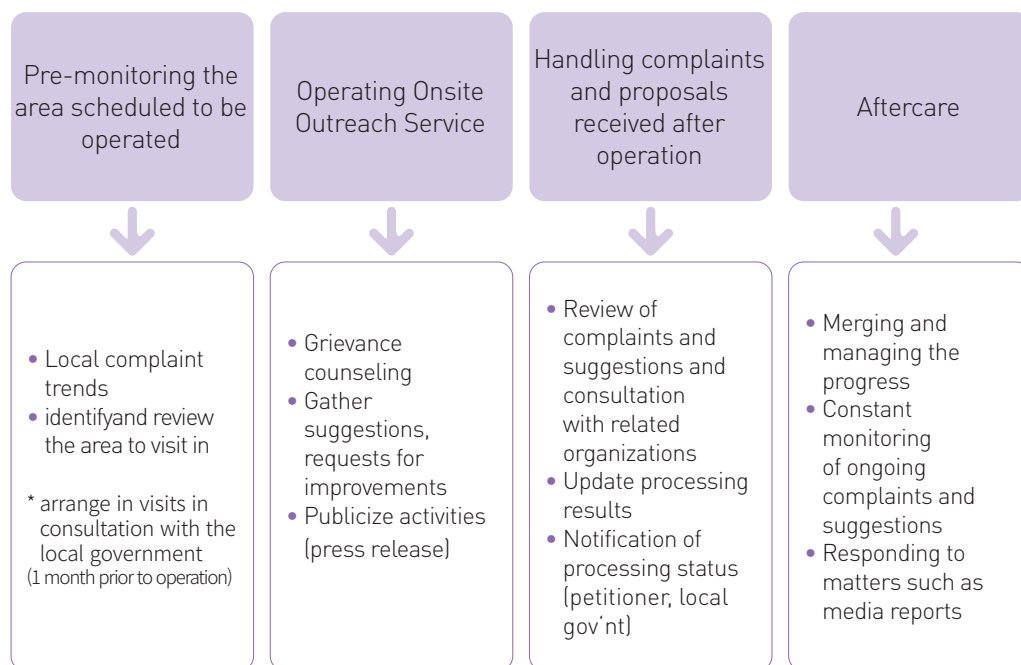
In addition, the ACRC serves as a communication and resolution channel for identifying collective grievances and local pending issues, gathering diverse voices from the regions, and reflecting them in policymaking. Since 2016, the Commission has also been implementing the Welfare Blind Spot Identification and Support Project, which identifies crisis households—those with special circumstances who are in urgent need of financial assistance but are unable to receive government support—and provides them with emergency living expenses.

*Cases include households where individuals were unable to receive living support because their names were misused to falsely indicate real estate ownership, or because a husband engaged in income-generating activities during divorce proceedings or separation.



Among the civil complaints filed through the Onsite Outreach Service, those that can be settled on the spot are resolved immediately by coordinating the disagreement between the civil petitioner and the administrative agency concerned. Those that require further investigation are submitted as grievance petitions to the ACRC, and it investigates and resolves them according to the procedure.

<Table 4-4> Operation and grievance resolution procedure for Onsite Outreach Service



B. Operation performance of the Onsite Outreach Service

The ACRC operated the Onsite Outreach Service 105 times in 2024, counseling a total of 2,140 complaints. 1,358 complaints (63.5%) were received, of which 189 cases (13.9%) of them were resolved on the spot through mutual agreement.

<Table 4-5> Operation performance of the Onsite Outreach Service

(unit : cases)

Category		Total	2003~2007	2008~2012	2013~2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Frequency (times)		1,192	55	178	292	84	101	78	91	104	104	105
[Regional]		590	55	140	146	33	36	33	31	40	40	36
[Tailored]		602	-	38	146	51	65	45	60	64	64	69
Consultation record	Total	30,920	1,543	6,441	8,928	2,163	2,519	1,511	1,482	1,929	2,264	2,140
	Complaint Submission (on-the-spot agreement)	8,089 (2,823)	541 (-)	2,088 (1,206)	2,079 (919)	370 (130)	346 (135)	264 (54)	247 (41)	356 (57)	440 (92)	1,358 (189)
	on-the-spot consultation (closed)	22,831	1,002	4,353	6,849	1,793	2,173	1,247	1,235	1,573	1,824	782

[Operation of the Onsite Outreach Service]



Regional Onsite Outreach Service in Yeosu-si
(May 22, 2024)



Tailored Onsite Outreach Service in Mokwon University
(September 5, 2024)

In 2024, through the Welfare Blind Spot Identification and Support Project, the ACRC identified a total of 49 crisis households and provided KRW 49 million in emergency living expenses.

<Table 4-6> Support status by sponsoring organization

(unit : household, KRW 10,000)

Category	Total	Korea Racing Authority (KRA)	GKL	LX	Korea Rural Community Corporation	Korea National Oil Corporation
Supported Households	49	20	10	9	5	5
Support Amount	4,900	2,000	1,000	900	500	500

<Table 4-7> Support status by type

(unit : household)

Total	Young Caregivers	Children-Youth	Female Heads of Household	Elderly Living Alone	Extremely Poor Households*
49	3	11	8	6	21

*Households facing financial hardship due to illness or disability, households requiring emergency relief due to disasters- such as fires or accidents, and extremely poor households resulting from fraud, bankruptcy, and similar causes.

C. Way forward

The Onsite Outreach Service will be continued by visiting all corners of the country to resolve complaints from marginalized areas and vulnerable groups. In addition, the Onsite Outreach Service will do its best to solve the business difficulties of small business owners in small and medium-sized cities in the countryside, which are experiencing economic difficulties due to population decline, high prices and high interest rates, and the difficulties of young people in job seeking and starting a business.

3. On-site Meeting for Business Grievance

The ACRC has been operating the "on-site meeting for business grievance" to provide practical support to companies that reflects the on-site voices of the people. To this end, the ACRC visits companies, SMEs, and small business owners located in industrial and agricultural industrial complex across the country to identify their grievances and difficulties, and seeks multi-dimensional solutions with relevant organizations.

In 2024, 12 on-site meetings for business grievance were held, and a total of 159 complaints were received, 90 of which were resolved by taking necessary measures through investigations by related organizations or by providing guidance on related systems.

<Table 4-8> 2024 Status of on-site meeting for business grievance

Date	Target	Date	Target
Feb 2	Gwangju Flower Farming Cooperative Corporation	Jul 26	Products Manufactured by Severely Disabled Persons
Feb 23	Gyeongsan Knowledge Industry District	Aug 27	Agricultural Corporation
Mar 26	Companies Run by Persons with Disabilities	Oct 15	Women CEOs in the Design Industry (Honam Region)
Apr 23	Hwasun Biopharmaceutical Industrial Complex	Oct 31	Gwangju Advanced Green Industrial Complex
May 24	Port-Related Industries in Busan	Dec 6	Cosmetics Manufacturing Industry
Jun 19	Small Business Owners at Lotte Department Store, Masan Branch	Dec 16	Foreign-Invested Companies

In order to support the establishment of a strong growth environment for SMEs, small business owners, etc. and to enhance the vitality of corporate activities, the ACRC will continue its efforts to resolve various difficulties in a timely manner through collaboration with relevant ministries, and guide businesses to government policies that meet their needs.



Chapter 4.

Efforts to Further Protect People's Rights and Interests

1. Overview

As mentioned earlier, a grievance petition is a secondary complaint filed by a person who is dissatisfied with the outcome of a general civil petition (court, inquiry, suggestion, etc.). Here, the term “secondary” is not a numerical indication of a sequence or order but it is used to signify dissatisfaction or objection, and the secondary complaint itself may be filed several times. At this point, the petitioner’s dissatisfaction is at its peak, so the investigators of the ACRC are simultaneously tasked with resolving the grievance and improving the satisfaction level.

First, in order to resolve collective complaints that are difficult to resolve due to the involvement of multiple agencies and complex interest, and that take long time to resolve even if resolved in a professional manner, the ACRC is working toward the enactment of the Act on the Mediation of Collective Grievances.

Second, in cooperation with the Ministry of the Interior and Safety, the ACRC conducts the annual Overall Civil Complaint Service Evaluation to enhance the grievance-handling capacity of local governments and offices of education, and to improve citizen satisfaction.

Third, the ACRC supports the establishment of local ombudsmen to promptly and fairly resolve complaints arising from local governments, and for those that have already been established, to revitalize their operations.

Last, to improve the quality of complaint handling by each organization and the ACRC

investigators, the ACRC continues to conduct capacity-building training, sharing resolved complaint cases and disseminating methods for handling unusual and repeated complaints.

2. Mediation of Collective Grievances to Smoothly Resolve Complex Conflicts

A. Promotion status

In our society, there is an increasing awareness of people's rights, and a maturing perception of civil society participation, along with rapid economic growth. As a result, public conflicts with complex interests and significant scale are gradually intensifying. The number of collective grievances filed with the ACRC has been increasing every year.

The ACRC actively utilizes the mediation system as a policy tool to promptly and fairly resolve grievances that involve a large number of people or have a significant social impact, effectively resolving various types of public conflict.

In the past, there were many simple types of collective civil petitions involving conflicting interests between a single administrative agency and a single village or group but in recent years, there has been an increase in the number of "complex disputes" involving multiple agencies such as the central government, local governments, and public institutions. These disputes not only occur between residents and administrative agencies but also involve conflicts between residents themselves and between administrative agencies.

The number of mediation resolutions and mediation resolution ratio compared to the number of collective complaints received have been on a declining trend, but achieved the highest mediation resolution rate in the past five years in 2024. This is a result of the ACRC's efforts to focus its organizational capacity on coordinating and resolving collective grievances, including the establishment of a dedicated collective grievance investigation team in March 2023 and the assignment of veteran investigators with extensive experience and know-how to the team.



<Table 4-9> Progress in resolving grievance complaints through mediation

Category	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Receipt of collective complaints	299	310	317	384	407
No. of cases resolved through mediation	53	41	33	63	81
Rate of resolution through mediation	17.7	13.2	10.4	16.4	19.9

Collective civil petitions tend to arise from conflicts of interest among parties in the pursuit of public interest projects, budgetary limitations of relevant organizations, and institutional limitations imposed by laws and regulations, rather than from unlawfulness or unfairness of an administrative agency's decision. Thus, there are considerable difficulties in resolving them through a conventional grievance-handling method. Therefore, it can be said that the mediation of the ACRC is firmly established as an alternative means of dispute resolution that seeks optimal agreement through communication and compromise among the parties involved.

In response to increasingly complex and diverse collective civil complaints, the ACRC is strengthening practical consultations by conducting more proactive field investigations, persuading stakeholders, and organizing a mediation council consisting of relevant organizations and experts. And the chairperson and members of the ACRC are doing their best to come up with win-win mediation solutions by visiting the sites and listening to residents' grievances. It also focuses on strengthening publicity such as media reports on good solutions, mediation systems and their effects. This is expected to build public trust in the mediation system, resulting in an increase in the number of collective civil complaints requiring mediation and prompt resolution by the ACRC, thereby fostering a virtuous cycle.

B. Major cases of on-site mediation of collective civil complaints

One of the most notable mediation cases resolved in 2024 involved the "Request for Safety Measures in Rock Blasting at the Geomdan Housing Development District." A conflict had arisen between Korea Land and Housing Corporation (LH) and 3,128 residents during the large-scale rock removal process discovered in the midst of the Geomdan New Town development project in Incheon. Thanks to the mediation efforts of the ACRC, the dispute was resolved approximately one year after the grievance was filed.

During foundation work for the Geomdan New Town housing development in Incheon, LH discovered a large rock formation measuring approximately 17m³ and planned to remove it using blasting methods. However, around 2,600 households living in nearby apartment and villa complexes, which surround three sides of the rock in a "U"-shaped layout, expressed concerns about potential damage to their homes, as well as noise, vibration, and dust caused by the blasting. Despite repeatedly filing complaints with LH and other parties, the issue remained unresolved. As a result, in May 2023, 3,128 residents, led by the chairman of the Emergency Committee Against Blasting, turned to the ACRC for help.

The ACRC conducted multiple on-site inspections and held discussions with related agencies. However, the gap between LH, which insisted that blasting was unavoidable, and the emergency committee, which argued that construction should not proceed until safety was ensured, made resolution difficult. Over the course of a year, the ACRC worked to develop a coordinated plan that all parties could accept, through additional test blasts, geological surveys, and resident briefings. It was agreed that the outer section of the rock would be removed using non-blasting methods, while the core would be removed using a 50-50 mix of blasting and non-blasting techniques. Noise and vibration monitors would be installed on the rock, and a public watchdog recommended by the emergency committee would be assigned. In the event of damage such as housing cracks, construction would be halted immediately at the request of the committee. A professional agency selected by the committee would then conduct a detailed investigation, and repairs or compensation would be provided based on the findings.



Collective grievances involving a clash between safety and efficiency are difficult to resolve. However, the ACRC succeeded in reaching a core agreement between LH and the emergency committee of “construction would proceed with the residents' safety as the top priority.” This resolved the conflict and allowed construction—suspended for nearly two years—to resume.



Geomdan New Town rock blasting safety grievance site



On-site mediation meeting for the "Request for Safety Measures in Rock Blasting at Geomdan Housing Development District" collective grievance (June 13, 2024)

The second major mediation case involved resolving the difficulties of a village where Hansen's disease patients had suffered from livestock odors for decades. The applicants were residents of Yeongmin Village, a Hansen's disease settlement in Yeonggwang County, Jeollanam-do. They settled there around 1974 with the help of the Catholic Archdiocese of Gwangju. They made a living through livestock farming and other means. Now, with an average age of 80, all have closed their businesses. Most of them now rely on government support for their livelihood.

In January 2020, the Catholic foundation granted land use rights to external pig farming operators. Subsequently, Yeonggwang County approved the legalization of the livestock facilities. This led to a significant worsening of odor-related issues for the Hansen's disease residents. Numerous complaints were raised as the stench intensified. As living conditions deteriorated severely, the residents of Yeongmin Village turned to the ACRC, requesting intervention to address the livestock odor problem.

The ACRC prepared a mediation plan to protect the rights of the Hansen's disease residents. This plan was developed through multiple site inspections, stakeholder consultations, and public feedback. Yeonggwang County agreed to carry out rural and village environment improvement projects, while temporarily allowing pig farming only until the projects commence, under strict management to reduce and control odors. The Catholic Archdiocese of Gwangju, as the landowner, promised to actively cooperate with the environmental improvement efforts and conditionally lease the land to pig farmers for a limited time, provided they make efforts to address odor issues until the project is completed. Meanwhile, the livestock operators within the settlement agreed to improve their operations to minimize unpleasant smells.

This mediation played a meaningful role in resolving conflicts caused by livestock odors in the village. It laid the foundation for improving the living conditions and quality of life for the Hansen's disease residents, who have long endured hardship without stable livelihoods, while facing social prejudice and discrimination.



On-site Visit for Collective Complaint Resolution: Odor Conflict in Yeonggwang County Hansen's Disease Settlement (July 3, 2024)



On-site Mediation Meeting for Collective Complaint: Odor Conflict in Yeonggwang County Hansen's Disease Settlement (July 3, 2024)

The third major mediation case involved a collective complaint from residents affected by noise from the Boryeong Air Force Daechon Firing Range. Through the intervention of the ACRC, the long-standing hardships of the residents of Gatbae Village—who had suffered for 65 years—were finally addressed. In December 2023, residents of Gatbae Village,

located near Daecheon Beach in Boryeong, visited the ACRC's On-site Outreach program during its stop in Boryeong, Chungcheongnam-do, to file their collective petition and share their grievances.

The Daecheon Firing Range has been used for live-fire exercises since 1960, initially by U.S. forces. Since 1991, the Republic of Korea Air Force has been stationed there, and the Army, Navy, Air Force, and U.S. Forces Korea have conducted training at the site for about 100 days each year. As the only surface-to-air firing range owned by the South Korean military, it holds significant strategic importance. However, due to the intense and year-round training activities, local residents have had to endure shooting noise and related disturbances for 65 years.

The ACRC developed a mediation plan after conducting multiple on-site inspections and holding consultations with relevant agencies and local residents. During this process, an official from the Presidential Office led a working-level meeting with directors and division heads, enabling all involved parties to work together and resolve the conflict amicably. The Air Force Headquarters and the Air and Missile Defense Command agreed to create a buffer zone around the Daecheon Firing Range to reduce the impact on residents and initiated a research project to assess relocation needs. Moreover, Chungcheongnam-do Province and Boryeong City committed to participating in the study and providing administrative and financial support for the relocation and compensation of Gatbae Village residents.

Thanks to the active mediation efforts of the ACRC, residents who had long endured hardship were given new hope. At the same time, the stable management of the Daecheon Firing Range—the only surface-to-air firing site in South Korea—helped ensure continued training operations, contributing to the strengthening of national security.





On-site Mediation Meeting for Collective Complaint:
Noise Damage from Boryeong Air Force Daechon Firing Range (November 28, 2024)

3. Provision of Civil Complaint Services that Satisfy the Public

The ACRC, in collaboration with the Ministry of the Interior and Safety, conducts a "comprehensive evaluation of civil service" every year to check and inspect the handling of civil complaints at various levels of agencies in order to improve the quality of public services provided by administrative agencies.

In 2024, a total of 307 organizations were evaluated, including 47 central administrative agencies, 243 local governments, and 17 offices of education, and the evaluation indicators were as follows.

<Table 4-10> Evaluation indicators of the 「2024 Comprehensive Evaluation of Civil Service」

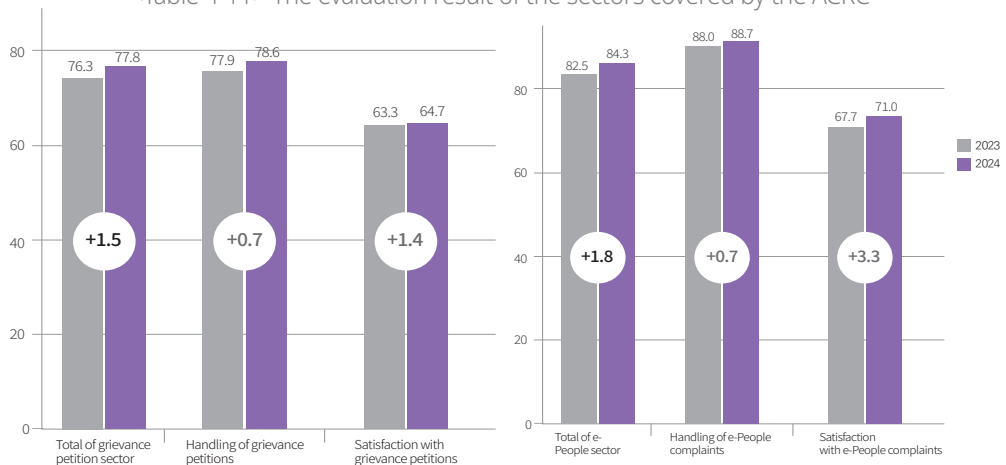
Evaluation areas	Evaluation items(5)	Evaluation indicators	Evaluator
Civil complaint administration activities	Handling of grievance petitions	1) Efforts to handle grievance petitions 2) Efforts to resolve grievance petitions 3) Management and inspection of grievance petition 4) Activation of local ombudsman	The ACRC
	Handling of e-People complaints	1) Speed of handling complaints 2) Fidelity of response to civil complaints 3) Appropriateness of handling complaints 4) Efforts to improve civil complaint administration	
	Operation of civil complaints system	1) Provision of civil complaint information and operation of civil complaint laws 2) Monitoring and reviewing the status of civil complaints and record of personal data training 3) Civil complaint administration and institutional improvement 4) Reorganization of civil complaints and reduction of required documents 5) Adherence to the legal complaint processing deadline	Ministry of Interior and Safety
Management basis for civil complaint administration	Civil complaint administration strategy and system	1) Suitability of establishing civil complaint administration and institutional improvement plan 2) Performance of civil complaint administration by the head of an agency 3) Civil complaint administrative management organization 4) Protection of vulnerable complainants and civil complaint officers	
Civil complaint handling performance	Satisfaction	1) Satisfaction with legal complaints 2) Satisfaction with e-People complaints 3) Satisfaction and credibility of grievance petitions	Common

In 2024, the overall average score of the 「comprehensive evaluation of civil service」 was 84.4: 87.2 for central administrative agencies, 92.8 for provincial offices of education, 85.8 for metropolitan municipalities, and 80.2 for basic local governments. The average score for the sectors covered by the ACRC was 77.8 (1.5 ▲) for grievance petitions and 84.3 (1.8 ▲) for e-People complaints, both of which improved from 2023.

In particular, the satisfaction with grievance petitions (64.7 points, 1.4 ▲) and the satisfaction with e-People (71.0 points, 3.3 ▲), which were surveyed among complainants, improved year- on-year, showing the effectiveness of the customer service improvement.

Meanwhile, the newly introduced Grievance Credibility Score recorded 59.5 points this year, relatively low compared to its satisfaction levels. This indicates a need to enhance credibility by ensuring fairness in procedures and the rationality of the grounds for decisions.

<Table 4-11> The evaluation result of the sectors covered by the ACRC



The ACRC publishes the results of its annual comprehensive evaluation of civil service in the media to encourage voluntary efforts by administrative agencies to improve their civil service, and actively supports the strengthening of their capacity to handle civil complaints by providing rewards to outstanding agencies and consulting services to those that are not up to par.

In fact, of the 46 organizations that received customized consulting in 2024 due to

underperformance in their 2023 assessment, a total of 39 (84.8%) saw their rankings increase by an average of 15 or more positions.

The ACRC will continue to thoroughly monitor the quality of civil complaint services across all administrative agencies. It also plans to make ongoing efforts—such as providing consulting support—to help improve the overall quality of public service delivery.

4. Invigoration of Local Ombudsman to Strengthen the Rights and Interests of Local Residents

The ACRC recommends the establishment of a Local Ombudsman, an independent complaint-handling body with expertise to promptly and fairly resolve grievances against local governments and their affiliated organizations.

The legal grounds for the establishment of the Local Ombudsman in Bucheon-si for the first time in 1997 were prepared by the Act on the Establishment and Operation of the Local Ombudsman enacted in 2005. As of December 2024, 94 local governments (11 metropolitan and 83 basics) were operating the Local Ombudsman.

<Table 4-12> Status of establishment and operation of the citizens' grievance mediation committee

- **[11 Metropolitan/Provincial Governments]** Seoul Metropolitan City, Daegu Metropolitan City, Gwangju Metropolitan City, Ulsan Metropolitan City, Gyeonggi-do, Gangwon Special Self-Governing Province, Chungcheongnam-do, Jeollanam-do, Jeonbuk Special Self-Governing Province, Jeju Special Self-Governing Province, Sejong Special Self-Governing City
- **[83 Local Governments]** **[Seoul]** Gangdong-gu, Gangbuk-gu, Gangseo-gu, Gwanak-gu, Gwangjin-gu, Guro-gu, Geumcheon-gu, Nowon-gu, Dobong-gu, Dongdaemun-gu, Dongjak-gu, Mapo-gu, Seodaemun-gu, Seocho-gu, Seongdong-gu, Seongbuk-gu, Yangcheon-gu, Yongsan-gu, Eunpyeong-gu, Jongno-gu, Jung-gu, Jungnang-gu, **[Busan]** Saha-gu, **[Incheon]** Gyeyang-gu, Michuhol-gu, Seo-gu, Yeonsu-gu, Jung-gu, **[Daegu]** Dalseo-gu, Dong-gu, Buk-gu, **[Gwangju]** Gwangsan-gu, Nam-gu, Buk-gu, Seo-gu, **[Daejeon]** Daedeok-gu, Seo-gu, Jung-gu, **[Ulsan]** Nam-gu, Buk-gu, Jung-gu, Ulju-gun, **[Gyeonggi]** Gwacheon-si, Gwangmyeong-si, Gwangju-si, Namyangju-si, Dongducheon-si, Bucheon-si, Seongnam-si, Suwon-si, Siheung-si, Ansan-si, Anseong-si, Anyang-si, Yangju-si, Yeosu-si, Yeoncheon-gun, Yongin-si, Uiwang-si, Icheon-si, Paju-si, Pyeongtaek-si, Pocheon-si, Hanam-si, Hwaseong-si, **[Gangwon]** Wonju-si, **[Chungnam]** Gongju-si, Dangjin-si, Boryeong-si, Asan-si, Cheonan-si, Buyeo-gun, **[Chungbuk]** Jecheon-si, Cheongju-si, Yeongdong-gun, **[Jeonnam]** Suncheon-si, Yeosu-si, Goheung-gun, Damyang-gun, Hwasun-gun, **[Jeonbuk]** Iksan-si, **[Gyeongnam]** Yangsan-si, **[Gyeongbuk]** Sangju-si

※ Establishment Status: (2015) 20 → (2016) 26 → (2017) 30 → (2018) 37 → (2019) 43 → (2020) 49 → (2021) 62 → (2022) 70 → (2023) 80 → (2024) 94

In 2020, the ACRC established operational guidelines for the National Council of Grievance Mediation Committees to create an institutional platform for policy discussions and the exchange of opinions with citizens' grievance committees. Based on this framework, the ACRC held the first National Council meeting in March 2021. Since then, annual meetings have been held through 2024, providing a forum for collecting feedback on policies and systems aimed at strengthening the role of the committees, and for discussing mutual cooperation. These efforts have supported continued collaboration and exchange among citizens' grievance mediation committees nationwide.

<Table 4-13> Overview of the national council of grievance mediation committees

- ▶ [Council] A consultative body between the Anti-Corruption and Civil Rights Commission (ACRC) and Citizens' Grievance Mediation Committees.
- ▶ [Composition] Chairperson of the ACRC and the lead representatives of each Citizens' Grievance Mediation Committee
 - ※ Co-chairs: ACRC Chairperson (ex officio) and a committee representative (elected)
- ▶ [Functions] Consultation on matters such as information sharing and cooperation for committee activation, collecting feedback on policies and systems, and providing consulting and training to enhance committee capabilities
- ▶ [Meetings] Held once a year (regular), with additional sessions (as needed)
- ▶ [Support] Allowance and travel expenses may be provided within budget limits

In addition, to facilitate the sharing of information related to the Citizens' Grievance Mediation Committees, the ACRC has established a centralized information portal on its official website. This portal provides access to local government ordinances on the establishment and operation of grievance committees, examples of grievance resolutions, and operational updates. Through these efforts, the ACRC continues to actively support the establishment and enhancement of Citizens' Grievance Mediation Committees.

5. Training for Strengthen the Capacity to Handle Grievance Petitions

The ACRC provides annual complaints capacity-building training to public officials at various levels in agencies to improve the quality of public service and broaden their understanding of grievance petitions and protection of people's rights and interests.

The training for strengthening the capacity to handle grievance petitions for agencies at all levels consists of one basic course and four specialized courses. Training is provided in a variety of ways, including regional training, nationwide training, and training in conjunction with training institutes taking into account the effectiveness of the training and the convenience of the trainees.

<Table 4-14> Training course to strengthen capacity for handling grievance petitions

Category	Course Title	Target Audience
Basic course	① Basic course for handling grievance complaints	Newcomer, civil affairs worker
Advanced course	② Professional investigation course by grievance complaint field	Investigation team leader, middle manager
	③ Collective grievance complaints and public conflict course	
	④ Local ombudsman course	City committee members, secretariat staff
	⑤ Investigation course for special civil complaints	Common

The ACRC also provides on-the-job training on laws and investigative techniques to new and transferred investigators to improve their work skills. In order to proactively respond to the increasing number of large-scale collective complaints and social conflicts, the ACRC also provides outsourced training to the Korean Commercial Arbitration Board and the Korea Institute of Public Administration to cultivate a higher level of mediation expertise and conflict management capabilities

[Training for strengthening the capacity to handle grievance petitions]



6. Planned Investigation through Analysis of Frequent Civil Complaints

The ACRC identifies recurring civil complaints each year and conducts in-depth analyses, coordinates with relevant agencies, and performs field investigations. These efforts aim to improve related policies and systems by addressing the root causes of grievances

Major Cases of Planned Investigations

1. Comprehensive Regional Traffic Safety Improvement Plan

■ Overview

To address confusing signal systems, inadequate traffic safety facilities, road structures, and pedestrian safety measures that cause inconvenience and accidents, Sejong City—promoted as a future city—was selected as a pilot site. A model for an advanced traffic environment project was developed and disseminated nationwide.

➡ Comprehensive review and improvement of accident-prone facilities such as confusing traffic signals and inappropriate safety infrastructure.

2. Eliminating Gaps in Veterans' Allowance Coverage

■ Overview

Although the government and local authorities provide allowances to veterans or their spouses under relevant laws and ordinances, complaints persist because the spouses of deceased veterans often go unnoticed due to lack of information and their advanced age. The Ministry of Patriots and Veterans Affairs and local governments are reviewing ways to regularly update and manage information on deceased veterans to prevent omissions in allowance payments.

➡ Institutional improvements to ensure regular updates of deceased veterans' data and revision of ordinances to eliminate blind spots in allowance distribution.

3. Enhancement of Post-Traffic Impact Assessments

■ Overview

After initial traffic impact assessments, changes in facilities or traffic conditions can still cause congestion, but current procedures make it difficult to implement countermeasures. Additionally, regions with fewer than 100,000 people are exempt from traffic congestion charges even for high-impact facilities, raising fairness concerns. Recommendations include allowing post-assessments where traffic conditions change and revising rules so certain facilities like racetracks are subject to charges regardless of city size.

➡ Establishing updated traffic measures and expanding congestion fee targets to improve policy fairness.



Part
05

Handling Administrative
Appeals in a Fair and Prompt
Manner



Chapter 1. Administrative Appeals System

Section 1 Overview of the Administrative Appeals System

1. Key Features of the Administrative Appeals System

Administrative appeals serve two main purposes: redressing the rights and interests of the people and controlling autonomous administration. The redress of rights and interests refers to protecting the rights and interests of individuals who have been infringed upon by unlawful or unjust administrative actions, and autonomous administrative control refers to ensuring the legality and rationality of administrative actions by allowing administrative agencies to self-correct.

The Administrative Appeals Act stipulates that “The purpose of this Act is to relieve citizens from the infringement of rights or interests caused by any illegal or unjust disposition or omission of public power by administrative agencies through the administrative appeals procedures, thereby achieving a due operation of administration.”

2. Characteristics of the Administrative Appeals Commission

The Administrative Appeals Commission is a deliberative administrative body established to review and decide administrative appeal cases.

The administrative appeals commission is divided into three types: the Central Administrative Appeals Commission (CAAC) established under the ACRC; and administrative

appeals commission established under the jurisdiction of a Mayor/Provincial Governor of the 17 metropolitan governments; and other administrative appeals commissions. Among these, the CAAC and the Provincial Administrative Appeals Commissions handle the largest number of cases and are the most actively operated.

Established under the umbrella of the ACRC, the CAAC deliberates and rules on appeal cases related to the disposition or omission of the agencies below:

- Heads of state administrative agencies, or their subordinate administrative agencies (except for agencies for which the establishment of an Administrative Appeals Commission is mandated),
- Special Metropolitan City Mayors, Metropolitan City Mayors, the Special Metropolitan Autonomous City Mayor, Provincial Governors, and the Special Self-Governing Province Governor,
- Superintendents of education or the Assembly of the Special Metropolitan City, Metropolitan Cities, the Special Metropolitan Autonomous City, Provinces or the Special Self-Governing Province,
- Other administrative agencies jointly established by the State, local governments, public corporations, etc. in accordance with relevant laws such as the Local Autonomy Act

The CAAC consists of no more than 70 members, including one chairperson and its standing members not more than four (currently 3 persons). Its Chairperson is one person, from among the vice chairpersons of the ACRC, and where the Chairperson is absent or is unable to perform his/her duty because of inevitable circumstances, or where he/she deems it necessary, a standing member (in order of seniority of service as a standing member, and in cases of equal seniority of service, in order of their age) should act on the Chairperson's behalf. The meetings of the CAAC should be attended by 9 persons, including the Chairperson, standing members, and non-standing members designated by the Chairperson for each meeting. The CAAC should adopt a resolution with the attendance of a majority of the members and by the concurring vote of a majority of those present.

The municipal or provincial administrative appeals commission deliberates and makes a



ruling on an appeal filed against the disposition or omission by administrative agencies under the jurisdiction of a Si (City), Gun (County) or an autonomous Gu (District) located under the jurisdiction of a city or province, its subordinate administrative agencies, or the Assembly of a city, county or autonomous district, or an administrative agency jointly established by at least two local governments and a public corporation, etc. under the jurisdiction of a city/province. It is a board-style administrative agency like the CAAC.

In addition, there are other administrative appeals commissions subject to the Administrative Appeals Act under the jurisdiction of the 17 municipal/ provincial education offices, 6 high prosecutors' offices, 4 regional corrections headquarters. In consideration of the expertise and specific nature of certain matters, such as taxation, patents, and land expropriation, special administrative bodies are designated under individual laws. These either replace the general administrative appeal process or provide exceptions to the Administrative Appeals Act.

Section 2 Operation of the Administrative Appeals System

1. Active and Warm-hearted Approaches

The ACRC promoted the introduction of the court-appointed defense counsel system, which allows an appellant, who is unable to appoint a representative due to his/her financial difficulties, to request the administrative appeals commission to appoint a public defender, and where the Chairperson of the commission appoints the appellant's defense counsel to represent him/her in the appeal for free. Those who are eligible to apply for a public defender are basic livelihood security recipients, basic pension recipients, single-parent family support recipients, disabled pension recipients, North Korean defectors, and other persons who are recognized by the chairperson of the administrative appeals commission as having difficulty in appointing a representative due to their financial capabilities. In 2021, the CAAC lowered the income cap for individuals eligible for a court-appointed defense counsel from KRW 2.7 million to KRW 3 million per month. The ACRC also expanded the eligibility to include small-business owners whose monthly sales are KRW 400 million or



less, so that the rights and interest of the less privileged can be better protected.

The ACRC has actively promoted the development of an online administrative appeals system to eliminate the inconvenience of visiting institutions or sending documents by mail. Through this system, the public can file appeals, submit documents, and check decisions—all online. It also allows easy access to search for relevant appeal cases.

In a rapidly changing society, disputes of various types and sizes between the public and administrative agencies are increasing. But administrative appeals have shown certain limitations as a system for resolving public conflicts by the administration itself, with a structure in which only one of the persons directly involved can obtain satisfaction. The ACRC introduced the administrative appeal mediation system to resolve appeals swiftly and reasonably within the scope of the parties' rights and authority. This system has been in effect since May 1, 2018, and is actively used to protect civil rights.

2. Engagement and Cooperation with Agencies related to Administrative Appeals and Enhancement of Employee Competence

To enhance understanding of administrative appeals and strengthen professional expertise, the ACRC has provided training to officials in charge of administrative dispositions with a focus on the introduction of the administrative appeals system, case handling procedures, and major re-adjudication case precedents. In 2024, the ACRC conducted its first nationwide training tour in collaboration with provincial administrative appeals commissions. This training targeted decision-making authorities and covered the administrative appeals system, how to prepare written responses, and key considerations in decision-making—based on accumulated case rulings—to help prevent rights violations caused by administrative errors.

In 2024, the CAAC held workshops with provincial administrative appeals commissions and provincial offices of education appeals commissions. In the September workshop with the education commissions, discussions focused on how to handle the growing number of administrative appeals related to school violence and teacher rights protection measures. At the December workshop with the provincial administrative appeals commissions, the focus was on strategies to respond to malicious or abusive administrative appeal filings, which had become a pressing issue.



Chapter 2.

Performance of the Central Administrative Appeals Commission

In 2024, 20,217 administrative appeals were filed with the CAAC, decreased by 10,679 from the previous year: specifically, an increase of 18 in patriots/ veterans' cases, a decrease of 10,388 in general cases and a decrease of 309 cases in driving cases. Meanwhile, the number of cases processed was 19,357, a decrease of 8,530 from the previous year. Of these, a decrease of 8,194 in general cases, a decrease of 105 in veterans' cases, and a decrease of 231 cases in driving cases.

The number of received and processed general cases significantly decreased compared to 2023, which is attributed to a sharp decline in mass and repetitive filings following the firm response to malicious claims in 2024.

<Table 5-1> Receipt and handling of appeal cases over the past 8 years

(unit : No.of cases)

Year	Receipt	Deliberation · Resolution				Acceptance rate (%)	Withdrawal · Transfer
		Total	Acceptance	Rejection	Dismissal		
2017	27,918	25,775	3,584	19,105	3,086	15.8	1,307
2018	23,043	25,153	3,814	18,928	2,411	16.8	1,401
2019	24,076	21,534	1,567	14,166	5,801	10.0	1,271
2020	22,367	22,727	1,573	16,783	4,371	8.6	1,094
2021	19,229	18,873	1,710	14,892	2,271	10.3	1,140
2022	21,467	21,159	1,468	15,581	4,110	8.6	1,527
2023	30,896	27,887	1,247	15,994	10,646	7.2	1,904
2024	20,217	19,357	964	15,051	3,342	6.0	1,392

1. Analysis by Type

In 2024, the number of cases filed with the CAAC by case type was 12,032 driver's license cases (59.5%), 7,026 general cases (34.8%), and 1,168 patriots/ veterans' cases (5.8%). Among the cases received, driver's license cases account for the largest proportion (59.5%), which is most likely due to the system, which requires that appeals against administrative dispositions of driver's licenses must go through a trial under the Road Traffic Act. Given the fact that the number of administrative dispositions on driver's license violations of the Road Traffic Act reaches hundreds of thousands, driver's license cases are expected to account for a significant proportion of administrative appeals cases in the future

<Table 5-2> Receipt of cases by category

(unit : No.of cases, %)

Category	Driver's license-related cases		Patriots and veterans affairs cases		General cases	
	Receipt	Percentage	Receipt	Percentage	Receipt	Percentage
2022	12,614	58.8	1,197	5.6	7,658	35.7
2023	12,332	39.9	1,150	3.7	17,414	56.4
2024	12,023	59.5	1,168	5.8	7,026	34.8

General cases, which are appeals against dispositions, excluding driver's license cases and veterans' cases, are in various fields such as employment and labor, information disclosure, national defense, legal affairs, land and transportation, various examinations, etc.

In 2024, the number of general cases handled was 6,059, a decrease of 8,194 (57.5%) from the previous year. Especially, the number of dismissals decreased to 2,968 in 2024, a reduction of 7,347 cases compared to 2023.

This sharp decline is mainly attributed to active measures taken against indiscriminate, repetitive, and complaint-driven appeals by certain individuals, including criminal complaints and restrictions on access to the online appeals system.

<Table 5-3> Receipt and handling cases of general cases

(unit : cases)

Year \ Category	No. of cases received	Number of cases handled			
		Total	Acceptance (rate)	Rejection	Dismissal
2022	7,658 (35.7%)	7,006	588(18.3%)	2,617	3,801
2023	17,414 (56.4%)	14,253	513(13.0%)	3,425	10,315
2024	7,026 (34.8%)	6,059	542(17.5%)	2,549	2,968

Patriots and veterans cases are administrative appeal cases related to the registration of applications for veterans -national veterans, independence patriots, and war veterans- or their bereaved family members under laws related to veterans affairs, and most often disputes the rejection of national veterans' registration by the Ministry of Patriots and Veterans Affairs, its regional offices and branch offices.

<Table 5-4> Receipt and handling of patriots and veterans affairs cases

(unit : cases)

Year \ Category	No. of cases received	Number of cases handled			
		Total	Acceptance (rate)	Rejection	Dismissal
2022	1,197 (5.6%)	1,437	163 (12%)	1,196	78
2023	1,150 (3.7%)	1,241	92 (8%)	1,062	87
2024	1,168 (5.8%)	1,136	41 (3.8%)	1,024	71

Driver's license cases are administrative appeals against the suspension or revocation of a driver's license due to violations of the Road Traffic Act, and each year, about 170,000 dispositions are repeatedly issued. These cases are often referred to as livelihood cases since driver's licenses are often crucial for employment or as a means of livelihood for the appellants. In addition, compared to general cases and veterans' cases, drivers' license cases involve a larger number of appeals, but they typically lack complexity and also have relatively straightforward facts, such as drunk driving.

<Table 5-5> Receipt and handling of drivers' license-related cases

(unit : cases)

Category Year	No.of cases received	Number of cases handled			
		Total	Partial acceptance (rate)	Rejection	Dismissal
2022	12,614 (58.8%)	12,716	717 (5.7%)	11,768	231
2023	12,332 (39.9%)	13,393	642 (5.3%)	11,507	244
2024	12,023 (59.5%)	12,162	381 (3.2%)	11,478	303

2. Processing Period and Oral Hearings

According to Article 45 of the Administrative Appeals Act, a ruling on a case should be made within 60 days from the date on which the appellee or the commission has received a written appeal. Where unavoidable circumstances arise to the contrary, the chairperson of the administrative appeals commission may extend the period for another 30 days ex officio to make sure that the case is handled within 60 days, and 90 days at the latest.

In practice, the CAAC had been handling some cases beyond the statutory time limit every year due to the consistent growth in case numbers and lack of manpower. As a result of various efforts such as improving work processes and conducting capacity-building training to shorten decision-making periods, the CAAC reduced the average decision period in 2024 to 55.6 days, 4.5 days shorter than the previous year.

<Table 5-6> Yearly breakdown of the handling period

(unit : cases)

Year	Total number of cases handled	Average ruling period (days)	Within the statutory period		Over the statutory period
			Within 60 days	61~90 days	Over 90 days
2022	21,159	75.83	13,570 (64.1%)	2,677 (12.7%)	4,912 (23.2%)
2023	27,887	60.11	19,616 (70.3%)	3,445 (12.4%)	4,826 (17.3%)
2024	19,357	55.60	13,563 (70.1%)	3,019 (15.6%)	2,775 (14.3%)

The review of an administrative appeal is made orally or in writing. In an oral hearing, the involved party appears before the commission and testifies. Compared to a review based on documents, oral hearing also provides easier to establish facts and identify inconsistencies through spontaneous questions and answers. In addition, oral hearings offer the advantage of allowing the general public, who may struggle with written statements, to fully express their opinions. The Administrative Appeals Act stipulates that if a party requests an oral hearing, it should be conducted unless the case can be clearly decided through written review alone.

Moreover, to enhance the convenience of oral hearings, the CAAC coordinated with local governments to utilize nearby municipal buildings for video hearings. It also increased the number of special case review committees dedicated to oral hearings from once to twice a month. As a result, the number of oral hearings in 2024 reached 155 cases, an increase of 54 from 2023. The Commission will continue to expand oral hearings to strengthen procedural rights and improve the quality of case deliberations, while also working to enhance convenience for participants through institutional improvements.

3. Suspension of Execution and Provisional Disposition

The Administrative Appeals Act adopts the principle of non-suspension of execution. In principle, even if a request for adjudication is made, the effects of a disposition or its execution, or continuation of proceedings continues. If the commission deems that it is urgent to prevent the appellant from suffering a serious loss that may occur, it may decide to suspend the execution, ex officio, or upon request by the concerned party.

If there is a decision by the commission to suspend execution, the disposition subject to judgment shall be suspended until a decision is made by the administrative appeal, and if there is a decision, the decision to suspend execution shall lose its effect. However, from 2023, the period of suspension of execution has been extended to 30 days from the date of ruling. To prevent a gap in the protection of rights that may occur between the administrative appeal decision and the filing of and administrative lawsuit, the CAAC has,



since 2023, extended the duration of the suspension of execution to up to 30 days from the date of ruling.

The suspension of execution system plays an important role in protecting procedural rights, but it is limited in that it only maintains the status quo before the administrative action. As such, it provides insufficient relief for passive administrative actions such as rejections or inaction. For this reason, the Administrative Appeals Act contains provisions on provisional disposition to better protect the rights and interests of people that cannot be adequately addressed through suspension of execution alone.

A provisional disposition may be issued when it is strongly suspected that a disposition or omission is unlawful and unjust, and thus, it is necessary to prevent a serious disadvantage or urgent danger that might occur to the concerned party to whom a provisional status is granted. It can be filed if the concerned party is unable to obtain the desired outcome through suspension of execution. The provisional disposition system has stricter requirements than suspension of execution and is not widely used. However, it is expected to significantly contribute to protecting procedural rights in cases not covered by the suspension of execution system, such as exam failure decisions.

<Table 5-7> Filing and handling outcomes for suspension of execution

(unit : cases)

Handling Year	No. of cases filed	Handling outcome			Ex officio suspension of execution	Withdrawal· Transfer
		Acceptance (rate)	Rejection	Dismissal		
2022	1,759	110(7.1%)	1,446	47	148	58
2023	1,336	119(10.8%)	982	40	177	65
2024	1,303	85(8.0%)	982	51	157	55

<Table 5-8> Filing and handling outcomes for provisional disposition

(unit : cases)

Handling Year	No. of cases filed	Handling outcome			Ex officio suspension of execution	Withdrawal · Transfer
		Acceptance	Rejection	Dismissal		
2022	41	-	28	6	1	9
2023	37	-	21	12	4	3
2024	77	-	24	14	33	10

4. Case of Major Administrative Appeal Rulings

A. [2023-22330] Appeal for cancellation of rejection of national merit registration, etc.

[Case Issue]

Whether the claimant's cerebral hemorrhage was caused by overwork during working hours.

[Case Summary]

The claimant suffered a cerebral hemorrhage while on duty. However, the respondent rejected the claimant's application for registration as a person eligible for veterans' compensation, stating that the claimant's working hours did not appear excessive and that health check results showed hyperlipidemia and habitual alcohol consumption, thus denying a causal link between the hemorrhage and official duties.

[Ruling Summary]

While the claimant's health check records show hyperlipidemia, the levels were not significantly above normal and are unlikely to have caused the cerebral hemorrhage. There was no evidence of other underlying conditions such as hypertension or diabetes typically associated with cerebral hemorrhage. On the other hand, the claimant had worked continuously without holidays, including two overnight shifts within three weeks prior to the incident, indicating a physical and mental workload sufficient to impair normal cerebrovascular function. Therefore, the decision not to recognize the claimant as eligible for veterans' compensation was deemed unlawful and inappropriate.

b. [2023-27068] Appeal for cancellation of recovery of quarantine support fund and rejection of loss compensation payment

[Case Issue]

Whether changing the business registration number can still be considered as operating the same business.

[Case Summary]

The claimant received quarantine support funds from the respondent. However, after the claimant changed their business registration number, the respondent ordered a recovery of the funds, citing non-fulfillment of the business continuity requirement based on the date of closure.

[Ruling Summary]

Although the claimant did change the business registration number, the business name, representative, location, and type of business remained the same, with only the tonnage of the fishing vessel being modified. Despite this, the respondent recovered the support funds solely based on the registration number change, without a substantive review of business continuity. This was deemed highly unreasonable, and the recovery order was found to be unjustified.

c. [2024-15547] Appeal for cancellation of imposition of compensation for unauthorized use of state-owned property

[Case Issue]

Whether it is reasonable to impose compensation for underground space occupation using the same standard as for direct occupation of surface land.

[Case Summary]

The claimant had installed and operated a cave-themed park in the underground space of state-owned land. The respondent later imposed compensation fees, stating that the claimant had occupied the space without official permission.

[Ruling Summary]

The respondent argued that since the relevant subordinate legislation under the State Property Act was amended to apply a "three-dimensional use impairment rate" when calculating compensation, this rate could not be retroactively applied to the claimant's previous period of use. However, the rationale behind the impairment rate recognizes that using underground or aerial space interferes with land use far less than surface occupation. Therefore, applying the same compensation rate as for surface use to the claimant, who only used the underground space, is not appropriate. Furthermore, since the amended regulation does not include transitional provisions in its supplementary clauses, imposing the same rate as surface use effectively shifts the burden of legislative gaps onto the claimant. Thus, the compensation imposition was deemed unlawful and unfair.



Chapter 3. Integration of Administrative Appeals

1. Background of the Initiative

Compared to administrative litigation, administrative appeals are cost-free, procedurally simple, and offer the advantage of speed, as a favorable ruling binds the respondent and resolves the dispute in a single instance. The ACRC has worked to advance the administrative appeals system by introducing provisions such as state-appointed representatives, indirect enforcement, and mediation into the Administrative Appeals Act.

However, there are currently 123 institutions operating administrative appeals, with differing jurisdictions and procedures depending on the nature of the disposition. Furthermore, the use of various terms such as objection, retrial request, and review petition to refer to special administrative appeals, along with inconsistent filing periods, makes it difficult for the general public to use the appeals process. Operating separate systems has also led to significant differences in processing times, acceptance rates, and how similar cases are handled.

As a quasi-judicial procedure, administrative appeals require institutional independence, which is a key factor in ensuring fairness and public acceptance of decisions. However, under current law, the same authority that issued the disposition may also handle the appeal, or the appeal may be managed by a higher agency of the disposition authority. This has raised concerns about whether administrative appeals are being conducted fairly and independently from the claimant's perspective. To address these issues and to enhance its independence and fairness, the ACRC initiated the integration of administrative appeals through the "One-Stop Administrative Appeals Service" project, which was selected as a key national policy task.

2. Key Details

The “One-Stop Administrative Appeals Service” project primarily aims to integrate the organizational structures of the CAAC and various special administrative appeals bodies established under individual laws. It also seeks to unify and build a government-wide online administrative appeals system, enabling centralized operation by a single institution.

The service first focuses on organizational integration by analyzing the characteristics, decision-making structures, and operational status of 66 special administrative appeals bodies to develop a consolidation plan with the CAAC, followed by relevant legislative action. At the same time, a government-wide online system will be established to improve the convenience of administrative appeal services. This system will enable citizens to file appeals in all areas and access a vast information database through a single online platform.

3. Progress and Future Plans

To ensure implementation of the project, the ACRC expanded and reorganized its collaborative task force dedicated to this national policy initiative. Initially, the “Administrative Appeals Integration Planning Group,” jointly operated by the ACRC, Ministry of the Interior and Safety, and Ministry of Government Legislation since May 2023, was restructured in September 2024 into the “Administrative Appeals Integration Promotion Group.” This expanded body now includes additional agencies subject to integration, such as the Ministry of Health and Welfare, Ministry of Personnel Management, and the Tax Tribunal, thereby establishing a government-wide, permanent coordination system to support the initiative. To develop an integration plan for administrative appeals, the ACRC completed a study on the “One-Stop Administrative Appeals Integration Plan” in December 2022. Based on the findings of this research, the ACRC collected a wide range of opinions from experts, the public, and agencies subject to integration. Additionally, the Commission conducted a detailed review of the operational characteristics of each special administrative appeals body, including procedural considerations specific to each case type, to determine which unique elements should be reflected in the integration plan. Based on this comprehensive analysis, a draft law for the integration of administrative appeals was prepared.

Meanwhile, the ACRC secured an additional budget of 16.885 billion KRW to advance the development of the One-Stop Administrative Appeals System. In June 2024, a service contract was signed to initiate the system construction in earnest. By December 2024, the ACRC held 13 working-level meetings and 3 workshops with relevant institutions, collecting and analyzing 497 requirements submitted by agencies including the Tax Tribunal. These efforts helped establish the system development framework and direction. Based on these efforts, by December 2024, the system design was completed with the goal of significantly enhancing overall functionality. This included unifying online administrative appeal services into a single platform, enabling online submission of petitions, case review, and committee deliberations, incorporating electronic signature capabilities, and strengthening the security of personal information management.

The ACRC plans to finalize the list of agencies subject to integration and establish a “(tentatively named) Administrative Appeals Integration Council” comprising all participating institutions. Going forward, the ACRC will continue close coordination with these agencies to finalize the legislation for the integration of administrative appeals and improvement of the appeals system, with the aim of enacting the law within 2025.

In addition, the ACRC plans to launch the One-Stop Administrative Appeals System in June 2025. Citizens can access all administrative appeal services through a single online platform, significantly improving convenience. Furthermore, the integration of administrative appeals systems will reduce costs previously incurred by individual agencies for system maintenance and redevelopment.

Moreover, starting in 2026, the Commission plans to enhance the system by incorporating advanced technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI), including tools like ChatGPT. These innovations will assist citizens who lack legal knowledge in filing administrative appeals and provide 24/7 legal consultation services for administrative appeals. In addition, the Commission aims to promote transparent governance by publicly sharing data collected across various fields—such as general appeals, tax, personnel, and compensation insurance. It is also exploring ways to enable both the public and private sectors to utilize the accumulated big data collaboratively.

Part
06

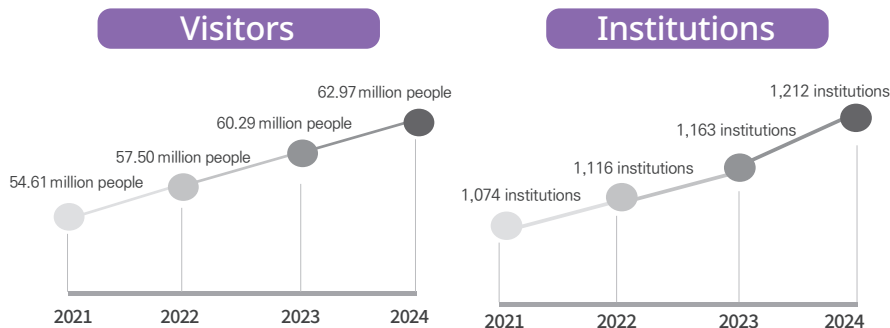
Building up Policy Feedback
through Engagement with
the Public

Chapter 1. Citizen-Centric Communication System

Under the slogan of “No voice left unheard,” the ACRC launched the integrated government- citizen communication portal called “e-People” that combines all of the public communication channels previously operated separately by individual administrative agencies for handling of civil complaints, public proposals, and policy participation.

Starting with the integration of such systems of 7 central government agencies in August 2005, the Commission continued to integrate public service systems of all central government agencies in July 2006, and then combined systems of local governments and major public institutions in February 2008. This laid the foundation for an integrated system of public service. As part of the e-government development project with a total budget of KRW 10 billion, the ACRC utilized cutting-edge information technologies to establish an upgraded e-People system with improved user convenience and work efficiency starting from August 2018. The e-People system was officially launched in February 2020. As of the end of 2024, a total of 1,121 administrative institutions are providing services through the e-People. In 2024, the number of users who visited e-People reached 62.97 million, and its public awareness rate, as surveyed in 2023, stood at 91.8%. This firmly established e-People as one of South Korea’s leading public service platforms.

○ [Figure 6-1] The number of e-People visitors and registered Institutions



1. Operation of the Civil Petition System

The ACRC provides training and consultation on how to process civil complaints on the e-People system to improve the capability of public institutions in addressing civil complaints. It is also working to make sure that administrative agencies handle civil complaints in a proper manner by conducting inspections and evaluations on complaint services on the e-People system every year to identify the level of complaint handling and manage the quality of the services.

In order to improve quality of handling civil complaints from the e-People, 48 of the public administrations using the e-People were selected to receive customized consulting to improve their civil service. As a result, their scores in the e-People category of the public administrations that received consulting from the Comprehensive Evaluation of Public Grievance Service improved by 6.24 points in 2024. In the 2024 Comprehensive Evaluation of the Public Grievance Services, the e-People segment scored 84.3 points, an increase of 1.8 points from the previous year. Notably, the satisfaction score from petitioners rose by 3.3 points to 71.0, indicating an overall improvement in the quality of public grievance handling through e-People.

In addition, in order to address the practice of civil complaint tossing or ping-ponging between administrative institutions, the ACRC introduced the “Pending Complaint Mediation System” in 2015. Moreover, the Commission has been conducting continuous inspections and monitoring, and shortened the period for updating the classification criteria for civil petitions (from bimonthly to monthly), making efforts to stabilize the system. As a result, the proportion of civil petitions transferred three or more times significantly decreased from 0.49% in 2016 to 0.11% in 2024.

<Table 6-1> Status of civil complaint tossing between agencies

2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
0.49%	0.46%	0.40%	0.31%	0.26%	0.14%	0.15%	0.12%	0.11%

In addition, the ACRC operates the “Multilingual Petition Service” of e-People. This service, which initially started with English, Chinese, and Japanese in June 2008, currently supports 14 languages. The Multilingual Petition Service ensures that if overseas Koreans and foreigners living in Korea file a civil petition in their native language, the relevant government institution processes the petition and translates the outcome into the requested language to notify the petitioner. The system is fulfilling its purpose of facilitating international cooperation based on complaints processing in this globalized world, and the government obtained a national patent for the Multilingual Petition Service in 2014 in recognition of its innovativeness.

<Table 6-2> Commencement point of complaint service in foreign languages

commen- cement	Jun. 2008	Dec. 2009	Jun. 2010	Nov. 2010	Feb. 2011	May 2011	Sep. 2011	Nov. 2011	Dec. 2012	Nov. 2013	Jun. 2016
Language	English Chinese Japanese	Vietnamese	Mongolian	Indonesian	Thai	Uzbek	Bengali	Cambodian	Sinhalese	Nepali	Russian Burmese

International interest in the e-People system has led to its export. Since 2012, the Tunisian government has worked with the ACRC, resulting in the launch of Tunisia's e-People system in March 2018. Currently, an advanced development project for the system is underway, aiming for completion by 2028. The ACRC continues its efforts to promote Korea's expertise and best practices in operating the e-People system to countries around the world.

- [Figure 6-2] e-People of Tunisia (www.e-people.gov.tn)



2. Foundation for Public -Private Cooperation Online

'e-People's Citizens' Proposals' provides a platform through which the public can make proposals to improve the quality of administrative services and suggest ideas to address inconveniences they face in daily lives so that the government can provide better services. Such proposals can be submitted both online and offline, and they are shared among agencies across the government. This enables proactive delivery of public services that prioritizes the needs of the people. In addition to the yearly inspection of the proposals from the public, the ACRC is monitoring key performance indicators of each agency on a quarterly basis and provides them with the inspection results to help them identify their service quality and resolve problems at an early stage.

On March 28, 2016, the ACRC launched People's Idea Box to collect people's opinions on major policies and programs that directly affect their lives, so that they can be reflected in policies. In 2016, around 16,000 people shared their thoughts on the platform. The number jumped to 531,000 in 2024, which suggests that People's Idea Box has established itself as a Korea's leading channel for people to express their voices on public policy.

<Table 6-3> Public participation via People's Idea Box

Year	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
No. of participants	16,136	64,338	164,594	231,175	358,597	445,487	525,365	719,113	531,359
No. of items	546	1,809	4,405	6,817	8,622	7,703	6,546	6,542	6,604

The ideas posted on the official website of People's Idea Box are transformed into government policies after deliberation based on consultation with the concerned agencies and advice from experts. In 2024, the number of ideas submitted to the People's Idea Box that were incorporated into policy by the ACRC or its lead agency totaled 40, an increase of two from the previous year.

- [Figure 6-3] Improvements in major policies and institutions based on ideas proposed via People's Idea Box in 2024

Policy Improvement Case ①

Prevention of Illegal Ticket Resale for Performances and Sports Events

- (Public Opinion) : 96.3% of citizens agreed on the need for active measures to prevent the harm caused by illegal ticket resale (scalping).
- (Policy Implementation) : (ACRC): Recommended institutional improvements including a full ban on scalping and provisions for confiscation and forfeiture of profits → (Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism): Developed and announced measures to eradicate illegal ticket resale.

Policy Improvement Case ②

Expansion of Mental Health Screening in National Health Checkups, Shortening of Screening Intervals, and Enhanced Follow-Up.

- (Public Opinion): In a rapidly changing and competitive society, concerns over youth mental health are growing, prompting calls to expand mental health screenings in national health checkups.
- (Policy Implementation): (Ministry of Health and Welfare): Announced measures including shortening the mental health screening interval for young adults from 10 years to 2 years and adding new screening item

Meanwhile, since April 2021, the ACRC has been recruiting a “Citizen Panel” to gather public policy opinions on major national interests and social issues. Survey results from over 20,000 Citizen Panel members are compared and analyzed alongside those from the general public collected through the People's Idea Box website. This approach helps prevent the disproportionate influence of specific interest groups on survey outcomes.



Chapter 2. Operation of Government Call Center(#110)

1. Overview

Operated by the ACRC, the 110 Government Call Center offers one-stop service to individuals who dial 110 for inquiries, reports, or recommendations, etc. regarding public services, providing them with consultation, assistance, and appropriate referrals to the relevant agencies.

2. Number of Calls Received and Handled

The 110 Government Call Center has processed 2,439,681 calls in total. Of the total number of the calls, 2,156,801 calls were consulted and 2,187,559 calls were handled. The number of handled calls exceeds the number of counseling responses because it includes both incoming calls from complainants and additional services provided through outbound calls made by the 110 Government Call Center.

3. Activities of the 110 Government Call Center

A. Establishing a productive labor-management relationship of the 110 government call center through cooperation and mutual growth

The 110 Government Call Center has worked to strengthen counselor protection by revising and supplementing the Counselor Protection Operational Guidelines. Efforts included operating a labor-management council for regular consultations on potential conflict areas, installing grievance boxes for continuous support channels, and providing customized healing programs and a fall walking event to relieve counselor stress. These initiatives contributed to enhancing job satisfaction among counselors.

B. Enhancing operational efficiency through integrated call center system development

To establish a shared platform for systems individually developed and operated by each agency's call center, a government-wide AI-based integrated call center system was developed and completed in 2024, targeting 17 agencies including the Korea Meteorological Administration, Rural Development Administration, and Ministry of Land, Infrastructure and Transport.

C. Improving public satisfaction with the 110 Government Call Center consultation service

By updating the counseling database and improving the expertise of counselors through periodic training, the counselors are able to answer questions without referring them to other organizations or provide contact information for those organizations, which has led to improved public satisfaction by an increase in the rate of self-closing counseling.

D. Raising awareness through diversified promotion methods

The ACRC strengthened online promotional efforts by running advertisements on KakaoTalk, a mobile messenger used nationwide, and hosting interactive public events through social media platforms such as the 110 Call Center's Twitter and Facebook. It also utilized high-impact media channels, including subway station interior ads and bus exterior ads, to raise public awareness of the 110 Call Center for the Public.

4. Way Forward

The ACRC plans to continue its efforts to enhance the services of the 110 Call Center for the Public. The Commission will improve the quality of consultation services by operating healing programs and improving working conditions for counselors. It will also provide citizen-centered consultation services by stabilizing the government-wide AI-based integrated call center system. Furthermore, the ACRC will go beyond conventional promotional methods and pursue more diversified outreach strategies to promote continued use and raise awareness of the 110 Call Center.





Chapter 3.

Quality Improvement of Guidance and Counseling for Citizens

The primary mission of the Government Complaints Counseling Center is to listen to the complaints of those who visit the ACRC, help resolve their issues, and provide prompt and accurate guidance and counseling to them, thereby contributing to improving the quality of people's lives and serving as a last resort to protect the rights and interests of the underprivileged.

More specifically, it is supposed to help address grievance petitions by providing information about relevant statutes, institutions, and procedures related to various aspects of public services such as permission, authorization, patent, license, approval, designation, recognition, recommendation, examination, inspection, certification, etc. Additionally, the center provides guidance and counseling for measures to address inconveniences and violations of basic rights caused by dispositions of administrative agencies.

The ACRC operates the Sejong Complaints Counseling Center for petitioners who visit its headquarters and those living in and around the Chungcheong region, and a Seoul Complaints Counseling Center at the Government Complaints Counseling Center for those who live in Seoul and the metropolitan areas in Gyeonggi. In addition to the consultations with its grievance petition investigators, the ACRC also ensures that low-income individuals and the vulnerable who lack legal knowledge or face economic difficulties visit the center at any time to receive counseling and guidance on appropriate remedies from expert consultation commissioners (attorneys, certified labor attorneys, and tax accountants) and complaint consultation commissioners (retired public officials with much experience in public administration).

In 2024, the complaint counseling center in Sejong and Seoul delivered a total of 25,964 cases of consultation and guidance services to petitioners. Located in Sejong City, the headquarters of the ACRC is not easily accessible for those living in Seoul and the metropolitan areas in Gyeonggi to visit in person. To alleviate their inconveniences, the ACRC is providing video consultations between its investigators and the petitioners who visit the Seoul Center. In 2024, a total of 90 video consultations were conducted.

<Table 6-4> Status of investigator consultations and guidance by sector

(unit : cases)

Year	2020		2021		2022		2023		2024	
Total	37,249	100%	41,495	100%	33,704	100%	27,567	100%	25,964	100%
Administrative Culture Education	4,056	10.9%	5,344	12.9%	3,664	10.9%	3,147	11.4%	2,698	10.4%
Defense & Veterans	754	2.0%	887	2.1%	868	2.6%	745	2.7%	660	2.5%
Police	1,456	3.9%	2,495	6.0%	1,970	5.8%	1,140	4.1%	1,162	4.5%
Welfare & Labor	3,857	10.4%	14,644	35.3%	12,564	37.3%	10,557	38.3%	10,038	38.7%
Finance & Tax	12,554	33.7%	4,129	10.0%	3,335	9.9%	2,616	9.5%	2,358	9.1%
Industry, Agriculture & Environment	2,948	7.9%	4,101	9.9%	3,603	10.7%	2,672	9.7%	2,385	9.2%
Housing & Construction	2,900	7.8%	3,413	8.2%	2,569	7.6%	2,078	7.5%	2,144	8.3%
Urban Affairs	325	0.9%	531	1.3%	342	1.0%	287	1.0%	197	0.8%
Transportation & Roads	1,364	3.7%	1,472	3.5%	1,281	3.8%	998	3.6%	922	3.6%
Civil/ Criminal, etc	7,035	18.9%	4,479	10.8%	3,508	10.4%	3,327	12.1%	3,400	13.1%

※ The number of civil/criminal consultation cases includes repeated complaint cases

Online civil consultation services provide citizens with accessible guidance prior to submitting formal complaints, offering answers regarding the responsible agency, relevant laws, and procedures. These services deliver support that aligns with public expectations and help resolve so-called “ping-pong complaints” or issues with unclear jurisdiction by directing citizens to the appropriate agency or department. Additionally, for multi-agency or complex civil petitions—an area seeing yearly growth—the Government Complaints Counseling Center consolidates review opinions from national and local authorities to provide integrated, one-stop responses. This system has contributed significantly to easing the administrative burden on related agencies by reducing the rate of additional complaints submitted to other institutions after initial consultations, currently down to 16.7%.

<Table 6-5> 2024 Online consultation results statistics

Total	Consultation Outcome			
	Resolved through Consultation	Referred to Appropriate Agency	Converted to Formal Petition	Withdrawn, etc
24,249 cases	22,821 (94.1%)	998 (4.1%)	9 (0.04%)	378 (1.6%)

<Table 6-6> Status of civil consultation council operations

Category	Total	Oct. 2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
No.of Meetings Held	26	2	6	4	4	5	5
No.of Agenda Items Submitted	146	2	11	25	33	34	41
No.of Cases Resolved (Resolution rate)	101 (70%)	2 (100%)	4 (36.3%)	14 (56%)	23 (70%)	21 (62%)	37 (90%)

Since August 2021, the Government Complaint Counseling Center took over the Onsite Outreach Service from the headquarters and has been actively using it for on-site publicity, visits to complaint sites, and on-site operation of the Complaint Counseling Council.

<Table 6-7> 2024 Key operating results of Onsite Outreach Service in the Seoul Metropolitan Area (16 sessions)

Category	Sessions	Location
Winter Youth Olympic Games Promotion	2	Pyeongchang, Gangwon Province (Jan. 23–24)
Civil Consultation and Promotion around Bukhansan	2	Targeted at residents near Bukhansan entrances (Mar. 27 / Apr. 25)
On-site Civil Consultation and Promotion at Local Festivals	10	Goyang Flower Expo (May 9–10), Paju (Jun. 18 / Nov. 30), Yangpyeong Lotus Festival (Jul. 11), Icheon Rice Culture Festival (Oct. 16), Cheorwon Goseokjeong Flower Field Festival (Oct. 30), etc.
Headquarters Support for On-site Grievance Consultations	2	On-site support for veterans' family grievance consultations (Jun. 4–6), School commute safety coordination in Okjeong New Town, Yangju (Sep. 25–26)

Petition letters submitted to the Office of the President are processed through e-People by the Special Petition Review Division of the Government Complaints Counseling Center, in accordance with the Regulation on the Operation of the Online Public Participation Portal (Presidential Directive). Each petition is registered and handled by the respective competent agency.

In 2024, a total of 19,641 petition letters were submitted via e-People. 5,328 cases (32.2%) requested corrective actions or remedies; 5,015 (25.5%) called for investigations, audits, or inspections, 4,287 (21.8%) were classified as other matters. 3,061 (15.6%) involved policy proposals, 620 (3.2%) raised objections to court rulings, 251 (1.3%) requested pardons or reinstatements, and 46 cases (0.2%) were expressions of hope for good governance.

<Table 6-8> Status of petition letters submitted to the office of the president

Total	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
19,641 cases	5,891 cases	5,386 cases	4,586 cases	3,778 cases

Chapter 4.

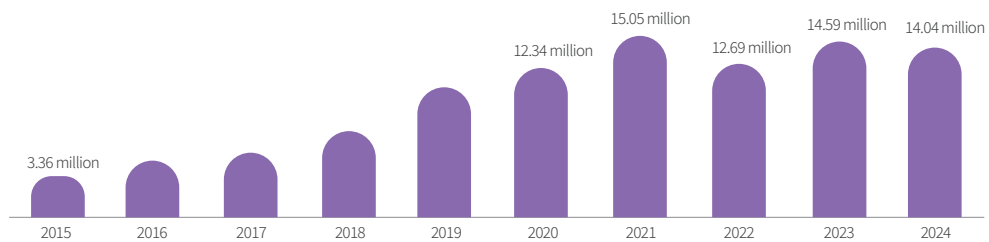
Policy Improvement through Analysis of Big Data on Civil Complaints

In 2024, 14.04 million civil complaints were filed against central and local government agencies through the e-People system and local governments' complaint channels. Following the previous year, 2023 (14.59 million cases), over 14 million civil complaints were collected annually for the second consecutive year.

Since the launch of the Public Grievance analysis system in 2012, the number of accumulated grievances has shown slight fluctuations but has steadily increased. Since the 2020s, an annual average of approximately 13.7 million grievances has been recorded over five years. It means that the public is increasingly expressing their opinions on the policies of administrative agencies, and the utilization of accumulated big data is becoming more important.

● [Figure 6-4] Yearly collection of complaint data

◎ 13.7million annual average complaints for 5 consecutive years since 2020



Big data analysis of complaints plays an important role in identifying patterns within individual complaints and uncovering problems with the system as a whole. This analysis enables the direct identification of public inconveniences and provides guidance on areas where policies need to be improved. As such, big data analysis of civil complaints is being utilized as a key tool to systematically incorporate “people’s opinions” into policy.

1. Analysis of Civil Complaints Data of Various Types

A. Providing information on civil complaint trends through big data monitoring

The ACRC publishes “Voice of the People,” a comprehensive report on complaint trends derived from big data analysis, which offers weekly and monthly complaint trends, the status of complaints by institution, and cases of public inconvenience. The ACRC provides it to more than 1,750 public and research institutions and makes it accessible to the public.

In 2024, “Voice of the People” was published 40 times weekly, 11 times monthly, and once annually. Its weekly edition includes not only the trends of complaints during the week but also cases of public inconvenience that are deemed to require fundamental system improvements to prevent the recurrence of the same or similar complaints. The monthly edition provides periodical forecasts of complaints expected to occur at a specific time or to surge or spread and presents trends by organization, region, and major policies for the month.

B. Planned analysis to address public inconvenience and unfairness

The ACRC conducted an in-depth analysis of complaints related to major national policies and social issues, identifies problems and implications, and then provides them to relevant organizations to improve policies and systems that cause such complaints.

The major planned analyses conducted in 2024 include several key cases. For example, due to a surge in pothole-related complaints caused by frequent snowstorms, heavy rain, and abnormal temperature spikes during winter, civil petition data was analyzed and shared



with the Ministry of Land, Infrastructure and Transport, the Ministry of the Interior and Safety, and local governments. As a result, the analysis led to policy improvements such as focused road inspections and repairs by local authorities and related agencies, contributing to the creation of safer road environments.

<Table 6-8> Status of planned analysis

No.	Analysis Period	Analysis Topic	Analysis Scope	Social Policy Area
1	April	Road Surface Dents (Potholes)	52,262 cases over the past 2 years	Public Safety
2	June	Wedding Industry (marriage related services)	1,010 cases over the past 3 years	Low Birthrate & Youth
3	September	Golf Courses (Reservations/cancellation, Complaints)	884 cases over the past 3 years	Fairness Improvement
4	November	Mobile Gift Certificates (e.g., Gifticons)	1,085 cases over the past 5 years	Fairness Improvement

C. Operation of the public grievance forecast system

Complaint forecasting is a system that helps related organizations prepare for complaints thoroughly in advance by capturing issues that appear periodically at a certain time and notifying them before the damage spreads, or sharing information to pay attention to new and rapidly increasing complaints. That is, the ACRC issues regular and occasional civil complaint forecasts, depending on the frequency of complaints and the time of issuance, and actively informs the public of all forecasts through “Civil Complaint Big Data at a Glance” and social media.

In 2024, a total of 12 Public Grievance forecasts were issued—11 regular and 1 special. Regular forecasts covered monthly issues such as fire safety (February), election campaigns (March), accessibility for persons with disabilities (April), illegal advertisements (May), food poisoning (June), heatwaves affecting vulnerable groups (July), typhoon safety (August),

campsite safety (September), shared bicycles (October), digital sex crimes (November), and cold-related illnesses (December). A special forecast was issued in May concerning pest-related disinfection requests, prompting swift responses from relevant agencies.

2. Collaboration Using Public Grievance Data

In 2024, a broad collaboration framework was established with academia and private sector experts to maximize the value of Public Grievance data. A total of over 20 roundtables and technical consultations were held with various public and private organizations—including the Ministry of Science and ICT, the National Information Society Agency (NIA), and E-mart—to identify emerging technology trends and explore ways to advance big data analysis. The data collaboration research also produced tangible outcomes. In partnership with POSTECH's Social and Cultural Data Science Lab, a joint research project was conducted to exchange grievance analysis technologies and explore the use of grievance data under the goal of “contributing to the improvement of citizens’ quality of life.” In 2024, POSTECH's Data Science Institute carried out a study analyzing grievance data from the past three years in key areas of interest among young adults in their 20s and 30s—such as education, labor, culture, welfare, and housing. The research focused on identifying the relationship between the decline in youth populations in regional areas and their specific local characteristics, under the theme: Identifying the Challenges of Local Youth through Grievance Data Analysis. The ACRC shared the findings with seven metropolitan governments, including Gangwon Special Self-Governing Province, to help develop tailored policy alternatives based on regional characteristics.

On November 20, 2024, the ACRC announced the results of a joint Public Grievance big data analysis conducted in collaboration with the Korea Research Institute for Human Settlements (KRIHS), under the topic: A Study on Improving Public Grievance Guide for Monitoring Public Concerns.

In this study, the KRIHS focused on the transportation sector, which accounts for approximately 60–70% of all petitions. By integrating and analyzing data on illegal parking complaints and grid-based accessibility to fire and emergency facilities, the institute

identified “high-risk zones for emergency vehicle access” (tentatively named Priority Community Safety Management Zones). Pilot models were proposed for Seoul and Busan to support proactive risk management in these areas.

In addition, to incorporate cutting-edge technologies such as artificial intelligence into the civil petition information analysis system, the ACRC held ongoing technical consultations with AI research institutions from both the public and private sectors. To better understand the intent behind approximately 14 million public grievance cases annually, the ACRC aimed to automate responses and more accurately capture the underlying meanings in petitions. The Commission participated in consulting and technical verification programs, where its project, Validation of the Effectiveness of Meaning-Based Public Grievance Data Analysis, was selected as a representative initiative, achieving notable results.

3. Operation of the Complaint Data Analysis System and Opening up of Public Data

A. Operation of the 「Complaint Data Analysis System」

The complaint data analysis system collects a vast amount of complaint data from major complaint channels in Korea, including the e-People system (1,212 organizations integrated and linked as of Dec. 2024) and individual channels of the local governments. The ACRC provides support for the operation and management of the system, training, and consulting so that each administrative and public institution can monitor and analyze its own complaints using the complaint data analysis system.

B. Operation of the website, 「Civil Complaint Big Data at a Glance」

In “Civil Complaint Big Data at a Glance,” which was reorganized in 2020 to align with the new features of the next-generation complaint data analysis system, the results of data analysis are presented in various visual formats and made available to the public. In particular, a horizontal layout has been applied so that statistical graphs can be checked immediately without scrolling left and right, and a responsive web design has been fully implemented to make it easy to use on mobile devices.



In addition, a total of 21 types of information are made available through the promotion of public data opening via the Open-API method every year. This allows users to develop their own applications and services. The number of applications to utilize Open-API through public data portals, as well as requests for data linkage and provision from research institutes, academia, media, and the National Assembly is steadily increasing.

4. The Way Forward

The ACRC has been systematically managing and analyzing civil complaint big data, which contains the voices of the people, to find public opinion from the data and use them for policy improvement.

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence technology, when combined with public service delivery, is expected to significantly improve citizens' access to and convenience in using public services. In response, the ACRC plans to introduce advanced AI technologies from the industrial and academic sectors into the public grievance data analysis and utilization system. The Commission will continue its efforts to enhance petition processing and analysis, aiming to respond more swiftly and accurately to the diverse needs of the public.



Chapter 5.

Promotion of Civil Petition System for Proactive Administration

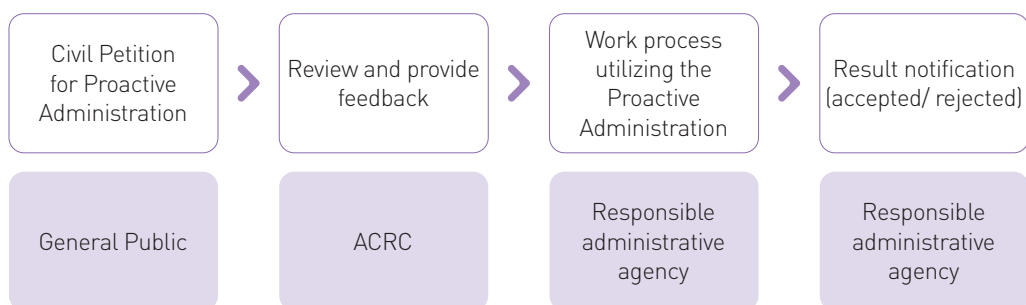
1. Operation of the Civil Petition System for Proactive Administration

A. Overview

The “Public Petition for Proactive Administration” is a pan-governmental initiative to drive proactive administration and a system that operates on a fast-track basis for redressing rights and interests.

When a citizen submits policy ideas for the public interest, the ACRC reviews the contents and provides its opinion, or recommendations on how to handle the suggested ideas to the relevant administrative agency actively. Then, the administrative agency actively incorporates them into its administration by improving laws and systems and notifies the idea submitter of the outcome. If the public official requests an opinion from the Proactive Administration Committee of the competent administrative agency, or handles a matter following the opinions of the Committee or pre-consultation with the Audit Department, disciplinary measures may be exempted.

<Table 6-9> Procedures for civil petitions for proactive administration



<Table 6-10> Key drivers of proactive administration

- Introduced the 'Proactive Administration National Application System' by amending the 'Proactive Administration Operating Regulations' (July 27, 2021)
- Established the 'Proactive Administration Request Team' (February 22, 2022)
- Revised the "Guidelines for Processing and Operation" (April 27, 2022)
- Published casebooks on the 'Proactive Administration Applications' (Dec. 2022, Dec. 2023, Dec. 2024)

B. Operational performance

From July 2021 to the end of December 2024, the ACRC received 12,559 petitions for proactive administration through the e-People system, processed 12,485 cases, and provided advisory opinions to competent administrative bodies for 758 cases.

<Table 6-11> Civil petition for proactive administration(as of Dec. 2024)

Classification	No.of petitions received	Processing status			Under investigation
		Total	Recommendations	Transferred closed	
Civil petition for proactive administration (implemented on Jul.27, 2021)	12,559	12,485	758	11,727	74

The main examples include improving policies for declining birthrate and the younger generation, resolving inconveniences in people's lives, and addressing unreasonable regulations for the public.

First, in order to improve policies to counter the declining birthrate and support young people, the ACRC recommended that the government respond to the declining birthrate crisis, address injustices against young people, and actively respond to changes in society and conditions.

Countermeasures against low birthrate and improved policies for the young generation

- Improving the burden of pharmaceutical expenses due to military treatment for discharged persons who have not completed medical treatment.

(Situation) Treatment for discharged persons who have not completed treatment is available for up to 6 months after discharge, but the patient is responsible for the cost of medication

(Improvement) It is recommended that the government prepare a basis for support for pharmaceutical expenses and prepare measures such as securing a budget in order to help the state return to normal as a healthy member of society through medical support for mental and physical disorders that occurred during military service

→ Expected to eliminate the financial burden of approximately 700-800 medications per year

- Expanding health insurance coverage for fertility treatment

(Situation) As the number of infertile couples increases, the number of subfertility treatments, including in vitro procedures, is also increasing. Currently, only a total of 22 cycles (including 9 fresh cycles, 7 freezing cycles and 5 artificial insemination cycles) are covered.

(Improvement) It is recommended to actively consider expanding health insurance coverage for subfertility treatment to expand the scope of support and remove barriers to treatment methods.

→ Expect more support for increasing birth rates

Second, to address the inconveniences in people's lives, the ACRC recommended incorporating people's opinions into policies to resolve the problems they encounter in their daily lives.

Improving inconveniences in people's lives

- Relocation of utility poles located in the center of the sidewalk

(Situation) Increased traffic inconvenience and risk of safety accidents due to utility poles located in the exact center of the sidewalk due to road expansion, etc.

(Improvement) After consultation with relevant administrative agencies, it is recommended that relocation work of utility poles be carried out quickly

→ Relieve traffic inconveniences and prevent safety accidents by carrying out relocating the utility poles.

- Improving hygiene in railroad cabins

(Situation) A passenger has developed hives on the skin due to skin contact with the seat on the train. Problems with cleanliness were identified and countermeasures were requested.

(Improvement) It is recommended to strengthen hygiene management inspection standards for railway vehicles and establish management measures.

→ Related agencies have stepped up inspection and cleaning of rail cars, including reducing the frequency of seat contamination inspections from once a year to once a month.

Third, to address unreasonable regulations for the public, the Commission recommended reforming regulations that impact people's daily lives and strengthening the competitiveness of businesses.

Improvement of unreasonable regulations that the public needs

- Revision of laws related to ice import reporting obligations

(Situation) Due to unclear laws, frequent civil complaints are filed regarding sanctions on ice makers imported without notification

(Improvement) A revision of the law was recommended by analyzing cases of sanctions due to omission of import declaration

→ Prevent complaints by proactively improving unclear laws for business

- Ensuring real educational opportunities for students with Tourette's syndrome

(Situation) To prevent students with Tourettes syndrome from dropping out of public education, it is necessary to consider whether they should be included in special education

(Improvement) Recommendation to actively guide parents and teachers to diagnose and evaluate whether students with Tourette syndrome should be included in special education

→ Expecting students with Tourettes syndrome to receive education specific to their disability

2. Prevention and Elimination of Passive Administration

The ACRC investigated re-report of passive administration and recommended that the head of the administrative organization take appropriate measures.

Passive administration is the act of a public official infringing on the rights and interests of the public or causing financial losses to the State through passive work behavior such as omission or negligence of duties.

<Table 6-12> Passive Administration re-report status (as of the end of Dec. 2024)

Classification	No.of report received	Processing status			Under Investigation
		Total	Opinion recommended	Transferred closed	
Re-report of passive administration (enforced on Aug.19, 2021)	18,314	18,297	82	18,215	17

From August 2021 to December 2024, the ACRC has received 18,314 re-reports of passive administration via e-People, conducted investigations to verify the facts and made 82 recommendations to administrative agencies, including requests for reconsideration, and improvements to work methods.

Examples of such recommendations are as follows: recommending to repair and take systematic management measures for the overpass along the elementary school commuting route that had been left disrepair for a long time; recommending to make emergency repair and take responsible management to solve delayed measures for reports of manholes collapse and road damage; recommending to take active corrective action against the local governments that ignore the interpretation of the MOLIT on the exemption of fines for not having compulsory insurance for vehicles stored in junkyards and arbitrarily perform their tasks; and improving the problem of cars and two-wheeled vehicles passing on roads designated as the 'car-free streets'.

To prevent and eliminate passive administration, the ACRC plans to provide advice, counseling, and training to each administrative agencies in a more systematic way, in addition to recommending appropriate measures for passive administration reports.



Part
07

Institutional Improvement to
Address the Underlying
Factors for Corruption and
Public Inconveniences



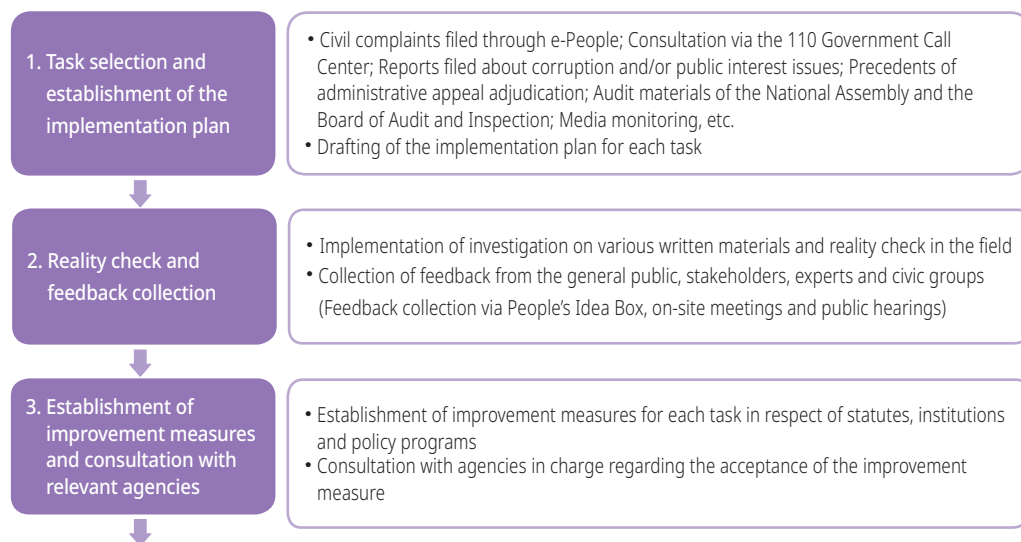
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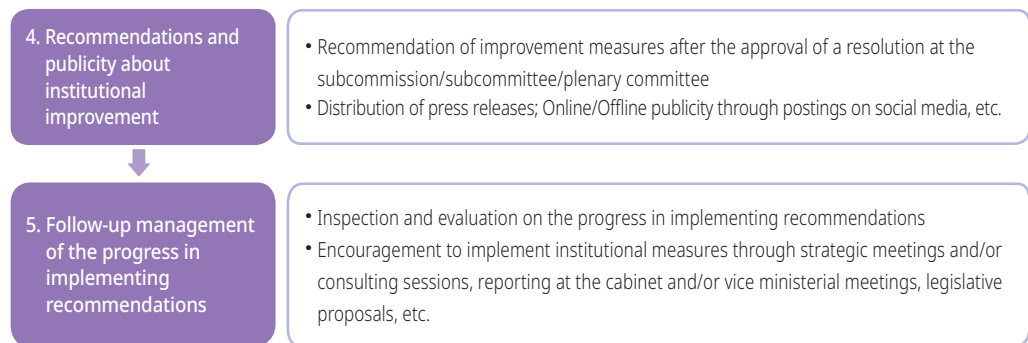
Task Overview and Major Achievements of Institutional Improvement

As a pivotal agency overseeing various policy communication channels such as e-People, the 110 Government Call Center, and People's Idea Box -the digital citizen participation platform, the ACRC is committed to addressing public inconvenience and structural causes of corruption at their root to prevent the recurrence of similar issues by analyzing corruption causing factors and people's opinions received through various channels and identifying problems in institutions and policies in need of improvement.

The ACRC is promoting institutional improvements to prevent corruption and resolve people's grievances, pursuant to Articles 12, 27, and 47 of the ACRC Act (hereinafter referred to as the 'Act').

<Table 7-1> Workflow of Institutional Improvement





1. Institutional Improvements in Corruption-prone Areas to Eradicate Chronic and Systemic Corruption

In 2024, the ACRC selected public integrity and fair society as priority areas for anti-corruption and recommended improvements to 4 related legal and institutional deficiencies.

The ACRC recommended measures to enhance transparency in treasury management at public institutions, strengthening the foundation for financial integrity. It also proposed ways to prevent missed disciplinary actions for sexual misconduct and drunk driving in local public institutions, and to improve fairness in the disciplinary reduction system, promoting more reasonable and fair personnel practices in the public sector.

The ACRC also issued a recommendation to improve fairness in the administration of the national qualification exam system, establishing an institutional foundation to support the government's policy goal of reforming unfair special provisions in national exams. In doing so, the ACRC provided policy support to help the government fulfill its public commitments.

2. Institutional Improvements to Resolve Public Grievances

The ACRC analyzes recurring civil complaints and policy proposals to identify any underlying issues in laws or systems. Through thorough investigations, the ACRC works to develop reasonable improvement measures that address the root causes of public grievances and inconvenience.

In 2024, the ACRC adopted and recommended a total of 29 institutional improvement measures to address public grievances. The Commission developed reform plans targeting key social issues such as the low birthrate and illegal ticket scalping in the cultural and sports sectors, as well as closing safety blind spots that pose risks to the public. Additionally, the ACRC made efforts to enhance the rights and interests of citizens—particularly through measures supporting vulnerable groups and young people—at the institutional level.

The ACRC took the lead in institutional reforms that can help address the low birthrate issue, starting from the public sector, by recommending measures such as “Enhancing the Effectiveness of Parental Leave and Childcare Systems for Public Officials” and “Improving Personnel Management to Support Spouses Working in Different Locations.” The Commission also made broad efforts to address diverse public concerns across all sectors by recommending improvements such as “Revising Unreasonable Eligibility Requirements for National Technical Qualifications,” “Promoting Transparency in Local Council Proceedings,” “Preventing Illegal Resale of Performance and Sports Event Tickets,” and “Improving the Process for Transferring Individual Taxi Business Licenses.”

In addition, the ACRC contributed to enhancing public safety by recommending measures such as “Safety Management for Long-Distance Late-Night Intercity Bus Passengers” and “Safety Measures for Users of Suspension Bridges and Other Elevated Walkways.” The Commission also proposed institutional improvements to support young people, including “Reducing Inconvenience in National Qualification Exams for Youth” and “Improving Living Conditions in University Dormitories and Residential Halls.”

3. Strengthening of Follow-up Measures to Materialize the Effect of Institutional Improvements

Since its establishment in 2008, the ACRC has consistently expanded its recommendations for institutional improvements aimed at preventing corruption and resolving public grievances. To ensure that these recommendations are effectively implemented by the relevant agencies and that citizens can experience tangible improvements in daily life, the ACRC systematically manages follow-up measures.

In the first half of 2024, the ACRC inspected the implementation status of institutional improvement recommendations made from 2013 to Feb. 2024 for 1,936 institutions, including central government agencies and local governments.

Based on the results of the inspection, for institutions that faced challenges in implementing the recommended measures and needed further discussion on implementation measures, the ACRC conducted meetings and consultations to form a consensus on the implementation tasks. Furthermore, the Commission encouraged active implementation efforts of the target institutions through institutional evaluation, etc.

Additionally, in the second half of the year, the ACRC conducted on-site implementation inspections on local governments and small public service-related organizations with low implementation rates to encourage implementation and emphasized the importance of implementing the recommendations and sought to generate interest by explaining the objectives behind the recommendations.





Chapter 2.

Improvement Cases in Corruption-Prone Areas

1. Enhancing Fairness in the Administration of the National Qualification Exam System

In September 2021, during the second round of the tax accountant examination—which exempted career civil servants from taking the test—a major incident occurred in which 3,254 out of 3,962 candidates (over 82.1%) received failing scores, resulting in a mass failure.

Currently, among the 176 types of national professional qualifications, 15 allow public officials with certain backgrounds to be exempt from all or part of the first and second exams. For example, public officials of grade 5 or higher, or those who have worked in audit-related roles at the Financial Supervisory Service for over five years, are granted full exemption from the first round of the CPA exam.

According to a 2022 survey conducted by the ACRC, 76% of the general public opposed special exemptions for public officials in professional qualification exams, while 79% of public officials expressed a preference for retaining such exemptions, either in full or in part.

To address the issue of unfair exemptions, the ACRC organized public forums to raise awareness about the need for reform. The Commission recommended that all relevant ministries abolish the exam subject exemption system for public officials across all 15 national professional qualification exams.

The ACRC also recommended excluding individuals who have been dismissed or removed from office through disciplinary action from being eligible for public service experience recognition. Additionally, it called for including offenses such as sexual crimes and hiring irregularities as grounds for exclusion from such recognition.

The relevant ministries that received the recommendation—such as the Ministry of Economy and Finance, the Ministry of Justice, and the Ministry of the Interior and Safety—plan to submit proposed amendments to the National Assembly by June 2025.

The ACRC expects that this institutional reform will help ensure fair opportunities for young people and foster an environment where they can more actively enter professional fields.

2. Measures to Prevent Omission of Disciplinary Actions for Sexual Misconduct and Drunk Driving in Local Public Institutions

With growing public awareness around sexual crimes and drunk driving, there is an increasing demand for ethical standards and integrity among executives and employees of local public institutions, comparable to those required of public officials. However, due to gaps in certain systems, it is necessary to prevent disciplinary actions for such offenses from being overlooked.

In cases of sexual misconduct, the statute of limitations for disciplinary action is often too short, leading to situations where institutions become aware of incidents only after the deadline has passed, making disciplinary action impossible. For local public institutions, however, the relevant laws and guidelines still set the disciplinary limitation period for sexual misconduct at three years.

Unlike public officials, for whom all investigation and audit results from investigative bodies and the Board of Audit and Inspection are reported, local public institutions only receive notifications for cases related to official duties. This creates an ongoing risk that incidents of sexual misconduct or drunk driving may not be identified in a timely manner.



In particular, for drunk driving, the lack of mandatory reporting of investigation results highlights a systemic gap. To address this, institutions need to implement self-monitoring mechanisms such as voluntary reporting systems or verification through driving history certificates. However, these measures are not specified in the relevant guidelines of the Ministry of the Interior and Safety, resulting in only a few institutions applying such practices.

In response, the ACRC recommended that the Ministry of the Interior and Safety amend Article 63-6(5) of the Local Public Enterprises Act, the personnel and organizational operation standards for local public enterprises, and the guidelines for personnel and organizational management of local government-funded institutions, to extend the statute of limitations for disciplinary action on sexual misconduct to 10 years.

The ACRC also recommended amending the Local Public Enterprises Act and related regulations to include sexual misconduct and drunk driving as mandatory notification items in investigation and audit reports concerning employees of local public institutions. Additionally, it advised that the personnel and organizational operation standards for local public enterprises explicitly allow the introduction of a self-monitoring system for drunk driving.

Lastly, the ACRC instructed all metropolitan and basic local governments to ensure that audits of their affiliated local public institutions include mandatory checks on drunk driving by employees and executives as part of the audit items.





Chapter 3.

Improvement Cases in Areas with Frequent Grievances and Complaints

Section 1 Resolving Grievances

1. Improvement of Unreasonable Eligibility Requirements for National Technical Qualifications

Under the National Technical Qualifications Act, a total of 545 national technical qualifications are administered—511 in technical and functional fields and 34 in service fields.

While all other national technical qualification exams allow candidates to apply based solely on work experience, even without a related academic degree, the clinical psychologist qualification was the only one that, without reasonable justification, restricted eligibility to those with a four-year university degree or higher.

In particular, for the Level 2 Clinical Psychologist qualification, only graduates of four-year universities were allowed to apply, regardless of their major. This created an unreasonable situation where individuals who graduated from psychology-related programs at junior colleges, or those with only a high school diploma, were entirely excluded from taking the exam—highlighting the need for improvement.

To address the issue of unreasonable academic discrimination in national technical qualifications, the ACRC recommended that the Ministry of Employment and Labor and the Ministry of Health and Welfare revise the system to allow candidates to take the clinical psychologist qualification exam based on practical work experience alone, regardless of academic background.

This institutional reform is expected to eliminate the long-criticized academic discrimination

within the national technical qualifications system and provide fairer opportunities for young people seeking to take these qualification exams.

2. Measures to Prevent Illegal Resale of Performance and Sports Event Tickets

According to data compiled and released by the Korea Performing Arts Box Office Information System (KOPIS), both the number of annual performances and ticket sales revenue have steadily increased in recent years, indicating continued growth in the performance ticket market.

< Table 7-2 > Annual number of performance and ticket sales revenue (2020~2023)

Category	2020	2021	2022	2023
No. of Performances (performances)	6,248	12,481	17,930	20,404
No. of Showing (times)	56,342	65,946	97,622	116,587
No. of Tickets Booked (tickets)	4,928,351	8,138,901	18,344,627	20,968,889
Sales Revenue (million KRW)	222,641	400,036	1,028,479	1,269,697

However, the growing popularity of cultural and sports events has been accompanied by a rise in illegal ticket resale (commonly known as “scalping”). In response, the Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism—responsible for overseeing the sector—has made efforts to strengthen legal regulations on illegal ticket sales by amending relevant laws.

Although legal amendments have established provisions to prohibit and penalize the illegal resale of tickets obtained using so-called “macros,” the ACRC assessed that relying solely on punishing based on the method of purchase, such as the use of macros, is insufficient to fundamentally resolve the scalping problem.

More specifically, even without using separate programs, the act of “habitually or

commercially reselling tickets at a markup after purchasing them” inherently poses a risk of disrupting the official ticket pricing system. From this perspective, the method of reservation is only a secondary issue. Fundamentally, there is a need to regulate the act of habitual or commercial resale itself, especially when it goes against the intent of event organizers and official ticket vendors.

Second, there have been concerns about the limited effectiveness of the amended law due to the technical difficulty of proving whether macros were used. In a roundtable held by the ACRC in April of this year with ticketing companies and related stakeholders, many industry representatives stated that “it is technically difficult to accurately detect and determine macro usage during the reservation process.” Meanwhile, under current laws such as the Performances Act, a key element defining illegal ticket resale is the “markup transaction,” which is specified as selling a ticket at a price higher than the original purchase price.

However, factors such as complimentary tickets, invitations, credit card discounts, and various other promotions can result in different individuals purchasing tickets at different prices—even outside the official sales channels. As such, the ACRC determined that the legal definition of “markup” in relation to illegal ticket resale also needs to be revised to ensure greater clarity and fairness.

In response, the ACRC recommended that the Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism amend relevant laws, including the Performances Act and the National Sports Promotion Act. The specific institutional improvement measures proposed are as follows.

First, the ACRC recommended expanding the scope of punishable scalping activities. Through amendments to Article 4-2 of the Performances Act and Article 6-2 of the National Sports Promotion Act, any act of reselling performance or sports event tickets at a markup for commercial purposes—regardless of macro use—is now defined as illegal ticket resale subject to penalties.

Second, the ACRC recommended strengthening penalties for those who sell scalped tickets for commercial purposes. Specifically, it advised amending the Performances Act and related laws to ① establish legal grounds for the confiscation and forfeiture of profits



from illegal ticket sales, ② raise the level of criminal penalties, and ③ apply differentiated punishment levels based on the severity of the violation.

Third, the ACRC recommended clarifying the standard for determining illegal ticket resale. While the current law bases the markup on “the price paid by the individual,” the proposed amendments to the Performances Act and related laws would use the “official ticket price” as the new standard. In other words, the ACRC advised revising the law so that any resale above the official ticket price constitutes a markup transaction, regardless of the original purchase price.

The ACRC hopes that this institutional reform recommendation will enable more citizens to enjoy performances and sports events at fair and reasonable prices.

Section 2 Protection of Vulnerable Groups

1. Measures to Strengthen the Effectiveness of Sanctions Against Abuse in Facilities for Persons with Disabilities

Currently, in elderly and child welfare facilities, sanctions for abuse can range from suspension of operations to facility closure depending on the type and severity of the abuse. In contrast, for facilities for persons with disabilities, only an improvement order can be issued for a first offense—regardless of the nature or severity of the abuse—and facility closure is only specified in cases of sexual crimes as a first violation.

As a result, identical acts of abuse have led to inconsistent administrative sanctions depending on whether they occurred in facilities for the elderly or children versus facilities for persons with disabilities—creating an unreasonable disparity in outcomes.

According to a fact-finding survey by the ACRC, out of 109 administrative sanctions issued over the past five years for abuse in facilities for persons with disabilities, 99 cases—or 90.8%—were limited to improvement orders.



Although local governments hold comprehensive oversight authority over facilities for persons with disabilities, only seven of them were found to request personnel actions against perpetrators of abuse and follow up on the outcomes. It indicates that post-management and supervision of individuals responsible for abuse are not being properly enforced.

In addition, under the Act on Welfare of Persons with Disabilities, individuals convicted of abusing persons with disabilities are restricted from working in facilities related to persons with disabilities, the elderly, or children. However, while the Welfare of the Aged Act was amended in 2023 to expand the scope of elderly-related facilities, similar updates have not been reflected in the Act on Welfare of Persons with Disabilities, creating blind spots in the list of institutions where employment restrictions for disability abuse offenders should apply.

In response, the ACRC recommended that the Ministry of Health and Welfare establish detailed administrative sanction standards that reflect the type and severity of abuse against persons with disabilities, require local governments to verify the personnel actions taken against perpetrators when abuse occurs within facilities, and expand the list of institutions subject to employment restrictions for disability abuse offenders by reflecting amendments to the Welfare of the Aged Act in the Act on Welfare of Persons with Disabilities.

2. Improvement of Unfair Practices in the Production and Distribution of Educational Materials for the Visually Impaired

Textbooks used by visually impaired students are produced and distributed in braille and large-print formats by the National Institute of Special Education, an affiliate of the Ministry of Education. When schools request the production of educational materials for visually impaired students, the Institute obtains general-use textbook files from publishers and converts them into braille or large-print versions.

According to an investigation by the ACRC, while a Korean Standards has already been established for submitting textbook files for visually impaired students, publishers are not obligated to follow it. As a result, they often provide files in inconsistent formats, creating significant challenges for the National Institute of Special Education, which must then reprocess the files to convert them into braille or large-print textbooks.



In addition, only 26.6% of the thousands of available textbooks are produced in formats for the visually impaired, making it difficult to promptly meet new demands that arise during the school term. For example, if a visually impaired student transfers to a school that does not have accessible textbooks, or if a student suddenly becomes visually impaired due to illness or an accident, they may have to attend classes without textbooks. This is because, for textbooks not already available in accessible formats, it takes at least two weeks to produce the necessary materials.

In response, the ACRC recommended that the Ministry of Education clearly establish and provide national-level standard guidelines for the production of educational material files for the visually impaired. It also advised that textbook publishers be required to strictly follow these guidelines when creating and submitting accessible learning material files.

The ACRC also recommended that the Ministry of Education and the Korea Educational Broadcasting System (EBS) produce accessible files for all educational materials, including textbooks, to ensure a swift response to sudden demands. It further advised that these materials be made publicly available for use by visually impaired students and their guardians.

It is expected that this institutional improvement will meaningfully guarantee the right to education for visually impaired students, creating conditions that enable them to compete and live independently on equal footing with non-disabled individuals.



Section 3 Enhancing Public Safety

1. Safety Measures for Long-Distance Late-Night Intercity Bus Passengers

With the recent increase in international travel and recovery of the tourism industry, more passengers are taking long-distance express and intercity buses during late-night hours. However, during the night (10:00 p.m. to 4:00 a.m.), a single driver is solely responsible for passenger safety. Traveling for long hours in a confined space at night raises the risk of incidents such as sexual harassment or violence, and traffic accidents during these hours can be even more dangerous. Nevertheless, current safety measures remain the same as those for buses operating during daytime hours. To address concerns about potential incidents and ensure a swift response, the ACRC pursued institutional improvements.

First, the ACRC aimed to strengthen inspection and management of safety risks on late-night intercity buses. This included clarifying existing regulations on prohibited items inside buses and ensuring that passengers are informed of these rules before boarding. Additionally, onboard announcements were updated to include messages on preventing sexual harassment and violence.

The ACRC also recommended the installation of protective driver partitions in express and intercity buses to safeguard drivers from unexpected incidents. Additionally, it called for the establishment of performance standards and evaluation methods to support the adoption and expansion of advanced safety devices for secure bus operation.

Next, the ACRC aimed to establish a rapid response system in the event of incidents or accidents. Emergency bells were installed at every seat to enable victims of sexual harassment or other crimes to alert the driver or fellow passengers. Additionally, the government was advised to standardize specifications such as the installation locations and resolution of onboard CCTVs, which had previously varied by operator, to minimize blind spots—even in buses operating with interior lights turned off.



In addition, the ACRC proposed introducing vehicle telematics-based emergency rescue services on late-night buses. This includes linking real-time incident data to emergency response systems such as 112 and 119 in the event of a critical situation, helping to prevent secondary accidents.

2. Measures to Strengthen the Prevention of Dresser Tip-Over Accidents

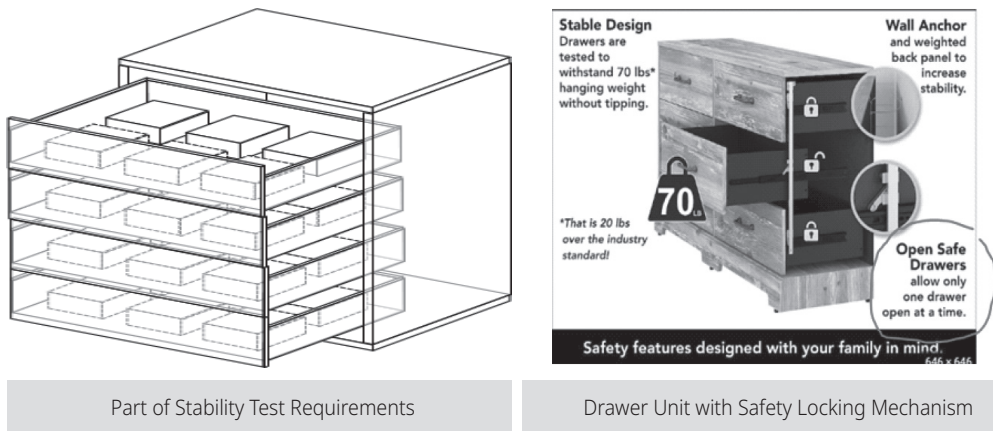
From 2020 to 2023, a total of 105 furniture tip-over accidents were reported to hospitals and fire departments. Among 83 cases where the victim's age was confirmed, 33 incidents (40%) involved infants and young children aged six or under. The ACRC, in collaboration with the Korea Consumer Agency, analyzed the status of reported tip-over accidents and initiated institutional reforms to strengthen the safety of chests of drawers, where child-related accidents are particularly frequent.

Regulations for drawer safety are divided into two categories based on height. Chests of drawers that are 76.2 cm or taller are subject to KC certification and must undergo a stability (tip-over prevention) test under the Supplier's Conformity Verification Standards. In contrast, those shorter than 76.2 cm fall under general safety compliance, where manufacturers voluntarily follow safety standards, and no formal stability testing is required.

The ACRC, referencing international practices such as those in the United States, recommended that the Korean Agency for Technology and Standards lower the current 76.2 cm threshold for stability testing to include more chests of drawers under mandatory safety inspections. The Commission also advised strengthening warning labels by emphasizing tip-over risks in handling instructions and clearly stating the obligation to provide wall-anchoring devices. Additionally, it recommended that even drawer units designed to prevent all drawers from opening simultaneously unless anchored to the wall should still undergo stability testing before being sold to consumers.



○ [Figure 7-1] Example of Drawer Units with Safety Locking Mechanisms



Part of Stability Test Requirements

Drawer Unit with Safety Locking Mechanism

Section 4 Addressing Low Birthrate

1. Enhancement of the Effective of Parental Leave and Childcare Systems for Public Officials

According to a survey conducted in January 2024 through the People's Idea Box, the highest priority task identified was providing preferential personnel treatment for public officials returning to work after taking parental leave. In response, the ACRC developed improvement measures to address excessive personnel and welfare disparities faced by public officials on parental leave or engaged in childcare, and recommended these measures to the relevant ministries.

First, in the area of promotion and performance evaluation, the ACRC recommended providing incentives such as assigning a performance grade equal to or higher than the employee's previous rating upon return from parental leave.

The ACRC also proposed that employees eligible for promotion before taking leave remain under consideration during their leave period and that additional points be granted for having multiple children. Furthermore, it suggested including the full duration of parental leave in the calculation of work experience and transfer restriction periods to prevent any personnel-related disadvantages.

In the financial sector, the ACRC recommended a realistic increase in allowances provided during parental leave and improvements to the salary structure based on leave duration to reduce the economic burden on employees. It also advised clarifying the conditions for deferring health insurance contributions and specifying the criteria for restricting performance-based bonus payments.

In the welfare sector, the ACRC recommended redesigning the eligibility criteria for public official rental housing by reserving a certain quota for those with shorter public service experience who are engaged in childcare. It also proposed extending the maximum tenancy period to 10 years. To further ease the financial burden of housing, the Commission suggested measures such as lowering loan interest rates, offering interest-free loans, and raising the loan limit to 100 million KRW.

In terms of childcare support, the ACRC recommended easing the substitute personnel deployment threshold from the current six months to three months, and proposed actively utilizing mid- to lower-level staff and retirees who can be immediately deployed on-site. It also advised strengthening pre-leave guidance on welfare procedures, prioritizing assignment to preferred departments upon return, and improving the overall reinstatement and transfer environment for employees with childcare responsibilities. Additionally, the Commission suggested extending the period for using parental time and securing designated parking spaces for caregivers to foster a family-friendly childcare and work environment.

2. Measures to Improve Inconveniences in the Infertility Support System

South Korea's total fertility rate in 2023 fell to the 0.7 range, signaling a deepening low birthrate crisis. To strengthen support for couples struggling with infertility who wish to have children, the ACRC collected public feedback on the inconveniences of the infertility support system through People's Idea Box in October and developed a corresponding institutional improvement plan.



Both the central and local governments operate infertility treatment support programs. The central government has reduced the out-of-pocket cost for infertility procedures to 30% through National Health Insurance coverage, while local governments provide subsidies of up to 1.1 million KRW per procedure to ease the financial burden on infertile couples. To receive both benefits, applicants must first obtain an Infertility Support Decision Notice from a public health center before visiting a hospital for each treatment session. Infertile couples faced inconvenience in having to repeatedly obtain an Infertility Support Decision Notice from the public health center each time they underwent a procedure. Additionally, complaints were raised about cases where individuals, due to work or other commitments, were unable to collect the notice beforehand and proceeded with hospital treatment—resulting in the loss of eligibility for financial support and requiring them to pay the full cost out of pocket.

In response, the ACRC recommended that a single Infertility Support Decision Notice be made valid for multiple infertility procedures, reducing unnecessary time burdens on couples and administrative workload on public health centers. The Commission also advised allowing couples to receive infertility treatment first and apply for the notice within a specified period afterward, ensuring they remain eligible for financial support.

A public proposal was submitted noting that even married individuals are unable to freeze their own eggs or sperm for future use without obtaining written consent from their spouse. In response, the ACRC recommended revising the Bioethics and Safety Act to allow exceptions so that married individuals can freeze their eggs or sperm without spousal consent.

Lastly, the ACRC proposed that long-term policies be developed to provide broader support throughout the entire process of infertility prevention and treatment. To help young people—whether single or newly married—prevent infertility through early health management and better plan for future pregnancy and childbirth, the ACRC recommended including fertility testing as an optional item in the national health screening program.



Section 5 Support for Youth

1. Measures to Improve Inconveniences for Youth and Others Taking National Qualification Exams

National qualifications managed and operated by the government are categorized into two types: national technical qualifications, which cover industrial technology, skills, and service sectors, and statutory qualifications governed by individual laws for specialized fields.

According to a fact-finding investigation by the ACRC, 15 national qualification exams imposed age restrictions—such as 18 or 19 years and older—without reasonable justification. Among these, six exams, including the driver's license and youth counselor qualifications, had legal provisions stating both “ineligible for qualification” and “ineligible to take the exam.” However, for nine exams, including those for security instructors and sports instructors, the law only specified “ineligible for qualification,” yet exam eligibility was also arbitrarily restricted—barring applicants from taking the test without legal grounds.

There have been ongoing complaints that age restrictions on national qualification exams limit economic participation opportunities for young people—particularly vocational high school students preparing for employment. Many argued that even if younger individuals are allowed to take the exam, the legislative intent behind age restrictions can still be met by maintaining age limits only at the final stage of certificate issuance. Therefore, prohibiting exam participation solely based on age is viewed by many as excessive.

In response, the ACRC recommended amending laws to lower or remove the age requirements for six qualifications where age restrictions are currently imposed based on legal provisions. For the remaining nine qualifications where age restrictions are enforced without legal grounds, the ACRC advised that the age requirements be abolished altogether.

In addition, individuals who fall under legal disqualification categories—such as minors or those who have lost eligibility—are prohibited from obtaining national qualifications.



However, because each qualification exam uses a different reference point (e.g., exam date, certificate issuance date) to determine disqualification, there were inconsistencies in whether individual applicants could sit for the exam. To address this, the ACRC recommended standardizing the disqualification assessment point to a later stage, such as the exam date or the certificate issuance date.

Meanwhile, for 42 national qualifications—including veterinary technicians and certified loss adjuster—the ACRC proposed that relevant authorities address regional imbalances in test site locations, as written exams are currently held only in specific areas such as the Seoul metropolitan region.

2. Enhancing Residential Quality in University Dormitories and Housing Facilities

Since the 2000s, the declining birthrate has led to a decrease in the school-age population. Coupled with a rise in single-child households, where privacy is more highly valued, there has been growing dissatisfaction among the younger generation regarding shared university dormitories and aging dormitory facilities.

However, universities have made limited efforts to improve conditions in aging dormitories—such as multi-occupancy rooms—citing constraints such as insufficient funding and a lack of available construction space on campus.

In response, the ACRC gathered opinions through a People's Idea Box survey of 1,772 respondents and roundtable discussions with dormitory student representatives and officials from eight major universities in the Seoul metropolitan area, and formulated improvement measures accordingly.

The recommendation includes a total of 10 detailed action items. To promote a user-centered approach by reflecting the proportion of private living spaces as an evaluation metric, the ACRC proposed ① Introducing a new indicator in university evaluations to assess efforts to expand independent living spaces and improve residential conditions in aging dormitories, ② Adding a “private living space ratio” as a criterion in the support

principles for national university dormitories, and ③ Including the “private living space ratio” in the evaluation criteria for funding support to private university dormitories.

The ACRC then recommended measures to promote mixed-use dormitories and the utilization of nearby private land, such as ④ Constructing mixed-use dormitories by integrating them with aging lecture or research buildings on campus, ⑤ Establishing a legal basis to allow public funding from local governments to be used for building such facilities on campus, ⑥ Developing plans to supply “Happy Housing” dormitories for university students as part of urban renewal projects—including mandatory prior consultation with local universities and adjustments to allocation ratios, ⑦ Exploring ways to utilize nearby private properties (e.g., one-room apartments, villas) for dormitory construction, and ⑧ Providing education to young people on how to prevent rental fraud in the housing market.

Additionally, to secure funding for the repair and remodeling of aging dormitories, the ACRC proposed the following to relevant authorities: ⑨ Expanding the allowable uses of university development funds to include “dormitory environment improvement and expansion of single-occupancy rooms,” and ⑩ Amending related laws to enable funding for the maintenance and repair of outdated dormitory facilities.

The ACRC expects that, under this set of proposals, combining private living spaces with shared areas such as common rooms within multi-occupancy dormitories will lead to greater residential satisfaction among the younger generation.

3. Measures to Reduce the Burden of Issuing Electronic Certificates at Universities

Since the COVID-19 pandemic, it has become common for companies to handle document submissions for hiring and other purposes remotely. University students and job seekers are frequently required to submit various academic certificates—such as certificates of enrollment or graduation—in electronic format for external programs, scholarships, or job applications. As a result, students often need to obtain multiple copies of electronic certificates, leading to a significant financial burden. This issue was raised by the ACRC’s 2030 Advisory Panel* as part of a proposal for youth-focused institutional improvements.

* The 2030 Advisory Panel is operated by the ACRC to incorporate the voices of young people into policies on

rights protection and anti-corruption. It consists of 20 members in their 20s and 30s, including university students, office workers, and individuals from various professional backgrounds.

According to the ACRC's fact-finding survey, students typically pay around 3,000 KRW per copy (mode value) to a certificate issuance agency contracted by their university when requesting electronic certificates. Unlike paper certificates, electronic certificates must include the name of the recipient company or institution at the top, requiring students to issue separate certificates for each submission. Considering that job seekers often apply to multiple companies, the financial burden was found to be significant. In addition, the validity period of electronic certificates is typically limited to around three months, forcing students to reissue certificates quarterly for external activities or job applications. This was especially inconvenient in the case of graduation certificates, where the likelihood of any change in status after issuance is extremely low, making a strict validity period largely unnecessary.

In response, the ACRC recommended the following measures to reduce the cost burden on students: ① Allow electronic certificates to be issued with only the submission purpose indicated (e.g., "for company submission"), without requiring the specific name of the receiving company or institution, and ② Extend the validity period of electronic certificates, thereby gradually lowering the frequency—and associated cost—of reissuance for students.

Section 6 SME support

Improvement of On-site Inspection Systems to Address Grievances of Small Construction Companies

With the construction industry facing continued profitability challenges due to rising raw material and labor costs, the ACRC initiated institutional improvements to help resolve on-site issues experienced by small construction firms.

The first improvement focuses on enhancing the certification process for authorized testing agencies related to building material quality. The ACRC recommended clearly



defining the assessment criteria for independence and impartiality when in-house research centers or similar entities apply to become authorized testing institutions that evaluate building material quality and issue test reports. To prevent undue influence from affiliated companies requesting testing, the Commission also advised establishing clear standards for disqualification during the accreditation review process.

Section 7 Improving Quality of Life

Measures to Alleviate User Inconveniences in the Use of Automated Civil Document Issuance Machines

As the use of automated civil document issuance machines has increased, public demand for an improved user experience during the issuance process has grown. Many complaints focused on expanding the types of documents available, improving accessibility and transportation to machine locations, and addressing the limited functionality of the machines.

The ACRC recommended that the Ministry of the Interior and Safety and 231 public institutions, including local governments, expand the types of documents available through the machines and improve authentication methods by allowing users to verify their identity not only with fingerprints but also via mobile resident registration cards. The ACRC also recommended that newly installed issuance machines be placed in easily accessible locations that can operate for extended hours. Additionally, it advised reducing or waiving service fees.

Improvements in the operation and management of automated civil document issuance machines will help create an environment where the public can conveniently obtain a wider range of documents without being limited by time or location.



